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INSIDE



'Chandrasekaran reappointment sullied image'

MUMBAI

Tata Sons Board's decision to grant N. Chandrasekaran a third term as chairman has sullied the company's reputation, outgoing Tata Trusts board member Darius Khambata has said in a letter to Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata. » PAGE 12



Will reopen Strait if U.S. accepts our demands: Tehran

TEHRAN

Iran on Monday said it was ready to reopen the Strait of Hormuz within two days if Washington agrees to conditions, as U.S. President Donald Trump issued his latest war threat at a rally for midterm elections. Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmaeil Baqaei said the offer to open the energy corridor showed "good faith". » PAGE 14

Truck with 'illicit liquor' runs over M.P. police officer

BHOPAL

An inspector of the Madhya Pradesh Police died after being run over by a truck in Dewas district on Monday after he intercepted the vehicle on suspicion of smuggling illicit liquor. The officer was identified as Dilip Puri, station house officer of Khategaon police station. » PAGE 4

Eight labourers electrocuted in Rajasthan village

JAIPUR

Eight labourers died from electrocution and five were injured when a road construction machine came into contact with an overhead 11-kV high-tension power line in Jhunjhunu district of Rajasthan on Monday. The gravel mixing machine was being used to lay a road with public participation. » PAGE 6

Kumaraswamy dares police to arrest him

BENGALURU

A day after the Bengaluru City Police alleged that the 'sting' video targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah was exchanged at his residence in Delhi, Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy on Monday dared the police to take action against him while refuting the claim. » PAGE 3

Two days of green crackers in Delhi-NCR: SC

- Bursting of firecrackers constitutes a religious practice to celebrate Deepavali, top court says
- Allowing environmental degradation defeats the purpose of festivities, the court observes
- Court acknowledges that festival holds religious and emotional significance for many people

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Terming the bursting of firecrackers during Deepavali a "religious practice", which, if left unregulated, takes a heavy toll on the environment and on public health, the Supreme Court on Monday permitted their conditional use in the Delhi-National Capital Region (NCR) for the festival.

"Bursting of firecrackers, though constitutes a religious practice meant to celebrate the occasion, shall result in severe environmental pollution, especially air and noise, apart from the creation of solid wastes... Amongst human beings, children, disabled and the elderly people constitute the most vulnerable groups," a Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and Prasanna B. Varale observed in an order.

The court permitted the bursting of certified green firecrackers from 6 a.m. to 7 a.m. and 8 p.m. to 10 p.m. on November 7 and 8 in Delhi-NCR.

"There shall not be any bursting of fireworks within a 300-metre radius of hospitals, nursing homes, primary and district health centres, old age homes, and any notified silence zones. These areas will be declared 'no-cracker zones', and shall be marked on the ground and published," the court said in the 23-page order. The same restriction would be applicable to educational institutions.

Cost of celebration

"We are conscious that the celebration of Deepavali has a religious, social, psychological, and emotional connotation amongst people, creating a positive atmosphere of hope, welfare and prosperity. That being said, allowing the environment to degrade, which results in a health hazard to all the living beings, defeats the very purpose of the festivities, and the celebrations would be rendered nugatory," the Bench reasoned.



Deepavali has partaken the character of a national festival, even an international one, regardless of caste, community and religion, the top court said. The festival ushered in joy and prosperity to every individual for centuries. However, even ancient Hindu scriptures, including the *Skandapurana* and the *Padmapurana* referred to the use of only lamps as a ritual during Deepavali.

"With the introduction of gun powder in India a few centuries ago, the celebration underwent a change. This led to the introduction of bursting firecrackers, which have been extensively done for many years," the court noted.

The unregulated use of firecrackers during the Diwali in the modern day had chronically led to a huge spike in the Air Quality Index (AQI) as well as pollution levels, including the release of particulate matter, the court said. In graphic detail, the court explained how microscopic particulate matter enters the usually resilient human body to cause "substantial damage".

The Bench stressed that the right to practice, profess and propagate religion conferred under Article 25 (1) of the Constitution was "certainly subject to public order, morality, health". The right to life under Article 21 included the right to a healthy, safe and pollution-free environment.

"The right of an individual to engage in a particular practice, which may have a religious colour, is only a qualified one and cannot go beyond the Constitutional restrictions," the Supreme Court held.

The State had "utterly failed" in complying with the court's orders, since 2015, to impose restrictions on fireworks, the Bench said. In fact, the situation had not improved even after the resumption of a complete ban on firecrackers. A significant spike in AQI levels was evident on the Dasara festival day and the one following it. The "complete ban" had not only facilitated the illegal sale of firecrackers, but also prevented people from purchasing legitimate green crackers, the court said.

Curbs on sales

In a series of directions, the court ordered that only manufacturers certified by CSIR-NEERI (Council of Scientific and Industrial Research - National Environmental Engineering Research Institute) and PESO (Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation) would be permitted to produce green crackers between November 2 and November 6. The cracker boxes would be sealed and not mixed with any of the unauthorised or conventional firecrackers. There would be no manufacture or sale of firecrackers joined in series ('*ladis*') and garlands. Only firecrackers carrying product-specific QR codes would be allowed to be sold.

Cancelled licences of traders would be restored temporarily from November 4 to November 6.

Manufacturers and traders of firecrackers in Delhi-NCR must furnish a monetary security, which should be a "handsome amount" determined by authorities.

A.P. braces for Cyclone Murasu's landfall



Anchored ashore: Fishermen secure their boats near Ongole in Andhra Pradesh on Monday as Cyclone Murasu moved closer to the coast. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

Nellore Sravani
VIJAYAWADA

The Andhra Pradesh government on Monday sounded alert in five districts – Bapatla, Palnadu, Markapuram, SPSR Nellore, and Prakasam – as the coast braced for the landfall of Cyclone Murasu between Ongole and Nellore.

The severe cyclonic storm is expected to bring very heavy to extremely heavy rainfall to these districts, which reported a rain deficit during the southwest monsoon.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said the weather system is likely to move with wind speeds gusting up to 120 km per hour and cross the coast early on Tuesday. A storm surge is expected in coastal areas to the north of the landfall point, the IMD said.

14 NDRF teams

The National Disaster Response Force (NDRF)'s 10th Battalion has deployed 14 teams across Andhra Pradesh and Telangana to coordinate with local officials and undertake emergency response and rescue operations.

In the wake of the cyclone, heavy rain was reported in the northern districts of Tamil Nadu from Sunday evening, and some parts of north Chennai reported waterlogging. In Odisha, where rain triggered by Cyclone Arnab caused widespread damage, the government evacuated 1.6 lakh people across Ganjam, Gajapati, Malkangiri, Koraput, and Kandhamal districts.

Odisha evacuated 1.6 lakh people from five districts amid Cyclone Arnab-triggered rain

The IMD said the storm was located about 80 km east-northeast of Nellore, 80 km east-southeast of Kavali, 110 km southeast of Ongole, 140 km south of Bapatla, 170 km south-southwest of Machilipatnam, 170 km northeast of Tirupati, and 190 km north-northeast of Nungambakkam in Chennai.

The system is moving towards the coast at 12 kmph, and gales of 70-90 kmph, gusting to 100 kmph, have been reported along the Andhra Pradesh coast.

Even as the weather system moved closer to the coast, there was no major rainfall activity on Monday.

However, northern Andhra, where no alerts were sounded, recorded light to moderate showers. Gales gusting up to 100 km per hour were also reported along and off the coast. The impact of Murasu is expected to be less severe than that of Arnab, a very severe cyclonic storm that recently hit the coast.

IMD, Amaravati, issued a red alert for Palnadu, Tirupati, and Nandyal districts on Tuesday, and an orange alert is in place for 12 districts. As the cyclone's outer bands brushed Tamil Nadu's northern coast, the Regional Meteorological Centre upgraded weather alerts for northern districts such as Chennai and Tiruvallur on Monday. It warned of squally winds, gusting up to 75 kmph, in various northern districts, including Chennai and Kancheepuram till Tuesday morning.

31,000 power poles

With 8,000 electricity poles likely to be affected, 31,000 poles have been dispatched from Srikakulam to Krishna district. In addition, 1,000 personnel are expected to reach from Chennai to assist in power restoration works.

(With inputs from Satyasundar Barik in Bhubaneswar and K. Lakshmi in Chennai)

Grievance redress rules for job scheme drop key provisions

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI



Key clauses dropped include a provision requiring registration of an FIR for *prima facie* proof of financial irregularities.

The Grievance Redressal Rules under the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin), or VB-G RAM G, which were notified by the Union Ministry of Rural Development on Monday, dropped several provisions that had figured in the draft rules circulated in May, some of which were also part of the previous rural employment programme which the current scheme replaced earlier this year.

The new rules allow for complaints to be filed on any matter related to the implementation of the scheme, and for these grievances to be resolved within a period of 15 days.

Key clauses dropped include a provision requiring the registration of a first information report (FIR) for *prima facie* evidence of financial irregularities, and the requirement to place action-taken reports before local body meetings for review and monitoring.

These provisions had been part of the Grievance Redressal Rules under the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), which was replaced by VB-G RAM G earlier this year.

The Ministry has also dropped a proposal for a "designated day" each week for grievance officials to receive complaints.

Under the notified framework, complaints may be submitted in person before the designated Grievance Redressal Officer, through Speed Post, on a digital grievance platform notified by the Centre, or through telephone helplines and other modes specified by State governments.

The rules specify that no grievance can be refused registration on the grounds of format, language, manner of submission, or procedural deficiencies.

The rules state that grievances received in physical form at the Gram Panchayat, Block, or District levels must be entered on the designated digital platform on the same day or by the next working day.

Complainants must receive an acknowledgement containing the registration number, date of receipt, and details of the receiving authority.

As per the rules, grievance officers must examine every complaint, seek records and information from authorities, and may hear complainants before disposal. Inquiries are required to be completed within seven days of receiving the complaint.

Findings and the action taken must be recorded and communicated to complainants. Unresolved grievances must be escalated after 15 days and tracked until disposal.

The rules also provide for appeals under the VB-G RAM G Act, 2025.

INBRIEF



Goa nightclub fire: ₹20 lakh to be paid to kin of 25 victims

The Bombay High Court on Monday directed Saurabh Luthra and Gaurav Luthra to pay interim compensation of ₹20 lakh each to the families of the 25 people who died in a devastating fire last year at Birch by Romeo Lane, a nightclub owned by the siblings. The Goa Bench of Justices Valmiki Menezes and Amit Jamsandekar heard the matter. A massive fire broke out at the nightclub in Arpora village in North Goa on the night of December 6 last year, claiming 25 lives, comprising 20 employees of the establishment and five tourists. Around 50 people were injured in the incident. PTI

8 acquitted in Muzaffarnagar riots case for lack of evidence

A local court on Monday acquitted eight persons in a murder case related to the 2013 Muzaffarnagar riots, citing lack of evidence, a government lawyer said. Additional District and Sessions Judge Anurag Panwar acquitted the accused, observing that the prosecution had failed to prove its case, government counsel Narendra Sharma said. The incident took place on September 8, 2013, in Lank village where 70-year-old Shakuran was killed. Her son, Yusuf Saifi, had lodged a complaint against the nine accused. One of the accused, Deepak, died during the pendency of the trial. PTI

Setback for AAP as 3 party legislators join BJP ahead of Punjab Assembly poll

AAP failed to fulfil promises made in run-up to 2022 election, say leaders after being inducted into BJP; State BJP chief says end of the AAP regime is near while the BJP grows stronger by the day

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Monday suffered a setback ahead of the Punjab Assembly election, due in early 2027, after three of its leaders – Kunwar Vijay Pratap, Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra and Chetan Singh Jauramajra – joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in New Delhi.

Mr. Pathanmajra and Mr. Jauramajra, MLAs from Sanour and Samana constituencies respectively, had resigned from the party's primary membership on Sunday.

They claimed that they were quitting AAP as it had "failed to fulfil the promises" it made ahead of the 2022 Assembly poll.

Mr. Pratap, former Indian Police Service officer, resigned as Amritsar North MLA on Monday morning to join the BJP later in the day. "There is an atmosphere of chaos all around Punjab. Drug abuse has reached alarming levels and a drug empire has been established. Extortion has now become an industry, and gangsterism is also at its peak," Mr. Pratap said after joining the BJP.



Joining hands: Former AAP leaders joining the BJP in the presence of senior leaders in New Delhi on Monday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Mr. Pratap has remained critical of the government's handling of various sensitive issues, including the "sluggish investigation" into alleged incidents of desecration of the Guru Granth Sahib and subsequent police firings at Behbal Kalan in Faridkot district that claimed the lives of two Sikh protesters in 2015.

He has also questioned AAP's touted 'Schools of Eminence'. In 2023, ahead of AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal's visit to inaugurate Punjab's first School of Eminence in Amritsar, Mr. Pratap had pointed out that the school in question had only been "renovated", and that it had been made a smart school by the previous governments.

In June 2025, Mr. Pratap was suspended from the party for five years for indulging in anti-party activities.

AAP leaders joining the BJP clearly indicated the impending end of the party's regime in Punjab, the State BJP president Kewal Singh Dhillon said. He adding that the BJP's "caravan in Punjab" was growing stronger by the day, with the ground reality turning decisively against the ruling party.

ED raid in PMLA case

Meanwhile, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Monday searched the premises of former Punjab Minister and Congress leader Sunder Sham Arora in connection with a money laundering investigation, officials said. The agency searched a total of 14 premises in Hoshiarpur, Chandigarh and Mohali, including the residence of Mr. Arora. Officials said the action is linked to an alleged corruption and possession of disproportionate assets case registered by the Punjab Vigilance Bureau.

'Kashmir issue can only be resolved by dialogue that heals'

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR



PDP president Mehbooba Mufti in Srinagar on Monday. PTI

Asking the Centre "to stop experimenting with J&K", former J&K Chief Minister and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti on Monday said the Kashmir issue "will not be resolved by jailing people under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA) [and the] Public Safety Act (PSA), and [by] terminating [jobs of government] employees (under special provisions, citing security) or jailing people, but by initiating talks to heal the wounds and opening roads".

"The PDP managed to open two roads for trade (with Pakistan Occupied Kashmir) but those stand closed today. If roads with China can be opened in Uttarakhand, why not allow the people of Kashmir to travel to China's Kashgar and Khotan?" Ms. Mufti said at a workers' convention at the Sher-i-Kashmir Park here.

"The Government of India experimented a lot to enforce peace in Kashmir; the baton policy will not work. This silence will not last long. There is a volcano brewing in Kashmir and it can erupt. It will endanger all if not addressed. I warn Delhi about it. This year, the protesters in Delhi tasted what Kashmir has been suffering all these years," Ms. Mufti said.

"Kashmir is a land of *sufis* (mystics), *rishis* and *munis* (saints). Any attempt to maltreat [Kashmir] will have a cost. *Dastaan na rahigi dastanoon mein* (not even a trace of your story will remain in the history books)," the PDP president said, describing Kashmir as the "crown of India".

NC targeted

Ms. Mufti also accused the late National Conference (NC) founder Sheikh Muhammad Abdullah of "sowing seeds of suspicion about Kashmiris".

The PDP leader called for introspection on why Kashmiris' identity needed to be proved even within their own land.

Delhi HC stays JNU order sacking Prof. Akoijam

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Monday stayed Jawaharlal Nehru University's (JNU) October 9 order dismissing Congress MP and professor Angomcha Bimol Akoijam from its services following an inquiry into sexual harassment allegations against him.

Justice Anup Jairam Bhambhani passed the interim order while hearing a petition filed by Mr. Akoijam challenging his dismissal. The court also issued notice to the university and listed the matter for further hearing in January 2027.

At least 11 female students complained against Mr. Akoijam in May this year. The Delhi police has also registered an FIR in connection with the allegations and its investigation is under way. Mr. Akoijam has denied the allegations.

Bribery case: CCB gets 3-day custody of ex-T.N. Minister

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi being produced at a city court.

A special court for Prevention of Corruption Act cases in Chennai on Monday permitted the Central Crime Branch (CCB) of the Greater Chennai Police to take former Tamil Nadu Minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi into custody for three days in a case of alleged bribery.

Mr. Poyyamozhi, who served as School Education Minister in the DMK government of 2021-26, was recently arrested on a complaint by an association of private schools that crores of rupees was collected in bribes for grant of permanent recognition to private schools. He is now lodged in Puzhal Central Prison, Chennai.

The police, who suspect ₹400 crore might have been collected in bribes, sought to keep him in their custody for five days. The court had earlier asked the police to file their response to Mr. Poyyamozhi's bail petition by November 2.

He was brought from the Puzhal prison and produced before special court judge L.S. Sathyamoorthy. The judge permitted the CCB to interrogate him from 1 p.m. on November 2 to 5 p.m. on November 4.

The court will hear his bail petition and plea for the return of certain electronic devices seized by the police on November 5.

Notice to Anant Singh over plea to expel him from Bihar Assembly

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The Bihar Assembly served notice on Mokama MLA Anant Singh on Monday, asking him to respond within a week to the plea by the Janata Dal (United) seeking the revocation of his Assembly membership.

On October 24, following the results of elections to eight State Legislative Council seats, in which Mr. Singh had opposed party's official candidate Neeraj Kumar, the JD(U) expelled the Mokama MLA and his wife, Neelam Devi, for "anti-party activities" for six years. Mr. Kumar went on to win the seat.

Ms. Devi was also removed from the membership of the government's 20-point programme committee, which had given her the status of a Deputy Minister. She was also asked to vacate the official bungalow in Patna. Two days after the election results, the ruling National Democratic Alliance partner had requested the Speaker to rescind the Mokama lawmaker's Assembly membership.



Anant Singh

SC order

On October 30, the Supreme Court directed the expelled MLA to surrender by December 1 in connection with murder of Dular Chand Yadav, for which he was arrested last year.

Mr. Singh said he would comply with the apex court's order.

Alliance partner JD(U) asks BJP to explain 2 Independent MLCs 'joining' party in Bihar

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

On October 31, MLCs Bansidhar Brajwasi and Rahul Raj 'joined' the BJP, but hours later both denied it

Ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) partner Janata Dal (United) [JD(U)] raised questions over two Independent Members of the Legislative Council (MLC) "joining" the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

Bihar JD(U) president Umesh Singh Kushwaha questioned the BJP's decision, asking under what circumstances a leader who was expelled by the party for six years was taken back so soon.

On October 31, MLCs Bansidhar Brajwasi and Rahul Raj "joined" BJP, but hours later both denied and said that they had only offered support to the party.

'NDA identity is unity'

Speaking to the reporters at Patna airport, Mr. Kushwaha said, "Whom the BJP decides to include or remove is its internal matter. However, the decision by the BJP, which had expelled Rahul Raj from the party for six years, to take him back after his election victory raises questions. The BJP and its senior leadership should think over this entire matter. The identity of NDA is unity and alliance partners should keep an eye on it."

In the results declared last week, Mr. Brajwasi defeated JD(U)'s Abhishek Jha from Tirhut Graduates' seat while Mr. Raj defeated JD (U)'s Anand Pushkar from Saran Teachers' seat.

Meanwhile, a Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) delegation met Legislative Council Chairman Ram Bachan Rai to demand the disqualification of the membership of both the independent MLCs for violating the anti-defection law. Prashant Kishor's JSP has bagged one seat out of eight that went to the polls.

JSP leader and former MLA Kishor Kumar Munna said, "In less than 72 hours after winning the election, Rahul Raj and Bansidhar Brajwasi joined the BJP."

'Can be expelled'

He added, "According to the provisions of Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, if an Independent elected member joins a political party after winning an election, their membership can be terminated. In this regard, a delegation met with the chairman and requested to take cognisance of the entire matter."

Akhilesh redraws 'PDA' to woo upper castes; rhetoric may not be enough: analysts

NEWS ANALYSIS

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav's move to expand his 'PDA' (*Pichhda*, Dalit, *Alpsankhyak*) plank to include Brahmins and Baniyas is being viewed by analysts as an attempt to fracture the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)'s core base ahead of the Assembly election.

However, they caution that the party's improved tally in the Legislative Council polls, where it won five of the 11 seats with the BJP bagging the remaining, may not automatically translate into broader electoral gains without a concrete policy road map.

"Brahmin and Baniya communities are core BJP supporters. By claiming injustice to them, the SP is projecting itself as a flagbearer of people and social groups across sections of society and creating a divide in the BJP's social base," said Asad Rizvi, a Lucknow-based political analyst.

Political commentator Umakant Tripathi noted that council polls are often used by specific communities to signal resentment and that sustained campaigning is required to convert any advantage from the MLC polls into gains in the Assembly election.

Himanshu Singh, an independent analyst, added that the SP must move beyond rhetoric and outline specific demands, such as a Brahmin Welfare Board, to capitalise on the sentiment.

Addressing a press conference in Lucknow on October 30, the SP chief said, "The BJP has victimised, oppressed, and humiliated every community, so all the oppressed have come together."



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav has claimed that Brahmins and Baniyas in U.P. are being harassed under the BJP government. FILE PHOTO

'95% with us'

"The PDA support base has now reached 95%, thanks to the Brahmin, business and Kayastha communities voting for us. For the BJP, politics, not community, is paramount. They've resorted to every tactic to defeat their traditional voting communities. The BJP is no one's ally," added the former Chief Minister.

The 'PD' in PDA stands for 'Pandit' while 'A' stands for Agarwals, the trader community, he said.

Mr. Yadav claimed that the Brahmin community is witnessing "systemic harassment" at the ruling coalition's hands and cited the loss of his party's upper-caste candidate, Sanjayan Tripathi, from the Gorakhpur Graduates' seat, alleging that "corrupt BJP members and complicit officials" had conspired to defeat the SP nominee.

He was defeated not merely because he was the SP candidate, but because "*Haata nahi bhaata* [Haata isn't favoured]", the senior Opposition leader said.

Explaining the phrase, SP spokesperson Sunil Singh Yadav 'Sajan' said, "It is well-known that *Haata* refers to the late Hari Shankar Tiwari, a senior Brahmin leader from Gorakhpur who was at odds with Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath."

Akash Agarwal, the SP candidate from the Agra Teachers MLC seat, highlighted his community roots during his campaign while alleging harassment under the Adityanath dispensation. "I am being harassed for being an Agarwal. I cannot continue living in such a Sanatana society. I will embrace Islam or Buddhism," said Mr. Agarwal, who went on to win the seat.

Aside from claiming caste divisions, Mr. Yadav has also tried to portray the CM as someone who prioritises his home turf of Gorakhpur over the party's prospects elsewhere, including Varanasi, from where Prime Minister Narendra Modi is serving his third consecutive term as a Lok Sabha member and where the BJP lost both MLC seats.

BJP's 'united front'

The BJP moved swiftly to project a united front. On October 30, senior BJP leader and Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressed the BJP's State executive meeting and played down reports of internal friction.

He urged party workers to "throw disappointment and resentment into the Gomti river" and work with dedication to form the BJP government while praising the development under Mr. Adityanath's leadership.

Speaking about the SP's outreach to upper caste communities, Mr. Himanshu Singh said, "The SP hasn't spoken about the much-demanded 'Brahmin Welfare Board'. Similarly for the business community, it needs to come up with schemes to address the traders' concerns. Council polls can be used as an opening to make inroads among these sections, but only a clear framework will help capitalise on the sentiment."

₹291-crore aid for flood-hit farmers in Maharashtra

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The Maharashtra government on Monday announced steps to address drought and flood-related agricultural distress across the State. It constituted a high-level panel headed by the Chief Minister to oversee soil and water conservation projects in drought-affected areas and approved ₹291.91 crore in financial assistance for farmers affected by heavy rainfall and flooding between June and August 2026.

Soil and Water Conservation Minister Sanjay Rathod said the committee would monitor conservation projects undertaken as part of drought mitigation efforts.

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INBRIEF



Major fire breaks out at HPCL refinery in Vizag; no casualty

A major fire broke out at Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL) Visakh Refinery late on Monday evening. The sudden explosion and intense flames at the Pitch Tower of the newly integrated Residue Upgradation Facility caused brief panic in the neighbourhood, officials said. Malkapuram Police Inspector E. Narasimha Rao issued a voice message confirming that the situation was under control and that there were no fatalities or injuries reported.

Rubber price touches record ₹300 a kg in domestic market

The price of natural rubber in the domestic market has touched a historic ₹300 per kg, extending a rally that has gathered pace over the past few months. According to the Rubber Board's daily price report, RSS-4 grade ribbed smoked sheet rubber was quoted at ₹300 per kg on Monday. With international rubber prices continuing their upward trajectory, market experts expect the bullish trend to persist in the domestic market in the coming days.

SEC complicit in malpractices during A.P. civic polls: Jagan

YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) president Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy accused the Andhra Pradesh State Election Commission (SEC) of being complicit in the electoral malpractices that took place during the urban local body elections on Sunday. In an X post on Monday, he said the election authorities and police facilitated booth capturing, rigging and intimidation. Despite "overwhelming proof", the SEC ordered repoll in only four booths, ignoring the violations elsewhere, he said.

Sting video: Kumaraswamy dares police to take action

Union Minister says Police Commissioner acting at behest of CM, questions objectivity of probe; Kumaraswamy accuses Shivakumar of conspiring to distribute 'sleaze' videos of Prajwal Revanna

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A day after the Bengaluru City Police alleged that the 'sting' video targeting former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah was exchanged at his residence in Delhi, Union Minister H.D. Kumaraswamy on Monday dared the police to take action against him while refuting the claim.

At a press conference, turning the tables on Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar, Mr. Kumaraswamy accused him of having met and conspired with the accused to distribute "sleaze" videos of former Hassan MP Prajwal Revanna. Accusing Bengaluru Police Commissioner Seemanth Kumar Singh of acting on the instructions of the Chief Minister, he told media persons, "Many people visit my residence, and there is no restriction on visitors. I do not know whom the Police Commissioner is referring to."


H.D. Kumaraswamy

He dared the police to summon him for investigation and said that "nobody has the guts" to touch him.

He said there was a suspicion that the investigation was not being conducted objectively.

"The woman victim had complained to the Karnataka State Commission for Protection of Child Rights. The complaint was not acted upon then. People behind the sting went to Kerala with the mala fide intention of meeting the woman for the interview," he added.

"There is information that the woman who had made accusations against the former Chief Minister has changed her statement. If this is true, why is she not being presented before the court? If she has changed her statement, she is part of the conspiracy. She too must be named as an accused," he said.

Hours before Mr. Kumaraswamy's press conference, in which he claimed that no action had been taken against the perpetrators of the sting video, the Central Crime Branch (CCB) of the Bengaluru Police searched the residence and office of Power TV managing director Rakesh Shetty.

The searches were carried out by multiple teams of investigators after obtaining a search warrant from a court.


Percussion instrument 'Murasu' displayed at the Thol Isai Kalanjiyam Museum in Chennai. FILE PHOTO

How 'Murasu' became the first Tamil name for a tropical cyclone

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

A name rooted in Tamil's cultural past is now travelling far and wide. As a severe cyclonic storm advances towards the Indian coast, 'Murasu', a Tamil name suggested by the Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC), has found a place in the region's meteorological history.

'Murasu' is a traditional Tamil percussion instrument. The name was chosen from the second list of names for tropical cyclones over the north Indian Ocean that was prepared by the World Meteorological Organisation (WMO) panel.

S. Balachandran, former Additional Director-General of Meteorology, who was heading the RMC when the names were proposed, said that 'Murasu' was the first Tamil name to be assigned to a tropical cyclone since the naming of cyclones over the north Indian Ocean began in September 2004.

"The name 'Murasu' was proposed because the instrument was used to disseminate information during the ancient period, and to alert the people to natural disasters. It also denoted a thunderous sound," he said.

Mr. Balachandran recalled that, after the names in the first list were exhausted, the Regional Specialised Meteorological Centre for Tropical Cyclones over North Indian Ocean, New Delhi, sought a new list of names from all the coastal States in 2020.

Gati and Tej

Meteorologists said 'Murasu' was the third name, after 'Gati' and 'Tej', to be featured in the list of 13 names suggested by India to the WMO and the United Nations Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific panel.

N. Puviarasan, Head, Meteorological Centre, Bengaluru, who was then posted at the RMC, Chennai, recalled that it had given names including 'Thirukai', 'Kalappai', 'Yer', and 'Naavai', related to ocean, fishing, and agriculture. But these did not make it to the list.

The names had to meet several criteria, including ease of pronunciation, a maximum length of eight letters, and neutrality.

Keralam shifts 35 IAS officers in major rejig

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam government has transferred 35 IAS officers in yet another major bureaucratic reshuffle.

K.R. Jyothilal, who was serving as Additional Chief Secretary of Finance, Taxes, and Public Procurement Advisory departments; and as Chief Executive Officer of the Rebuild Kerala Initiative in Planning and Economic Affairs department, has been posted as Additional Chief Secretary of the Home and Vigilance departments.

Puneet Kumar, who was serving as Resident Commissioner of Kerala House in New Delhi and Additional Chief Secretary of the Water Resources department (matters connected with inter-State water), has been posted as Additional Chief Secretary of the Power department. He will continue as Resident Commissioner of Kerala House in New Delhi.

POCSO case: doctor gets 20-year jail term

The Hindu Bureau
KANNUR

A 78-year-old paediatrician and former superintendent of the Kasaragod District Hospital, Dr. P. Krishnan, has been sentenced to a total of 47 years of rigorous imprisonment for sexually assaulting a 15-year-old girl who had visited his clinic for treatment.

Judge P.M. Suresh of the Hosdurg Fast Track Special Court pronounced the sentence after finding the doctor guilty under various sections of the Indian Penal Code and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

However, as the sentences are to run concurrently, Dr. Krishnan will have to serve 20 years in prison, the prosecution said.

The court also imposed a total fine of ₹1.25 lakh on him. In default of payment, he will have to undergo an additional 18 months of imprisonment.

Chargesheet filed against YouTuber in obscene content case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Ernakulam Rural Cyber Police in Keralam have filed a chargesheet before the Chief Judicial Magistrate Court against YouTuber Mohammad Nihad, popularly known as *Thoppi*, in a case related to the alleged online publication of obscene content.

The case was registered on the night of June 20, 2026, by the Cyber Police under various provisions of the Information Technology Act and other relevant laws for allegedly publishing obscene material through online platforms. According to the police, Mr. Nihad had shared nude images of some of his former friends on social media following a falling-out with them. Investigators maintained that the charges against the accused were legally sustainable. Throughout the controversy, however, *Thoppi* has maintained that he had been "betrayed" by his former friends.

The case stemmed from a complaint filed by lawyer Sreejith Perumana, who sought an investigation into a series of allegations exchanged among members of the YouTuber's former group after they parted ways earlier this year over disputes related to revenue sharing and live-streaming activities.

Following the complaint, the State Police Chief ordered a probe into allegations that included sexual abuse of minors, drug use and obscenity.

Mr. Nihad later obtained anticipatory bail from the Kerala High Court.

Fading light


Storm-stuck stock: With Deepavali just around the corner, potters handle traditional lamps and other earthenware in NTR district of Andhra Pradesh. Persistent rain following back-to-back cyclones Arnab and Murasu has delayed the drying and sale of the lamps, substantially reducing the craftsmens' expected earnings this festive season. G.N. RAO

Several A.P. youth 'tricked' into joining Russian military

V. Kamalakara Rao
VISAKHAPATNAM

IT Minister Nara Lokesh urges the authorities to ensure their safe and speedy return to India

A youth from Visakhapatnam, who went to Russia in search of a job, has allegedly been forced into the Russian armed forces.

Jetti Vamsi travelled to Russia in July with four others after paying ₹3.60 lakh to a Chodavaram-based agent for jobs. In Russia, he was left stranded after his recruitment agent allegedly abandoned him. Later, an agent of Nepalese origin reportedly lured him into joining the Russian military by promising a job in food packaging and military logistics.

According to his family, the five youths were assured safe, non-combat assignments, and they were allegedly made to sign service contracts written entirely in Russian.

Instead of the promised jobs, the youths were reportedly deployed near the Ukraine border and forced to dig defence trenches, construct bunkers and undertake other high-risk assignments.

In a video sent to his mother, Jetti Appalakonda, Mr. Vamsi said, of the five men, only friend Satheesh and he were traceable.

Appealing to the State government, Ms. Appalakonda, on Monday, sought the intervention of Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu, Deputy Chief Minister K. Pawan Kalyan and Minister Nara Lokesh to secure her son's return.

A police complaint has been registered in connection with the case. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Duvvada Circle Inspector N. Ganesh said that the police had begun an inquiry following directions from higher authorities.

In a post on X, Mr. Lokesh urged authorities to ensure the youths' safe and speedy return to India.

Fisherman in distress rescued 100 km off Mangaluru coast

The Hindu Bureau
MANGALURU

The Indian Coast Guard, District Headquarter 3, Mangaluru, safely evacuated a fisherman in urgent need of medical attention from a fishing vessel sailing about 100 km off Mangaluru coast on Sunday night.

The headquarters received a distress call over VHF from Indian Fishing Boat (IFB) *Shiv Sagar*, operating approximately 54 nautical miles (100 km) off Mangaluru on Sunday.

It was told that a fisherman had fallen overboard while hauling fishing nets. He was rescued, but required urgent medical attention and shifting to a hospital.

The headquarters deployed Indian Coast Guard Ship *C-448*, which located the fishing boat amid the darkness of the night. The disoriented fisherman, identified as Komara Ramu, was then safely evacuated, provided immediate first aid, and transferred to the New Mangalore Port Authority jetty. He was subsequently shifted to the nearest hospital for further medical management.

IFB Shiv Sagar had sailed out of Old Mangaluru Port three days ago, the Coast Guard informed.


Indian Coast Guard Ship *C-448* reaches fishing boat *Shiv Sagar*, about 100 km off Mangaluru coast, to rescue a fisherman in urgent need of medical attention on Sunday night. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Principal shunted out over 'misconduct'; Keralam school students go on a protest

The Hindu Bureau
KOZHIKODE

A section of students in Plus One and Plus Two classes at the Government Higher Secondary School, Meenangadi, Wayanad, on Monday staged a protest seeking revocation of the recent transfer of their Principal Shivi Krishnan. The Higher Education department took action against him claiming that official guidelines were not followed during a study tour undertaken by the students last week.

According to reports, the sequence of events began after over 130 students went on the tour in separate buses to Hyderabad. While returning, a section of students alleged that Hajis Ulladan, the PTA president, had consumed alcohol.


Action was taken against him allegedly for not following guidelines during a study tour.

Videos of the PTA president in an "intoxicated condition" were subsequently sent to the parents through social media.

Rumours spread that Mr. Krishnan too was drunk. When the students reached the school, a group of angry parents and some political activists blocked him at the gate.

Police personnel were subsequently called in, who escorted Mr. Krishnan to safety.

However, lab results of his blood samples revealed no trace of alcohol.

The students who were part of the tour also came in his support, saying Mr. Krishnan had not consumed liquor and that Mr. Ulladan had been shifted to another vehicle when the complaint arose.

'Political reasons'

Meanwhile, the Regional Deputy Director of Education conducted an inquiry into the episode and found out that the school authorities had not sought permission to conduct the tour. Also, a three-day tour was reportedly extended to five days.

Mr. Krishnan was subsequently transferred to Government Higher Secondary School, Vaduvanchal.

Officials of the school management committee told the media on Monday that Mr. Krishnan had been framed in the episode for political reasons.

He is a leader of the pro-Left Kerala School Teachers' Association. The officials also said that though the school authorities had sought the mandatory permission from the higher authorities, there was no response to it.

Mr. Ulladan also claimed that he had not consumed alcohol and there was no demand to test his blood samples earlier.

Poll authorities can't monopolise voter awareness, says SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

SC set aside an order passed by Rajasthan SEC refusing civil society permission to reach out to voters

The Supreme Court made it clear on Monday that electoral authorities neither hold a monopoly over voter awareness campaigns nor can they assume political partisanship on the part of activists engaged with local communities to promote electoral participation.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant set aside an order passed by the Rajasthan State Election Commission (SEC) refusing civil society groups permission to reach out to voters ahead of panchayat elections in the State.

The SEC voiced suspicions that activists were acting "on the behest of someone else". The counsel said the SEC was already doing voter awareness campaigns on its own.

"Your conducting it does not mean no other authority can do voter awareness campaigns. In case they [civil society groups] are doing any corrupt practices, you can regulate. But you cannot monopolise the voter awareness exercises," Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the three-judge Bench, observed.

Appearing for petitioner-activists like Aruna Roy, advocate Prashant Bhushan submitted that the initiative on the part of the civil society groups was undertaken in sheer public interest, only to be faced with prohibitive orders.

"We are not more than 20 people. They should not be imposing Section 163 ahead of elections unless there is breach of peace. But this is a blanket ban on us when all we do is tell voters to not take bribes... We tell them that they should participate in the Panchayat Raj elections in a fair manner," Mr. Bhushan had submitted.

Clean energy softened global crisis impact on India: Modi

At the Renewable Energy Summit and Expo, PM warns that excess dependence on fossil fuels could risk exposure to global disruptions; he emphasises need for solutions to spur solar adoption

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

The impact of the West Asia crisis on India would have been more severe than the rest of the world had the country not made investments in renewable energy over the last decade, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said at the inauguration of the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit & Expo (2026) in New Delhi on Monday.

"Had India not made the investments it did in clean energy and building the requisite mechanisms [and infrastructure], the impact of the crisis would have been far more severe than in the rest of the world," Mr. Modi said in his address. He also said that India's economy continued to grow despite the crisis.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacts with participants at the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit and Expo 2026 in New Delhi. ANI

Renewable energy pitch
The Prime Minister put forth that the West Asia crisis exemplified how energy security was directly tied to economic security, adding that the future of energy security rested in clean energy.

He warned that excess dependence on fossil fuels could risk increased exposure to global disruptions.

Mr. Modi also said that India's renewable energy sector would have investment opportunities of about $220 billion by the end of the decade.

In his pitch to potential investors, Mr. Modi held that it would be difficult to find the scale, scope and demand that India has in any other part of the world, alongside political and policy stability.

Solar revolution
Mr. Modi emphasised that the next phase of solar revolution would rest on innovation.

He pointed to opportunities in the realm of indigenous manufacturing of essential hardware and battery storage systems, as well as in enhancing storage capacities.

Explaining his vision, the Prime Minister said, "We must carve out a dynamic where the country's middle class has the option of an electric vehicle, and where they would be able to charge their scooty, bike, or car with solar-based energy. This would help save them a lot of money."

He said the country would also require solutions that would help spur solar adoption in the dairy sector, animal husbandry, and farming.

"We must not stop here; we must connect every government building, school, college, hospital, and the entire street lighting network to solar energy and at a rapid pace," he said.

The Prime Minister further suggested that there must exist healthy competition among States and local bodies about their performance in renewable energy adoption.

Defence Ministry signs ₹53,866-cr. deal for corvettes

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

In a first, indigenous warships will be constructed by Defence Public Sector Undertakings

The Defence Ministry on Monday signed contracts worth ₹53,866.50 crore with Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) and Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL) for the construction of eight Next Generation Corvettes (NGCs) for the Indian Navy, in a major boost to indigenous warship building capabilities.

According to the Defence Ministry, under the contracts, the GRSE will construct five corvettes, while the GSL will build the remaining three.

The project marks a significant milestone as it is the first time that warships indigenously designed by the Indian Navy will be constructed by Defence Public Sector Undertakings (DPSUs), the Ministry said.

The NGCs will be equipped with advanced missiles, weapons, and sensor suites, enabling the Navy to undertake operations across the air, surface and sub-surface domains. The induction of these warships is expected to significantly enhance the Navy's capabilities in anti-surface and anti-submarine warfare, coastal defence, littoral combat, and maritime surveillance.

Boost for self-reliance
The project is expected to provide a major boost to the domestic defence manufacturing ecosystem by involving DPSUs, private shipyards, Indian industrial partners, and micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).

The Ministry further said that the programme is expected to generate around 72 lakh person-days of employment in the shipyards and another 460 lakh person-days in ancillary industries and MSMEs over the next 10 years.

Village guard, wife die of bullet wounds in Jammu

The Hindu Bureau
SRINAGAR

A Village Defence Guard (VDG) and his wife died of bullet wounds in Jammu's Reasi district on Monday. The victims were identified as Javed Ahmed, a resident of Brailkund, Manjikote, Bagodass, and his wife Shaheen Akhter.

Initial reports suggested the bullets had been fired from the type of service weapon provided to VDGs, who are civilians armed to defend villages against terrorists. The police have not provided details on the incident. This is the third such incident in the past two years in the Jammu region.

Meanwhile, an Army porter was injured after accidentally stepping on an anti-personnel mine near the Line of Control in Rajouri district.

Top NC leaders reach out to disgruntled lawmakers

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Facing a political upheaval, the ruling National Conference (NC) in Jammu and Kashmir has gone into firefighting mode and fanned out top leaders to reach out to around 20 legislators who raised the banner of dissension over the party functioning and certain leaders close to Chief Minister Omar Abdullah.

The disgruntled legislators put forth 10-point demands to "restructure the party".

Top sources in the party said NC general secretary Ali Muhammad Sagar, his son Salman Sagar and NC MP Shami Oberoi held talks, in the past 24 hours, with several dissident NC leaders who met at the residence of NC lawmaker Qaiser Jamsheed Lone in Srinagar on October 27.


Omar Abdullah

Senior NC leaders confirmed to *The Hindu* that the NC reach out to placate the legislators. One dissident leader, however, said the NC had to bring reforms within and end coterie culture to address the unrest.

Change in tone
Meanwhile, several NC legislators who attended the meeting changed their tone towards the party leadership. "It is unfortunate that some people have tried to give a different colour and meaning to the gathering at one of our colleague's residence the other day. I had not gone there with the intention to ditch my leader or my party. We are what we are because of the NC, and our fidelity to the party goes far beyond posts and positions," said NC leader Hilal Lone, pledging loyalty to the party.

Pledging loyalty to the party, Mr. Lone said, "I am, like my father, loyal to the party and to my leader, Omar Abdullah *sahab*. If we have any concerns, we will place them before our leader once he returns from Delhi. Those who are trying to give a different interpretation to our gathering, whether acting at the behest of the Opposition or driven by their own vested interests, are only trying to create unnecessary confusion," said Mr. Lone, who represents the Sonawari constituency.

Govt. plans foreigners' registration offices in all State capitals by 2027

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Union government plans to establish Foreigners Regional Registration Offices (FRROs) in all State capitals by 2027, the Ministry of Home Affairs said on Monday. Since 2025, five new FRROs have been established, including two this year. The move is part of a wider effort to strengthen the institutional framework for managing foreign nationals visiting India.

The decision follows directions from Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who has asked authorities to expand the FRRO network amid a rise in the number of foreigners arriving in India for tourism, medical treatment, and education. The Ministry said the expansion is intended to improve access to immigration services, strengthen regulatory compliance,



The Ministry said the expansion is intended to improve access to immigration services.

and support India's efforts to attract international visitors. Since 2025, FRROs have been opened in Jaipur, Chandigarh, and Guwahati, bringing regions previously administered by the Delhi, Amritsar and Kolkata FRROs under local jurisdiction.

This year, two more FRROs have become operational in Aizawl in Mizoram and Amravati in Andhra Pradesh. Before their establishment, Aizawl fell under the Kolkata FRRO and Amravati under Hyderabad.

The government has also recently notified new FRROs in Kohima, Agartala and Bhubaneswar. Kohima and Agartala were earlier under the Kolkata FRRO and Bhubaneswar was under Hyderabad.

With these additions, the number of FRROs in the country has risen to 20. The offices are located in Ahmedabad, Amravati, Amritsar, Aizawl, Agartala, Bengaluru, Bhubaneswar, Calicut, Chennai, Cochin, Chandigarh, Delhi, Guwahati, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Kohima, Kozhikode, Lucknow, Mumbai, and Thiruvananthapuram.

"The government is also pursuing the establishment of FRROs in the remaining States that do not yet have one, including Bihar, Goa, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Arunachal Pradesh, Manipur, and Meghalaya," the Ministry said.

Officials said the expanded network would enable foreign nationals to access services such as visa extensions and conversions, immigration compliance support and legal clearances closer to their place of stay.

The move is also expected to improve coordination between Central and State authorities while strengthening the enforcement of immigration laws.

The expansion comes in the wake of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, which consolidated four earlier laws dealing with immigration and foreign nationals into a single statutory framework governing the entry, stay, movement, and exit of foreigners in India.

Three BSF personnel and a civilian injured in clash in Tripura

Syed Sajjad Ali
AGARTALA

The clash occurred during road blockade by locals protesting against detention and assault of a youth

Tensions ran high in the bordering areas under the Kalamchoura police station in Sonamura subdivision of Tripura's Sepahijala district, following a clash between Border Security Force (BSF) personnel and local residents on Monday. Three BSF personnel and a local youth were injured. The police are probing the incident.

Three BSF personnel, including an officer, were receiving treatment at a government hospital in Agartala, the police said. The injured youth, who has a leg fracture, has also been admitted to the hospital.

The clash occurred during a road blockade at the Ashabari locality by locals protesting against the detention and assault of a youth. Many women also joined the protest.

An officer and personnel who arrived at the scene in a vehicle ended up in a heated brawl with the protesters leading the clash. The crowds also chased the BSF men when they attempted to retreat.

The police confirmed three BSF personnel and a local youth had received multiple injuries. The injured were later shifted to the Tripura Medical College and BRAM Hospital in the outskirts of Agartala city.

The BSF has not made an official statement. A security contingent comprising armed police and Tripura State Rifles personnel has been deployed at the scene. The deployment of security forces helped restore normalcy, reports said.

Truck carrying 'illicit liquor' runs over M.P. police officer

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

An inspector of the Madhya Pradesh Police died after being run over by a truck in Dewas district in the early hours of Monday after he intercepted the vehicle on suspicion of smuggling illicit liquor. The officer was identified as Dilip Puri, station house officer of Khategaon police station.

An investigation launched following the incident has uncovered an illicit trade network spanning multiple districts of Madhya Pradesh that supplies liquor to Gujarat.

According to the police, the incident took place around 1.30 a.m. on the Indore-Betul highway when Mr. Puri was leading one of the four teams formed based on intelligence inputs that large amounts of illicit liquor was being transported from Harda district's Timarni to Gujarat.

During the checking, a parked truck was spotted near Sandalpur in Dewas district and Mr. Puri asked the driver to step down for a search.


Dilip Puri

"The driver, however, with the intent of killing Dilip Puri, ran him over with the truck and fled the scene. Mr. Puri died during treatment. The driver also tried to run over constable Sohan Jaat, who has suffered injuries," a police statement said.

The driver abandoned the truck after some distance and fled the scene. Dewas Superintendent of Police Aditya Mishra said the truck was seized and more than 1,800 litres of illicit liquor in about 200 cartons was recovered from it. Special Director-General (DG) of Police Upendra Jain, who has been deputed by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav to oversee the probe, told *The Hindu* that the driver had been identified as Gajendra Rawat, alias Akku, a resident of Alirajpur district, and a search is on for him.

Mr. Jain said the police had identified several people involved in the illicit liquor network.

They are Patendra Jaiswal, a resident of Badwani district who owns a government-licensed liquor shop in Harda; his business partners Manish Jaiswal of Indore, Mohin Jaiswal of Gujarat, and Rahul Jaiswal of Timarni in Harda district; and Vijay Rao of Indore, an associate of Mr. Rahul.

Mr. Rahul and Mr. Rao have been taken into custody. The officer said Mr. Rahul ran the liquor network. According to the police, Mr. Rahul is a Congress functionary.

Survivors describe attacks on Christian gatherings in Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

A number of Christian gatherings and prayer meetings have faced brutal attacks by mobs in West Bengal over the last few months, according to more than a dozen survivors of violence who narrated their experiences before a People's Tribunal on Christian Persecution in West Bengal on Monday.

Most of those who spoke said that the perpetrators of the violence had not been arrested. A number of them claimed that the police attitude to such violence had changed after the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) came to power.

The tribunal, held at Kolkata's Muslim Institute, was organised by the Karwan-e-Mohabbat, Sabar Institute, and Aamra Ek Sachetan Prayas.

A woman from Keshpur in Paschim Medinipur district said that her house was attacked by a mob of 80 to 100 people while a prayer meeting was being held on October 2. The woman said that she had been disrobed and beaten up by a few people from the mob.

"While they were leaving, they raised slogans and said that the place had become free of Christians," said the woman, who did not wish to be named.

Anup Kumar Ghosh, a priest at a church in Midnapore town, was arrested by the police after a mob attacked a church on July 3, when he was holding a feast after a marriage ceremony. "I was booked under several sections, including charges of attempted murder," the priest said.

U.S.-based research project, India Hate Lab, has documented at least 60 incidents of hate crimes against Christians in Bengal between May 13 and September 20 this year.

Ajit Doval holds security talks during Vietnam visit

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval on Monday held discussions with Vietnam's Deputy Prime Minister and Defence Minister, General Phan Van Giang, in Hanoi, reviewing the progress of bilateral defence cooperation.

The meeting was part of Mr. Doval's two-day official visit to Vietnam, aimed at strengthening the India-Vietnam Enhanced Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

The Embassy of India in Vietnam, in a post on X, said the two leaders reviewed ongoing defence cooperation and explored ways to expand engagement.

Mr. Doval arrived in Hanoi on Sunday and is scheduled to interact with senior Vietnamese leadership to discuss cooperation in security, defence and strategic affairs.

Rahul challenges PM to debate on 'foreign help'

Congress leader alleges that Modi remains PM owing to 'foreign help'; his remark comes after the latter targeted the Opposition, and alleged that obstructionist forces were trying to divide India

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Monday challenged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to an open debate, alleging that it was with "foreign help" that Mr. Modi became Prime Minister and continues to occupy the position.

The Congress leader's challenge came after the Prime Minister had accused the Opposition of taking foreign help to destabilise the country.

"Mr. Modi, stop lying to this nation. You became PM because of foreign help. You remain PM because of foreign help. Your financial system is fully controlled and supported by foreigners. Foreign social media fully backs you," the senior Congress leader alleged in a post on X.

> Mr. Modi, stop lying to this nation. You became PM because of foreign help. You remain PM because of foreign help. Your financial system is fully controlled and supported by foreigners. Foreign social media fully backs you
>
> **RAHUL GANDHI**
> Congress leader



"I challenge you to an open debate about this. Any stage, any time. Come if you have the guts. You won't dare, because you are terrified of what I know about you," he added.

He also shared a screenshot of a media report on the Prime Minister's allegation that obstructionist forces were trying to divide the country and that social media was being used to spread rumours.

"When the country was seeking solutions to external challenges, some forces within the country were also creating instability by spreading lies and rumours. But the countrymen stood shoulder to shoulder with the nation," Mr. Modi had said on Saturday in Gujarat.

'Standing as obstacles'

"It is our misfortune that at this time in the country, the Opposition has turned into an *avrodh paksh* (destructive force) rather than *virodh paksh* (opposing side). In their frustration, these people are standing as obstacles in the way of the country's development. This is not opposition; this is obstruction," the Prime Minister had said, adding that "these people were engaged in shredding the boundaries of the Constitution".

'Recognise patterns'

Mr. Modi also took a dig at the Opposition leader's trips abroad without directly naming him.

"Due to the frustration of more than a decade, these people have now come out in the open. Who is secretly meeting whom abroad? Whom are the anti-India forces supporting? Who is speaking the language of India's enemies? We will have to recognise all these patterns," the Prime Minister had said.

Shah slams Congress, says SIR helped govt. identify 3 crore 'illegal infiltrators'

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday alleged that three crore "unaccounted voters" were among the 13 crore names removed from electoral rolls during the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise. Describing such voters as "illegal infiltrators from Bangladesh", he asserted that they would be expelled from the country.

Addressing a public meeting in Hyderabad's Old City after a 'Save democracy-Remove anarchy' foot march, Mr. Shah claimed that of the nearly 13 crore names deleted from voter lists during the SIR process, 4.25 crore were registered in two different locations, three crore were deceased, and another one crore were duplicate entries. He questioned if such names should continue to remain on the electoral rolls. "Do we need to remove infiltrators from the country's voter lists or not," he asked.



Counter attack: Union Home Minister Amit Shah addresses a public meeting in Hyderabad on Monday. G. RAMAKRISHNA

Rahul flayed

The Home Minister accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of defending the alleged three crore "unaccounted" voters. "No matter how hard Rahul Gandhi or [Telangana] Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy may try, the BJP is committed to driving every infiltrator out of the country," he said.

Mr. Shah alleged that the Congress and other Opposition parties were opposing the SIR exercise to protect "infiltrators from Bangladesh", whom he described as their "vote bank".

Ridiculing Sunday's rally of Opposition parties in New Delhi, Mr. Shah described it as a "save infiltrators" rally and urged BJP workers to counter "fear-mongering" by the parties on the SIR through a door-to-door campaign.

Cong. seeks JPC probe into sale of IDBI Bank

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI:

The Congress on Monday demanded an immediate halt to the proposed sale of IDBI Bank to Canada's Fairfax Financial Holdings and a Joint Parliamentary Committee probe into the transaction, alleging that the government had manipulated the bank's valuation.

The party alleged that the foreign buyer would use the bank's own funds to finance the acquisition.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh separately described the transaction as a "major scam" by the Narendra Modi government and demanded that both valuation reports be made public.

Senior Congress leader Shaktisinh Gohil alleged that the disinvestment process was riddled with irregularities and lacked transparency.

The Congress also raised concerns over the valuation of IDBI Bank's real estate assets.

ECI to enable tribunal judges to e-sign orders

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) is likely to revise the ECINet portal software to enable judges of Appellate Tribunals in West Bengal to e-sign and upload orders instead of Aadhaar-based authentication, the norm till now.

There are more than 38 lakh voters whose cases are stuck in the 19 Appellate Tribunals in the State.

The ECI's move comes after tribunal judges had said that the commission's requirement for Aadhaar authentication on its portal hindered the issuance of final orders, official sources said.

The Appellate Tribunals were formed on directions of the Supreme Court. Judicial officers, drawn from a list the Calcutta High Court had sent to the top court, are adjudicating roughly 60 lakh "doubtful and pending" cases.

Congress reviews preparedness for Uttarakhand and Manipur elections

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after the INDIA bloc rally here against alleged vote *chori* (theft), the Congress leadership on Monday held separate meetings with party leaders from Uttarakhand and Manipur to review the political situation and organisational preparedness for the Assembly election due early next year.



Congress leaders Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and K.C. Venugopal with leaders from Manipur unit on Monday. PTI

Senior party leader Rahul Gandhi and general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal attended the meeting chaired by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge at his official residence here.

The discussions focused on the performance of the BJP government in the two States, the continuing ethnic violence in Manipur, and the party's electoral strategy. Following the meeting with Congress leaders from Uttarakhand, Mr. Kharge accused the BJP's "double engine" government of betraying the hopes and aspirations of the people over its 10 years in power in the State.

Citing a deteriorating law and order situation, concerns over women's safety, and the BJP government's failure to ensure accountability, the Congress chief said people were now seeking change.

"The Congress is fighting with full vigour for the rights and entitlements of the people, from the streets to the legislature," Mr. Kharge said on X.

Unemployment, examination paper leaks, and the handling of the Ankita Bhandari murder case had particularly affected young people and women, Mr. Venugopal alleged. He also accused the BJP government of facilitating land deals in favour of corporate enterprises despite environmental concerns.

Uttarakhand Congress chief Ganesh Godiyal, the Leader of the Opposition in the State Pritam Singh, and senior leader Harak Singh Rawat were present at the meeting. Party veteran and former Chief Minister Harish Rawat, whose personal yatra across Uttarakhand had riled a section of the party's State unit, was not present. The State leadership also met Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra.

Peace for Manipur

At the meeting with leaders from Manipur, the continuing ethnic violence and the failure to restore lasting peace and normalcy figured prominently.

The party also discussed its organisational preparedness and strategy for the Assembly elections, Congress Legislature Party leader Keisham Meghachandra said, adding that the people of Manipur deserved peace, security, stability and accountable governance.

"In 2027, the people will unseat the BJP and ensure a thumping majority for the Congress that will bring back a people's regime in these States," Mr. Venugopal said.

Citing GST revenue decline, DMK president says T.N. is 'doomed' under TVK govt.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

DMK president M.K. Stalin on Monday said the people should brace for difficult times as "Tamil Nadu is doomed" under the TVK government.

In a social media post, he said the growth in Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue had fallen below the national average under the TVK government. He also alleged that Korean investments worth ₹1,614 crore had been lost to Andhra Pradesh owing to the State government's indifference.

"Guidance Tamil Nadu, which attracted investments, has been sacrificed because of the ego of individuals. One should learn from this government how to shift to reverse gear. But the Chief Minister [C. Joseph Vijay], who could not understand any of this, has gone to campaign for the byelections," he said.



M.K. Stalin

EPS flags inflation

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami expressed concern over the reported 3% growth in GST collections last month, which was much below the national average.

In a social media post, Mr. Palaniswami referred to the State's level of inflation, which was higher than the all-India figure, and the "diversion" of industrial projects to other States, similar to what was shown in a feature film starring Mr. Vijay. "How would the GST collections go up unless industry achieves progress, which would, in turn, generate jobs, enable higher growth, and raise per capita income?" Mr. Palaniswami wondered.

Recalling that Guidance Tamil Nadu, the nodal agency for investment promotion and single-window facilitation, was established when Jayalalithaa was Chief Minister, the AIADMK leader accused the TVK-led government of having "ruined" it.

Former BJP leader and founder of 'We The Leaders' movement, K. Annamalai, said Tamil Nadu's GST collections over the past six months had raised serious questions about the State's economy.

No relief from SC for former T.N. Minister in cash-for-jobs case

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to intervene against a Madras High Court order giving the green signal to the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) to register an FIR and investigate allegations of a multi-crore cash-for-jobs scam involving former Tamil Nadu Minister K.N. Nehru of the DMK.

A Bench said a thorough investigation was necessary as Mr. Nehru was heading the Ministry under the scanner for involvement in the alleged recruitment irregularities. The Bench, however, said he was entitled to raise all points in his defence and in accordance with law during future proceedings before the court.

The High Court had earlier refused the Minister's plea to re-consider its February 20 order directing the DVAC to register the FIR. In October last year, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) had shared a dossier with the Tamil Nadu Police, levelling the cash-for-jobs allegation in the Municipal Administration and Water Supply (MAWS) Department led by Mr. Nehru.



K.N. Nehru

The ED had come across the incriminating materials in 2025 while conducting a search-and-seizure operation, in connection with a bank fraud case, on the premises associated with Mr. Nehru's brother N. Ravichandran.

SC disposes of petitions in temple donation theft case after SIT files chargesheet

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday closed multiple pleas seeking Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into the Ram Temple donations' embezzlement case after the State of Uttar Pradesh informed it that a chargesheet has already been filed by its Special Investigation Team (SIT).

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India bowed out of any further judicial scrutiny even as Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta submitted that the misappropriations had occurred during the counting of the money, which was allegedly invested in property by the accused persons.

In its order, the apex court allowed petitioners, which include Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Case Trust, Ajay Kumar Rai, Narendra Kumar Goswami and Sudhakar Singh, among others, to assist the trial court in further proceedings.



The SC allowed petitioners to assist the trial court in further proceedings. FILE PHOTO

The Bench reasoned that they could assist in the capacity of "victims of crime" as the case involved issues of public interest.

'Assisting the court'

"Courts have allowed victims of crimes to assist, similarly you also assist the court... If there is an element of public interest involved, law enables victims to assist the court," Chief Justice Kant told the petitioners.

Besides a common plea for a CBI probe, the petitioners had variously sought the immediate preservation of evidence, records, CCTV footage, and digital logs relating to donations and offerings at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Mandir. They had also sought an independent forensic audit of donations, offerings, and valuable items received by the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust from its inception till date.

The petitioners wanted the court to constitute or direct constitution of an expert committee to frame a 'National Minimum Temple Donation Transparency Framework' for public temples and religious endowments of national importance and temples receiving substantial annual donations.

Arunachal Pradesh and Assam hold talks over boundary issues

Press Trust of India
ITANAGAR

Assam and Arunachal Pradesh share an 804.1 km-long border, parts of which are disputed

The governments of Arunachal Pradesh and Assam held a regional committee meeting on Monday to deliberate on longstanding inter-State boundary issues, officials said.

The talks centred on the dispute between Lower Dibang Valley district of Arunachal Pradesh and the adjoining Tinsukia district of Assam. The meeting, co-chaired by Arunachal Pradesh Regional Committee chairman Ojing Tasing and his Assam counterpart Atul Bora, was held in Roing in Arunachal Pradesh's Lower Dibang Valley district, officials said.

Both Mr. Tasing and Mr. Bora are Ministers in their respective States. Several officials and other Ministers attended the meeting. The two sides reaffirmed their commitment to an amicable and mutually acceptable resolution through dialogue and consensus, officials said.

Later taking to X, Mr. Tasing said the deliberations focused on addressing outstanding boundary-related differences while safeguarding the legitimate rights, interests and aspirations of communities residing in the adjoining areas of the two States.

The discussions underscored the importance of constructive engagement, mutual understanding and consensus in resolving the longstanding boundary issues, while ensuring that the interests of people on both sides are duly protected, he said. The two States share an 804.1 km-long boundray, parts of which are disputed.

'Dissent must be respected, it provides direction'

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday said in a democracy, differences in opinions and perspectives are natural and there can be both agreement and disagreement.

Dissent must also be respected, he said while addressing the inaugural session of the 'Janpratinidhi Sammelan (Public Representatives' Conference)' organised under the 'Samvidhan Pakhwada (Constitution Fortnight)' by the Haryana Legislative Assembly in Panchkula.

"Dissent provides direction, offers a vision and inspires people to work. Despite differences of opinion, everyone must make collective efforts to take the country and the State forward," he said. He added that running the government was a responsibility, but public service was an even greater responsibility.

INBRIEF



HC extends stay on Imran Khan's 'Leave India Notice'

The Bombay High Court on Monday extended the suspension of a 'Leave India Notice' issued to actor Imran Khan, a U.S. citizen holding an Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) card, while directing him to tender an unconditional apology and submit an undertaking that he would not participate in future protests. The court allowed him to continue residing in India pending a decision by immigration authorities. The Foreigners Regional Registration Office had directed Mr. Khan to leave India by October 28.

Kuno cheetah was killed by hunters, not traders, says STF

The special task force (STF), formed to probe the killing of a male cheetah cub outside Madhya Pradesh's Kuno National Park (KNP), said on Monday that no organised wildlife crime or illegal wildlife trade syndicate was involved. It added that the two people arrested in the case for killing the animal were motivated by recreational hunting. The 19-month-old cub, KNG22, was found with five gunshot injuries in Sheopur forest division on October 25.

Govt. can intervene in airfares in 'extraordinary situations'

Rules under Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024 notified; airlines must publish tariffs on their websites or other DGCA-specified digital platforms to improve public awareness and transparency

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

The Union government can now issue written directions to airlines on airfares in the public interest during "extraordinary situations", say new rules framed under the Bharatiya Vayuyan Adhiniyam, 2024, and notified on the e-Gazette website on October 31.

Though the rules do not define "extraordinary situations", the government had intervened in airfares before. It imposed fare bands during the COVID-19 pandemic, and after IndiGo's operational meltdown last December, when nearly 5,000 flights were cancelled.

It had also informally urged airlines to restrain fares during the Kumbh Mela, and in the aftermath of the Pahalgam attacks and natural disasters, including the Kerala floods, following complaints of price gouging. The new rules provide a regulatory framework for such interventions.



The Centre had imposed fare bands during COVID-19 and IndiGo's operational crisis, and urged restraint during disasters. FILE PHOTO

The move follows a public interest litigation filed by social activist S. Laxminarayan, seeking binding regulatory norms to curb arbitrary airfare pricing and ancillary charges levied by private airlines during festive periods, holidays, and emergencies.

The rules also provide for closer fare monitoring. Airlines must submit their tariffs to the Director-General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) in the form, manner and at intervals specified.

They must also publish tariffs on their websites or other DGCA-specified digital platforms to improve public awareness and transparency.

Fares displayed on booking websites and tickets must show the total amount payable, along with a detailed breakdown of the base fare, taxes, fees, cancellation charges, refund conditions, and other applicable costs.

No fare caps

Airlines were already required to submit fare data to the DGCA and publish it on their websites under Air Transport Circular 2 of 2010, issued on November 19, 2010. These requirements have now been incorporated into the rules.

By providing for price monitoring in normal circumstances and refraining from imposing fare caps, the government has stuck to its position that airfares are market-driven and are not subject to direct regulation, following the repeal of the Air Corporations Act in March 1994. It has often maintained that ticket prices can change dynamically in response to demand and supply, as well as factors such as seat occupancy, fuel costs, aircraft capacity, and seasonal trends.

Delhi gets Stage 2 curbs as air quality slips to 'very poor'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As the air quality in the national capital deteriorated to the "very poor" category for the first time this winter, the Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and adjoining areas (CAQM) on Monday announced Stage 2 of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP).

The air quality is likely to remain in the "very poor" category for the next three days, says the Central government's Air Quality Early Warning System for Delhi. The last time Delhi's air quality was in this category was on February 11 this year.

Under Stage 2 of the GRAP, the NCR State governments are mandated to enhance vehicle parking fees to discourage use of private vehicles. The GNCTD (Delhi government) and NCR State governments also have "to stagger timings for public offices and municipal bodies in the National Capital Territory of Delhi and the districts of Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddha Nagar".

Considering the restrictions on vehicles, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has decided to run additional trips on weekdays. "This is to encourage people to use public transport rather than their private vehicles and help mitigate pollution," said a senior Metro official.

The GRAP is a set of short-term emergency measures to reduce air pollution and is divided into four stages. The CAQM announces the different stages depending on the level of pollution.

The 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) of Delhi stood at 324 (very poor) at 4 p.m. on Monday, up from 261 (poor) a day earlier, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB)'s daily bulletin.

"Very poor" air quality could lead to "respiratory illness on prolonged exposure", says the CPCB.

Court orders time-bound funds, rehabilitation for rescued bonded labourers

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Observing that the state's constitutional obligation towards bonded labourers does not end with their release, the Supreme Court on Monday asked the Centre to lay down a uniform procedure requiring financial assistance to be disbursed within seven days of release. The court asked the Centre to consider revising the existing rehabilitation scheme within three months to increase financial assistance and provide "subsistence support" when disbursements are delayed.

A Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Aparesh Kumar Singh issued a slew of directions while hearing two petitions, including one filed by a bonded labour survivor, highlighting delays in financial assistance and institutional shortcomings in the identification and rehabilitation of those rescued. The Bench said eradication of



bonded labour was a "continuing obligation", requiring authorities to ensure that those freed were meaningfully rehabilitated.

"The constitutional prohibition against bonded labour and the statutory measures enacted to enforce it cannot remain mere assurances on paper. The release of a bonded labourer cannot be treated as the completion of the State's obligation when the conditions necessary for a life of dignity remain unfulfilled. Identification, release and rehabilitation must therefore be understood as interconnected stages of a continuing constitutional responsibility," the Bench said.

Revised SOP

Taking note of the Union government's submission that a revised standard operating procedure (SOP) for dealing with cases of bonded labour was formulated on May 14, the Bench directed all States and Union Territories to implement it within six months. The Centre was asked to issue supplementary guidelines, in consultation with the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), within three months.

The Bench said the stipulated procedure should provide for complaints of bonded labour to be verified ordinarily within 24 hours, followed by prompt rescue wherever required. Once a person is identified as a bonded labourer, the competent authority must conduct the necessary inquiry and ordinarily issue a release certificate within 24 hours.

Six NCP leaders meet Shah, express discontent with party's functioning

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

In a core committee meeting of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) that Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar called on Monday evening, senior leaders are learnt to have expressed discontent about the style of the party's internal functioning. The meeting lasted three hours and will be followed by a meeting of all elected legislators of the party on Tuesday.

On Sunday night, six senior NCP leaders had met Union Home Minister Amit Shah and is learnt to have informed him about their unhappiness with the party's functioning under the leadership Sunetra Pawar, who is the national president of the NCP, and her son, Parth Pawar.

The leaders who met Mr. Shah are Praful Patel, Sunil Tatkare, Chhagan Bhujbal, Dhananjay Munde, Hasan Mushrif, and Dilip Walse Patil, a source said. They were given an appointment to meet the BJP leader without Sunetra Pawar and Parth Pawar. "There was no discussion about a merger [of the NCP with the Nationalist Congress Party-Sharadchandra Pawar (NCP-SP)]. A merger with NCP-SP is not in the picture. What happened during the delimitation Bill debate is behind us. The meeting with Mr. Shah was specifically about the issues in the NCP. [Regarding] the way the party is being run in an authoritarian manner at present, hampering the party's strength," an NCP source aware of the discussion during the closed-door meeting with Mr. Shah told *The Hindu* on Monday.



Six leaders from the NCP Ajit Pawar faction meet Union Home Minister Amit Shah in Delhi on Monday. ANI

"The Union Home Minister was already aware of the issues. The message to us was very clear. 'Mend your ways, improve your party,' is what was hinted to us," top sources said.

During the NCP core committee meeting at Ms. Pawar's residence, committee members did not mince their words while expressing their disagreements, sources told *The Hindu*.

Most of the six NCP leaders who met Mr. Shah are veterans with years of experience as Ministers and strong popular support. Two of them had recently called for introspection within the party after its dismal performance in the Legislative Council elections.

After the sudden demise of NCP leader and former Deputy Chief Minister Ajit Pawar in a helicopter crash early this year, his son and political novice, Parth Pawar, had unofficially taken the reins of the party. This has caused resentment and bad blood in the party. Senior leaders have criticised his style of functioning as "authoritarian". His political inexperience has only added to the discontent among senior leaders, who have been excluded from all key decisions in the party.

"If they (Parth Pawar and Sunetra Pawar) don't change their way of functioning, the senior party leaders are considering charting their own way. They are not left with much of a choice, considering the unilateral decisions being taken in the party," a senior NCP leader told *The Hindu*.

8 labourers electrocuted, 5 injured in Rajasthan

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

Eight labourers died from electrocution and five were injured when a road construction machine came into contact with an overhead 11-kV high-tension power line at Chhapoli village in Jhunjhunu district of Rajasthan on Monday. The gravel mixing machine was being used to lay a road with public participation.

A massive electric current spread through the equipment instantly, striking labourers at the site. Five workers were killed on the spot, while three died during treatment. All the deceased were residents of Chhapoli. Villagers rushed to the spot and helped in the rescue efforts, as those injured were shifted to the Community Health Centre at Udaipurwati.

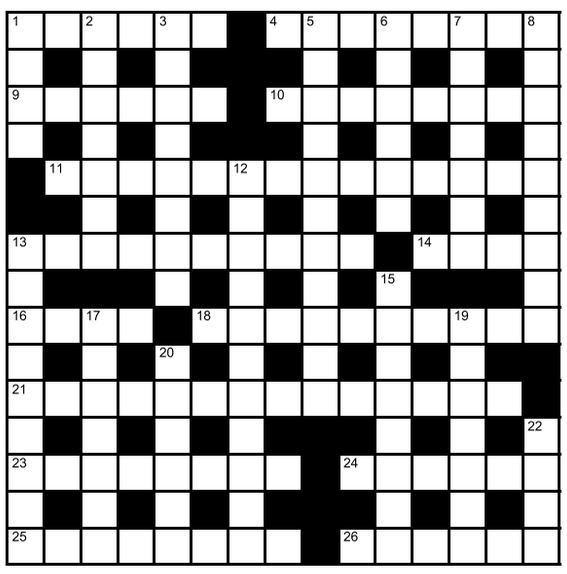
The deaths triggered anger among villagers, who staged a demonstration, alleging negligence by the administration and the power discom.

TH CROSSWORD + 14939

(set by Hypatia)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

1 Former partner not completely inflexible about engaging with sweetheart (2-4)
4 Leaders in power saw disheartened youngsters inspiring fashionable visionaries (8)
9 Measure regal London homes (6)
10 Tough working on his goal after leaving school (8)
11 So, each goes in lost cause (4,5,5)
13 Assign fee (10)
14 Pair of setters in viral image (4)
16 Starts from trio unexpectedly blowing air instrument (4)
18 Irreverently, loud sass beginning to provoke worker, largely discontented (10)
21 What Houdini might have said when denied permission to perform (2,5,3,4)
23 Regretted about magazine's last piece on topless girl published again (8)
24 Author's copy in both ends of store (6)
25 First knight ringing maiden had to propose (8)
26 Often reviewed lead genres by geographical area (6)

Down

1 Advantage earned during game especially at the outset (4)
2 With 22 Down, legendary hero shall report around one in the morning (7,4)
3 Bright student barging into meals getting drunk (8)
5 Without question, extremely sensuous blouse's a sensation (11)
6 Local icon's clothing material (6)
7 Batting by reportedly huge person with no appreciation (7)
8 Therefore, trust in earnest (9)
12 Rudely boos the French fragrance that's out of date (11)
13 A new tarmac made to accommodate a vessel (9)
15 Trace lake submerged in section with frozen water (8)
17 Faith of some oddly following Arab nation mostly lacking resistance (7)
19 Fruitful working together as a set in broadcast (7)
20 Quentin's found frequently in concert (6)
22 See 2 Down

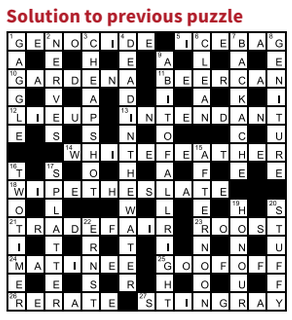
SUDOKU

1								
		8	9	1	3		7	
		3	8	6				
2							6	
5			4		6			7
	9							5
				4	9	5		
	3		1	7	8	2		
								4

No.SS7050 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

5	2	7	1	3	6	9	8	4
4	9	6	2	5	8	1	3	7
3	8	1	4	7	9	2	6	5
9	4	8	3	2	1	5	7	6
1	7	5	9	6	4	3	2	8
6	3	2	5	8	7	4	1	9
8	1	9	7	4	2	6	5	3
2	6	3	8	9	5	7	4	1
7	5	4	6	1	3	8	9	2

FAITH

Mangala sloka for Rama

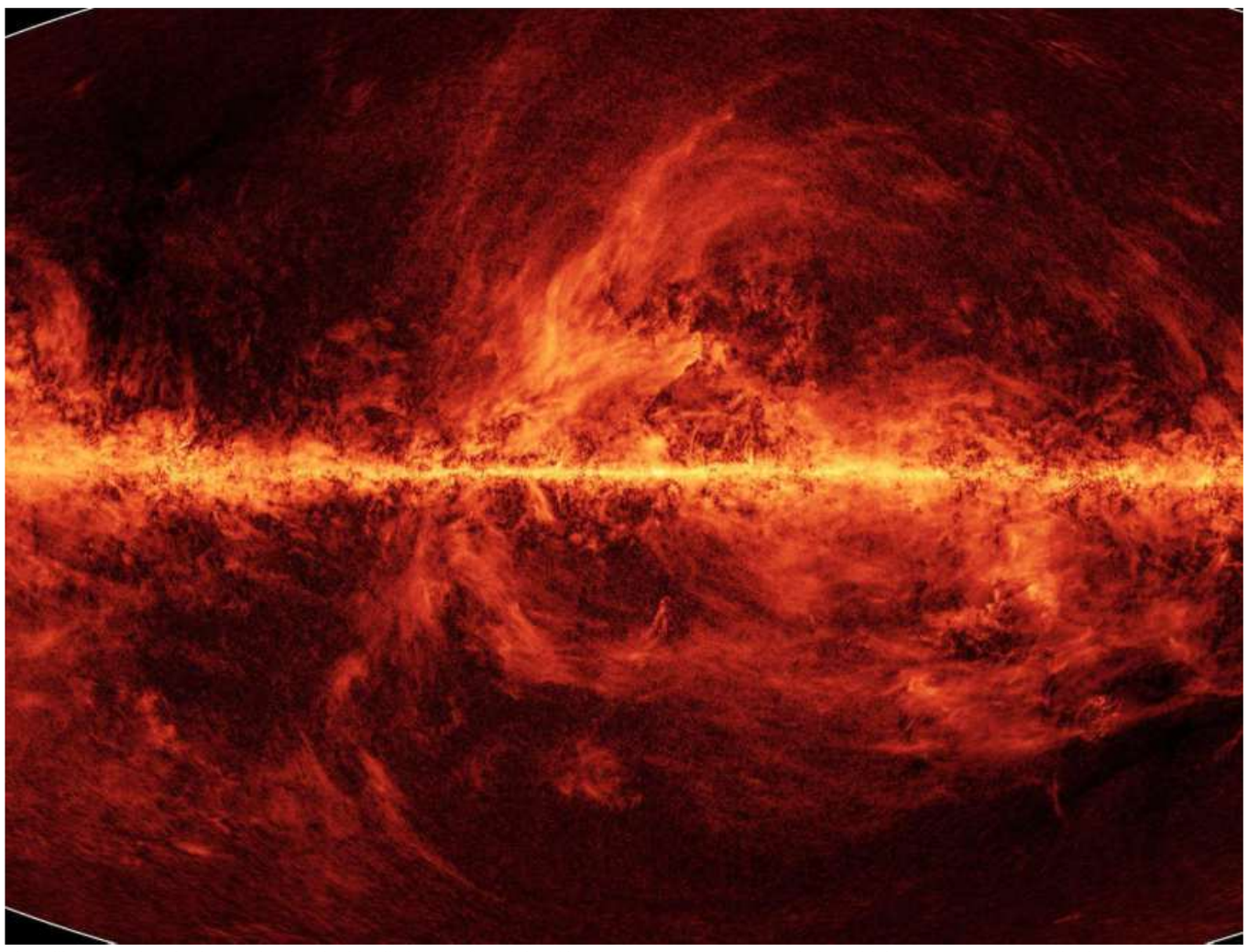
When Valmiki saw a hunter kill one of a pair of krauncha birds, he cursed the hunter through a sloka. But the sloka can also be interpreted differently, in a positive sense, said M.A. Venkatakrishnan in a discourse. Valmiki's sloka begins with the word *manishadah*. If you split this as *ma* and *nishada*, then it is Valmiki addressing the hunter (*nishada*). Valmiki curses the hunter, "Oh hunter! You killed one of two birds which were making love (*kaamamohitam*). Because of that, you will never have any peace." But if the word *manishadah* is not split, then it means the One who is never separated from *ma*, that is Mahalakshmi. So, this can be taken as a reference to Rama Himself.

While the words *shasvathi samah pratistham tvam agamah* have a negative meaning when we take them as referring to the hunter, they also can mean 'May you live long.' *Kaamamohitam* can be seen as a reference to Ravana, who was caught in *kama* (lust) for Sita. So, the entire sloka can be seen as a mangala sloka for Rama, the One who is never separated from Sita and the One who killed the lustful asura. While Valmiki's intention was to curse the hunter, it so happened that he presented the Ramayana story in a nutshell through that sloka. There are certain rules to be followed while writing a *kavya*. A *mahakavya* must have thousands of verses, and Valmiki's Ramayana has 24,000 verses. Although many versions of the Ramayana came up later, Valmiki's is the authentic account, because he was witness to everything that happened in Rama's life, thanks to the divine vision which Brahma gave him. When Lord Narayana decided to take the Rama avatara, Veda Purusha decided to take an avatara as Valmiki Ramayana.

Milky Way grew by devouring galaxies, leaving ghost stars

Galactic archaeologists are using precise measures and larger sample sizes afforded by new missions to tease apart minute differences between groups of stars, revealing the history of Milky Way going back around 12 billion years; age, chemistry, and motion reveal different aspects about stars

Siddhant Pusdekar
LONDON



The Milky Way galaxy is ablaze with dust in this all-sky map from 'Planck', a European Space Agency mission with important NASA contributions. The towers of fiery colours are actually dust in the galaxy and beyond that has been polarised. ESA/NASA/JPL-CALTECH

There have always been stories about them. Australian Aboriginal tales tell of an old couple called the Jukara, while for Chile's Mapuche people they are Rvganko or water ponds. To modern astronomers, they are the Small and Large Magellanic clouds, two of the closest galaxies to us that are in the process of being swallowed by the Milky Way.

They are evidence of a kind of snowball effect that characterises the formation and evolution of galaxies, which scientists believe are the result of a series of violent collisions. As galaxies fall into one another, the smaller ones are ripped apart by tidal forces of the larger, leaving behind streams and clusters of stars that don't move in lockstep with the rest of the galaxy. They also stand out for their chemical compositions, which allow astronomers to group stars that were born together and piece back their rough ages.

And together, age, chemistry, and motion tell astronomers different things about stars. Galactic archaeologists use precise measures and larger sample sizes afforded by new missions to tease apart minute differences between groups of stars, revealing the history of the Milky Way going back almost 12 billion years.

First of its kind

In early September, Vasily Belokurov, Amina Helmi, and Rodrigo Ibata won the Kavli Award for complementary discoveries of some of the galaxy's major collisions.

It began with a chance observation. Over three decades ago, when Dr. Ibata, of the University of Strasbourg, turned his attention to the central bulge of the galaxy's disc, he noticed some stars slightly off-centre moving in a peculiar way.

Everything in the galaxy has a shared direction of motion and velocity, but these particular stars stood out and all seemed to be moving in concert. After a year of repeated measurements, Dr. Ibata was left with the only hypothesis that made sense: that the group of stars were part of a much smaller galaxy, the Sagittarius dwarf, that the Milky Way had absorbed.

Although researchers had suspected that the galaxy is littered with remnants of ancient collisions, the discovery – the first of its kind – kickstarted a search for more. Galaxies that were absorbed earlier would be harder to see, because, unlike Sagittarius, which merged only six billion years ago, they might not be intact.

Gaia-Enceladus

As part of her PhD in the 1990s, Dr. Helmi, now at the University of Groningen, developed models of this destruction and predicted that as smaller galaxies are ripped apart by larger ones, they leave behind a stream of stars that should be visible.

In 1999, by applying those models on data from the European Space Agency's (ESA) Hipparcos mission, Dr. Helmi *et al*. analysed the three-dimensional motion of 97 stars around the sun. They found seven had a different orbit from the rest, suggesting they come from outside the galaxy.

But this was a small sample. If the Milky Way formed by cannibalising many smaller galaxies, the firmament should be littered with streams. To see them, researchers would need to tease apart the motion dynamics of thousands of stars with greater precision.

Dr. Helmi waited 20 years until the ESA Gaia mission released its second dataset, looking at almost the whole galaxy. In 2018, Dr. Helmi *et al*. used these measurements to find a large fraction of stars in our neighbourhood that move counterclockwise, instead of the clockwise motion of the rest of the galaxy.

The team combined photometry data on colour and brightness from Gaia and spectroscopy obtained from APO Galactic Evolution Experiment to estimate the ages and chemical composition of these stars. Finally, they grouped the stars that were born together.

They also developed a model that fit the relationship between the colour and luminosity of these groups of stars, to reveal their age. Together, the results suggested these stars were born 10-12 billion years ago in a different galaxy, which they called Gaia-Enceladus.

First major merger

Using the chemical compositions, the team also calculated the rate of star formation and the mass of this galaxy before it crashed with the Milky Way. As opposed to the many smaller collisions Dr. Helmi expected to see, the collision with Gaia-Enceladus, which occurred about 10 billion years ago, must have been large enough to alter the Milky Way's shape, she said. There have been even older collisions, however. In an August 2026 paper, researchers confirmed that around 12 billion years ago, a galaxy called Low-energy-Kraken-Heracles (LKH) collided with the Milky Way. LKH sits in our galaxy's central bulge, which contains the oldest stars going back to the galaxy's creation. But stardust obscures the view.

Another problem with studying such old collisions is that the galaxies were still young, making it harder to detect the divergence in the evolution of their stellar systems, which would be apparent in the stars that came from them.

Instead of focusing on individual stars, the researchers studied 39 globular clusters, groups of about a million stars that are born together and behaved in the same way. They also homogenised the models they used to calculate the ages of stars, because different models can produce results that diverge by as much as 2 billion years, said Davide Massari of the National Institute for Astrophysics at Bologna, who led the work.

'Amazing decade'

By applying these theoretical models about age-dependent dynamics and element content to their data, the researchers determined that 12 of these globular clusters are not from the Milky Way and were absorbed 1.8 billion years before Gaia-Enceladus. At about 12 billion years, this might be the first major merger the Milky Way experienced, Dr. Massari said. While data from the Gaia mission are resolving the history of the galaxy, they also raise new questions and are telling researchers where to point new tools.

How bits of galaxies move after being accreted by the Milky Way may not be uniform, making it challenging to tell whether some seemingly foreign objects have a common origin. A recent reanalysis suggested that the globular cluster omega-Centauri, once thought to be a dwarf galaxy absorbed by the Milky Way, may be the nucleus of Gaia-Enceladus. But the data are not conclusive: the researchers do not fully understand how omega-Centauri's interaction with the Milky Way's central bulge might have changed its motion.

New projects are coming online to dig deeper. 4MOST, a multi-object spectroscopic survey instrument in Paranal, Chile, will soon start surveying the Southern Sky, probing the Magellanic clouds, Sagittarius, and other previously identified galaxies. The MOONS telescope will also detect infrared light coming from the galactic bulge, which escapes from the center more easily, said Ása Skúladóttir of the University of Florence.

"The last 10 years have been amazing," Dr. Skúladóttir, who has a project associated with 4MOST, added. "But I genuinely believe that the next 10 years are going to be even more amazing because there's so much data coming, and people are really getting invested in this field."

(Siddhant Pusdekar is a science writer. siddhantttpusdekar@gmail.com)



U.S. President Donald Trump has often been the subject of deepfake images and videos. PAU CASALS/UNSPLASH

New technique uses light to spot deepfakes in seconds

Vasudevan Mukunth

Many deepfake videos are easy to spot – the eyes move in strange ways, there's an extra finger on a hand or the light is weirdly distributed – but many are just as hard, if not impossible. Recent research in *Nature Communications* found that humans are able to spot deepfakes only 50% of the time.

In a leg-up to humans in this fight against unreal information, researchers at the University of California, Los Angeles, have found a way to tell if a video is a deepfake based on the light in it. In lab tests, the method was so good that it almost never failed to spot a manipulated video.

Based on the findings, published in the journal *eLight*, the researchers have said it could reduce the burden on social media platforms, which currently process large quantities of user-submitted videos using resource-intensive techniques.

Deepfake videos have emerged as a scourge to society by playing on people's interest in videos and the general belief that videos are hard to fake. However, artificial intelligence (AI) has short-circuited the latter by allowing users to quickly and easily modify videos, often at low cost.

Thus, deepfakes have emerged during elections purporting to show politicians saying things they did not and to show men and women committing obscene acts that, in reality, they never did.

While AI-based detectors can identify videos with such falsified information, they require large amounts of computing power. The bad actors who produce these videos also sidestep such tools by compressing the video or deliberately blurring it. The technique reported in the new work combines an electronic computer – one that works with chips – with an optical computer, i.e. a machine where light performs part of the work normally done by chips.

A program running on this machine selects 12 frames from the video in question and checks the faces in them for patterns that could set them apart. Then the program feeds what information it has gathered into a device called a spatial light modulator and then to two spots on a sensor. Based on the difference in brightness between these spots, the system could say whether a video was fake.

In tests, the system was able to identify manipulated videos with an accuracy of 99.86% and real videos with an accuracy of 95.72% – while processing 15 videos at a time. Even when the number of videos being processed together was pushed to 18, the overall accuracy only fell to 96.13%. The system also identified videos made with the Google Veo 3 AI model with an accuracy of 94.8%, signalling that it doesn't have to be trained from scratch against content generated by the latest AI models.

The researchers estimated that the optical part of the machine consumed sevenfold less energy than the electronic part. That said, since the machine requires both parts to work, its overall energy consumption was a more modest 13% lower than a fully electronic setup.

Based on these findings, the researchers have proposed that social media platforms et al. can use the system as a filter that flags videos that do need to be checked further, liberating the platforms from having to check all of them.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

November 3 in the history of science

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1
On this day in 1906, a German psychiatrist named _____ _____ described a disease that was subsequently named for him, by presenting a woman named August Deter, who he said had the disease. Its symptoms include memory loss, loss of thinking skills, behavioural changes, and the inability to perform the tasks of daily life. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 2
Also in 1906, representatives from 27 countries signed the International Radiotelegraph Convention in Berlin, establishing the world's first standard wireless distress signal. It had a distinct Morse code that also made the signal easier to recognise in emergency communications. Name the three letters associated with the signal.

QUESTION 3
In 1955, two scientists named Fred Schaffer and Carlton Schwerdt presented their findings at a U.S. National Academy of Sciences meeting, including evidence that they had purified and crystallised _____ particles. The feat was the first for an animal virus, and paved the way for detailed studies that eventually lead to vaccines. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 4
In 1971, Bell Labs issued the first edition of the manual for the X operating system. Developed by a team of computer programmers led by Ken Thompson and Dennis Ritchie, X has had a significant influence on multiple generations of operating systems, including Linux and macOS. Name X.

QUESTION 5
In 1973, NASA launched the _____ __ mission to Mercury. The mission spacecraft became the first to explore the planet closest to the sun, the first to use a gravitational assist to reach a different destination, and provided the first close-in pictures of Mercury's cratered surface. Fill in the blanks.



Visual: Name the animal that inspired this statue in Moscow and the tragic feat she achieved on this day in 1957. MOS.RU (CC BY)

Answers to October 27 quiz:
1. When mountaineers don't receive enough oxygen for normal function
– **Ans: Hypoxia**
2. Mountain range whose name means "abode of snow"
– **Ans: Himalaya**
3. Country with the most 8K mountains; climber who summited all 14 of them
– **Ans: Nepal; Nirmal Purja**
4. Lowest layer of the earth's atmosphere
– **Ans: Troposphere**
5. Tallest mountain from base to summit; ocean in which it lies
– **Ans: Mauna Kea; Pacific Ocean**

Visual: **Annapurna**

First contact

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United stand

Protests against SIR are a recognition that it could subvert popular will

The gathering of hundreds of thousands of people at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan, organised by the Congress-led INDIA bloc parties, was a milestone in the battle for the restoration of the integrity of India's election process. As more and more skeletons tumble out the of the closet of the Election Commission of India (ECI), its chief Gyanesh Kumar has chosen silence while the ruling BJP has rushed to shield him from criticism. The united outcry of protest by the Opposition, led by the Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, is a strong signal of public opinion for the ruling party and India's institutions, including the ECI, that appear complicit in a scheme that threatens the foundations of Indian democracy. What remains unexplained by the ECI and Mr. Kumar are malpractices in the Special Intensive Revision that could have the effect of subverting the popular will. Protestors on Sunday had arrived from all parts of India, and included people directly affected by the SIR across the country.

The protest reinforced Mr. Gandhi's central role as the key challenger of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Mr. Gandhi, for all his faults, has been an uncompromising champion of constitutional values and pluralism in India. The BJP caricatured him, and even non-BJP voices had bought into the idea of Mr. Gandhi being a privileged dynast out of touch with the commoner. While his ancestry is a matter of fact, so is his tenacity. All Opposition parties mobilised for the protest, but the centrality of the Congress party was unmistakable. Mr. Gandhi has a special focus on subaltern classes to be included in positions of responsibility in the party. The Sunday protest was clearly the largest show of strength in recent memory. The manner in which the Congress coordinated with the wide spectrum of the Opposition, often involving rivals in States, also indicates a clear sense of purpose and pragmatism. The call for the restoration of institutional integrity is the need of the hour; but Mr. Gandhi must be careful not to misstate the nature of the crisis. In his well-reasoned call for accountability of the ECI, Mr. Gandhi ended up questioning the legitimacy of the previous election without providing any substantive basis for his allegations. He must remember that his emergence as the voice of the Opposition places on him the responsibility of being measured in his speeches and his steps.

Cascading effect

India must respect land rights of its people while building dams

The bureaucratic impetus for the 11.2-GW Siang Upper Multipurpose Project (SUMP) in Arunachal Pradesh purportedly comes from China's aggressive development of a 60-GW mega-dam in Tibet, stoking anxieties among Indian authorities over 'weaponised' transboundary waters. Beijing may be able to divert flows in the Yarlung Tsangpo river, which becomes the Brahmaputra in India, to cause drought downstream or release water en masse to trigger catastrophic floods in Arunachal Pradesh and Assam. New Delhi thus imagines SUMP as a strategic buffer, but in so doing faces a dilemma it should not attempt to resolve with force. Its extant top-down approach, exemplified by deploying security forces to guard survey teams and imposing the State Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act against activists, only validates fears among locals that the state will grab their land. The region also hosts sustained protests against the Subansiri Upper Hydroelectric Project, expanding the indictment to Arunachal Pradesh's model of hydroelectric power development. The eastern Himalayas are among the most tectonically active and erosion-prone landscapes in the world. The mega-dam in Tibet will comprise five cascading power stations over the river's roughly 2,000-metre fall over 50 km. Beijing has maintained the dam will not harm countries downstream but has declined to share crucial engineering details. This is why diplomacy will be an essential part of operating SUMP, in addition to Beijing's disputed claims on Arunachal Pradesh.

The Brahmaputra basin in Assam and Bangladesh receives most of its water from monsoon rains and tributaries downstream of the Tibetan Plateau, so China cannot straightforwardly control the river's total flow through India. Yet since Chinese interventions would have greater consequences closer to the border, SUMP will need information about both the mega-dam's operations and downstream inflows to plan its own operations, and Beijing has declined to share the former. SUMP thus faces many uncertainties at the outset. Despite India repeatedly raising the issue with China at the highest levels, headway has been limited to Beijing agreeing to share hydrological data on humanitarian grounds during emergencies. Planners have contemplated maintaining the SUMP reservoir at 70% to accommodate unexpected surges, but the level of protection possible if China supplies no advance warning remains unclear. This uncertainty is a thorn in the side of the government's push against more legitimate resistance by Adi community members and civil rights groups. The need for the project does not excuse the state from following all the relevant laws and protections. The state cannot protect the nation's needs by antagonising the nation's people.

How AI training models could compromise privacy



Tulika Avni Sinha

Senior Research Fellow (Data Governance, Privacy and AI), World Privacy Forum

The right to privacy is a constitutional right upheld by the Supreme Court in 2017. However, the legal instruments currently in place to safeguard this right seem inadequate, especially considering the technological revolution led by Artificial Intelligence (AI) around the world. While AI regulation is one of the most commonly discussed issues within governments today, the recommendations have been broad, vague and have only led to further questions. AI has immense potential to boost productivity and have positive effects on people's lives; any indiscriminate regulatory or policy measure risks inhibiting innovation and economic growth. However, there are lower hanging fruits; specific gaps that can be filled to better safeguard people's constitutional rights without permanently losing out in the AI race.

Privacy coverage

The Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act was passed in 2023, with the DPDP Rules being notified in November 2025. The implementation is phased with some provisions on consent and safety becoming effective only in 2027. Prior to the DPDP Act, the primary legal instrument to regulate the use and management of personal data was the Information Technology (IT) Act, 2000. Together the IT Act, 2000 and its 2011 Rules broadly regulated the export of "sensitive personal data" on the condition that the recipient ensured a level of data protection required under Indian law, and that the transfer was either necessary to perform a lawful contract or had been consented to by the data provider. An assertion and claim were sufficient to record adequacy. The criminal penalty for unauthorised disclosure was capped at three years' imprisonment or a fine of ₹5 lakh. These penalties only applied to disclosure of sensitive personal data that were listed in the Rules such as financial data, medical or health details, sexual orientation, biometric information etc. The Rules did not apply to personal data such as names, addresses, phone numbers, caste, religion, political affiliations, browsing history, social media activity, online or offline behavioural patterns, institutional affiliations etc.

It also did not apply to any data scraped publicly such as from social media platforms. For context, India is the largest market for Facebook and Instagram in the world. Tech giants such as Meta, Amazon, and Google use data collected from the users to train their AI models.

> Credible studies have shown that querying an AI model with 'anonymised' data to extract personal details that it had memorised during training can be used to identify individuals and build their profiles

The DPDP Act is now the general purpose legal instrument to regulate the use of citizens' data. Yet it does not apply to publicly available data or information inferred from parameters such as social media activity including names, gender/sex, locations, institutional affiliations, images, videos or attributes. Such 'inferred' data could include emotions, mobility, and behavioural patterns. It buckets all personal data together and does not create a specific category for sensitive personal data as was followed under IT Act, 2000. Consequently, data that are intuitively sensitive such as passwords and mental and physical health conditions are treated in the same bucket as name, marital status, city, shopping interests etc. When viewed in this light, it seems that the DPDP Act is regressive and fails to assign stronger protections to categories that were better protected earlier. It can be a valid critique to say that even personal non-sensitive data can reveal sensitive information depending upon the context of their collection and accompanying parameters in analysis. However, some data points, when revealed, stand the risk of being severely misused and encroach upon individual privacy without the need for any inference such as biometrics, passwords etc. They need higher levels of protection.

Training AI on personal data

Further, the DPDP Act does not acknowledge or engage with the topic of AI models and data used in their training. One of the risks of AI models to privacy is that they can regurgitate the data used in their training. Credible studies have shown that querying an AI model with "anonymised" data to extract personal details that it had memorised during training can be used to identify individuals and build their profiles. Studies have also shown that various methods can be used via AI to extract sensitive information about individuals using generic publicly available information. This means that if your data was used to train an AI model, an anonymised dataset that is now legally compliant can be used to extract your personal details and profile you without your consent.

It is important to note that Indian users have not had a right or a legal mechanism to prevent this use in the past. Since DPDP's consent provision is only effective next year, companies do not need to fully comply and obtain one's consent with respect to its data processing needs now. Worse, even after the DPDP's substantive provisions take full effect in May 2027, Indian users will have no right to object to AI being trained on their public data. In contrast, Meta currently provides its users in the EU an opt-out feature that allows the user to object to their data being used in Meta's AI training.

This also needs to be juxtaposed with the fact that the right to be forgotten under the DPDP Act only applies to data for which the user had provided consent to the organisation. It is unclear if the right extends to the information inferred from the analysis of the said data. The DPDP Act also exempts this right from processing for research, archival, or statistical purposes. The conditions to be met under such an exemption still need to be prescribed by the Union government. Whether AI model training (often framed by companies as research to improve service delivery) falls within this exemption remains unclear and is, therefore, a potential route by which such processing could escape the Act's obligations entirely.

What can be done

These are low hanging fruits and can be addressed with amendments, notification of Rules and legal judgments. The provisions of the DPDP Act must apply to data used for training AI models. Further, it should provide people with a right to object to that use, and enforce protections on publicly scrapped data and the information inferred from that data. It should also strengthen the right to erasure so that the responsibility falls on the companies to inform the users of every entity that holds their data. The DPDP Act should also clarify whether AI training is included under research exemption by default; and create a sensitive data category with stricter provisions of use and processing. There are definite trade-offs between development objectives and privacy safeguards and the extent of the adoption can follow that prioritisation.

Having said that, these are not non-urgent concerns. They are backed by documentation and acknowledgement from companies and the government. There have been numerous discussions on India being an exporter of its data for AI training. The solution is not to prevent the export or to ban personal information from AI training, which can worsen AI outcomes on inclusion, efficiency, discrimination and bias for the Indian population.

India is staged to be the use case hub of the world – AI is being deployed by corporate giants, MSMEs, and even not-for-profits across sectors. The more we delay closing gaps on privacy, the weaker the constitutional right becomes.

An anti-climactic outcome in the Knesset elections



Mahesh Sachdev

Retired Indian Ambassador, specialising in West Asia and oil issues

For the Israeli Knesset election hyped as "consequential" and a "day of reckoning for the October 7 Hamas attack", the verdict points to new trends and the normalisation of trenchant nationalism. The inconclusive outcome risks disappointing most stakeholders. Israel, being at the epicentre of the ongoing regional tumult, needs a real-time analysis.

Israel's total electorate is 7.3 million. Yet it has 38 officially recognised political parties vying for 120 Knesset seats, of which only 11 parties are likely to cross the 3.25% voting threshold needed to enter the legislature. The elections are on a proportional representation basis. The parties are currently arrayed in three coalitions: the ruling extreme right, the centrist bloc and the Israeli-Arab bloc which got 53, 48 and 19 seats, respectively. The last group representing a 21% minority is largely untouchable for mainstream Jewish parties. The electorate is also split along ethnic and origin-based lines into occidental, oriental and orthodox cohorts. Since the last elections in 2022, nearly half a million new voters have come of age. The voter turnout jumped by nearly a tenth to 77.7% – a sign of sharp political engagement.

The indications point to a hung parliament, with neither of the two major coalitions able to gain the 61 seats needed for a majority. While the Likud-led coalition, headed by current Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, is down by 11 seats, it is still ahead of the rival coalition. Although the Likud party got only 27 seats, its lowest score in 13 years, it remains the largest party in the Knesset. The Yashar, the main opposition party, got 21.

A war hungry rule

The election was overshadowed by the extraordinary turmoil faced by Israel during the last four years under Mr. Netanyahu, who led one of the most divisive governments in the country's history. His rule saw the shocking raid by the Gaza-based Hamas militia on October 7, 2023, which murdered nearly 1,200 Israelis and took 251 as hostages – the biggest single-day loss in Israel's history. The incident upended Mr. Netanyahu's claim of being a "security hawk", as several reports emerged that credible early warnings were ignored. He responded by waging all-out war over the past three years against Hamas, Lebanon's Hezbollah and Yemen's Houthis with mixed results. Though severely affected, these non-state actors are still defiant.

> While voters have reprimanded Mr. Netanyahu for his flawed conduct, they seem to be willing to give him another chance

However, Iran, the putative mentor of this "axis of resistance", remains Prime Minister Netanyahu's biggest unfinished agenda. Israel's two energetic military campaigns in concert with the U.S. have not succeeded in dismantling either the Islamic Republic or its nuclear programme. Moreover, Iranian retaliatory actions have inflicted serious costs on Israel, the U.S. and some Arab neighbours. The adverse global consequences of these wars and allegations of genocide in Gaza have sullied Israel's image. While most Israelis concur with his assessment of Iran being an existential threat, many see his pursuit of kinetic wars as costly failures that have not achieved their military objectives, but have instead created friction with the Trump administration and the U.S. public. Mr. Netanyahu is perceived as having used the wars to avoid accountability for the October 7 attack as well as for corruption charges against him.

Against this complex backdrop, the polls can be interpreted in multiple ways. First, better security, with a focus on preventive interventions, has emerged as the primary concern. Second, political discourse has hardened, with the national consensus shifting sharply to the right. An overwhelming majority have voted for the two coalitions, both of which reject any compromise on the Palestinian problem, including a "two-state" solution. This extreme Zionist nationalism complicates the pursuit of any pathway towards political rapprochement both at home and regionally. Third, while voters have reprimanded Mr. Netanyahu for his flawed conduct, they seem to be willing to give him another chance. The guarded and partial endorsement should be seen as a consequence of a rightward shift in public opinion. Mr. Netanyahu, who remains steadfast in his aggressive policies, is likely to use this popular affirmation to draw a line under his past infractions and bury calls for accountability. Fourth, the unprecedented performance of the Israeli-Arab bloc gives an edgy counterpoint to the polarisation of Israeli society. And finally, in a reversal to a global trend, Israeli Gen-Z youth seem to be preferring right-wing candidates.

A dangerous shift

While right-wing nationalism has always been present in Israeli society, from the Irgun and Stern gangs in the 1940s to the assassination of former Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin in 1995, the current Knesset poll marks its mainstreaming, which is a worrisome development.

The procedural follow-up of the election results would begin this week with the Israeli President inviting Mr. Netanyahu to form a majority government within the next 28 days, extendable by another 14 days. If he fails, the centrist coalition leader may be asked to make a similar attempt. In case he also fails, a national government may be attempted. Once all these options are exhausted, new elections may be ordered. In the meantime, Mr. Netanyahu would continue to be the Prime Minister in a caretaker capacity.

This situation is hardly new in Israel: during 2019-22, Israel had four elections before the current coalition came to power.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Responsible Opposition

The success of the INDIA bloc rally in New Delhi, which sought the removal of CEC Gyanesh Kumar over his alleged role in ordering a flawed Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise should serve as a wake-up call for the BJP-led government at the Centre. It must listen patiently to the legitimate grievances of citizens and address them with the seriousness they deserve. While the Congress and other INDIA bloc constituents can take satisfaction in the success of the Delhi rally, they cannot afford to lose sight of the imperative need to remain united and sustain public momentum against the ruling dispensation. The Opposition has an onerous responsibility to mobilise public opinion, safeguard democratic values and prevent the country from sliding towards authoritarianism.

M. Jeyaram
Tamil Nadu

Need holistic approach

It is gratifying to learn that the CJI while on an official visit to Keralam flagged his anguish and concern over the growing tendency among litigants to approach the top court to seek early hearing of their cases (November 2, "Why make litigants rush to SC for early hearings, CJI asks HCs"). What is beyond comprehension is the fact that even the top court often commits a breach of its own precepts by sitting on holidays to entertain petitions of some VIPs in utter disregard of how badly this impacts the psyche of litigants suffering the plight of pendency of their cases. The issue needs to be addressed in a holistic manner to rule out this dismal scenario.

Ravi Mathur
Noida

Cuba embargo

For the last three decades, the UN General Assembly has been adopting a resolution urging the U.S. to lift the economic embargo on Cuba but to no avail. Though the resolution was adopted in the recent UNGA too, the latest UN proceedings were truly shocking as there were more abstentions and negative votes than normal, and even worse were the scuffles which occurred between the U.S. and Cuban delegates. Mercifully India did not abstain and stuck to its decade-old position. The U.S. envoy to the UN Mike Waltz has gloated over the increased number of abstentions this year which, to say the least, is anything but dignified. Sufferings of ordinary people whether in Gaza, or Cuba or Iran on account of wars by the U.S. and its allies are human rights violations besides amounting to the virtual shredding of the UN Charter.

Angara Venkata Girija Kumar
Chennai

To read more letters online, scan the QR code.
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address and the full name or the name with initials.

T.N. can lead in expenditure reform



Anoop Singh

is Distinguished Fellow, Centre for Social and Economic Progress (CSEP), and has been Member, 15th Finance Commission, and Asia Pacific Director, International Monetary Fund

Tamil Nadu's new high-level committee on welfare and public spending has an important task: defining how expenditure is measured and evaluated, and to do so in line with international standards. This could establish a model for reform across India. The reform should reduce leakage, duplication, and low-value spending while creating room for human capital, infrastructure, and technologies needed for future growth.

The State's June 2026 White Paper shows why this is urgent. In 2024-25, committed expenditure absorbed almost two-thirds of revenue receipts, against 49% in Maharashtra and 45% in Karnataka and Gujarat. Interest payments alone reached almost one quarter of revenue receipts in 2025-26, against 16% in Karnataka, 12% in Gujarat, and 10% in Maharashtra. Capital expenditure was under 1.5% of GSDP, against 1.9% in Karnataka and Maharashtra and 2.9% in Gujarat. Thus, Tamil Nadu has an expenditure structure more rigid and less investment-oriented than its major peers.

The committee needs a clear picture of what the government is spending and where it is recorded.

India lacks comparable State expenditure data. Definitions, classifications, and institutional coverage vary across States and between States and the Union. Tamil Nadu could lead by reconciling its accounts with international standards, such as the IMF's Government Finance Statistics Manual 2014 (GFSM), which distinguishes investment in non-financial assets, transactions in financial assets, and incurrence of liabilities. A supplementary GFSM reconciliation would greatly improve inter-State and international comparability.

The government needs to establish the full fiscal cost of subsidies. State subsidy reporting is fragmented and frequently incomparable, with implicit subsidies remaining outside conventional statements. For example, it reports subsidies for bicycles and seeds as grants-in-aid; in 2023-24, this amounted to ₹802 crore. The White Paper also reports that working-capital borrowing by the State Civil Supplies Corporation rose sharply from ₹17,500 crore in 2021-22 to ₹27,181 crore in 2025-26 against rising subsidy receivables. The committee should identify the costs, beneficiaries, and outcomes of major subsidies.

Power shows why the fiscal perimeter matters. Support can take the form of explicit tariff subsidies, below-cost pricing, unpaid obligations, utility losses, guarantees, borrowing, capital outlays, and net lending. Where electricity is supplied below cost for social reasons, the subsidy should be explicit.

Recorded capital spending across States and the Centre typically includes loans, equity injections, debt repayments, and other financial transactions, although they do not necessarily create non-financial assets. Roads, water systems, schools, hospitals, and other productive assets should be distinguished from loans, equity, and other financial transactions. GFSM provides a consistent framework, especially important when the State's investment ratio is already below those of its principal economic peers.

The same measurement problem applies to employment. Tamil Nadu budget data put salaries at about ₹75,500 crore in the 2023-24 revised estimates. But the wider publicly financed employment bill extends beyond this. Notably, RBI's recorded municipal-finance data identify ₹3,668 crore of salary, wage, and pension expenditure for the State's covered municipal corporations, up from ₹2,899 crore in 2019-20. These figures illustrate why the full cost of publicly financed employment is difficult to establish. Spending on contractual and scheme workers, and on employees of aided institutions, local bodies, autonomous institutions, and public enterprises, is not regularly consolidated. Across States, our estimates suggest salary expenditure rises from a reported 2.5% of GDP to about 4.1% once important omitted components are included.

Tamil Nadu could publish both a GFSM-consistent compensation measure and a supplementary measure of its wider publicly financed employment footprint.

Once expenditure is correctly measured, the committee can ask what each rupee achieves. Major programmes should be comprehensively assessed for beneficiaries, unit costs, leakage, duplication and outcomes. Successful programmes should be protected or expanded and ineffective ones redesigned or discontinued. If the committee succeeds, Tamil Nadu could offer other States a practical approach to expenditure reform.

If the committee tasked with defining how expenditure is measured and evaluated succeeds, Tamil Nadu could offer other States a practical approach to expenditure reform

Firecrackers: Festivity or fallout?



Sincy Wilson

is Assistant Professor, School of Law, Vels University (VISTAS), and a legal researcher specialising in constitutional and administrative law, and international environmental law



Vaishali R. Venkat

The smoke that wafts through our celebrations carries a hidden cost. How can society preserve the joy of celebration without compromising the right to breathe clean air?

On October 12, the Supreme Court's *suo motu* hearing on air pollution in Delhi-NCR brought firecracker restrictions, religious sentiments, and public health into focus. Citing enforcement difficulties, the Bench cautioned against a blanket ban and emphasised public awareness and voluntary restraint to encourage the use of less-polluting alternatives.

Senior advocate Aparajita Singh, the amicus curiae in the matter, urged the Court to ask the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) to address the medical risks associated with air pollution. The proceedings raise a larger constitutional question: how can environmental protection be reconciled with religious freedom without compromising either public health or lawful cultural practice?

Article 21 of the Constitution provides that no person shall be deprived of their life or personal liberty, except according to the procedure established by law. As interpreted by the Supreme Court, the right to life encompasses the right to healthy life. Articles 48A and 51A(g) reinforce this very principle by placing environmental protection within the framework of the Directive Principles of State Policy and Fundamental Duties, respectively. While Article 48A directs the State to protect and improve the environment and safeguard forests and wildlife, Article 51A(g) makes environmental protection a fundamental duty of every citizen. Further, Article 25 guarantees every person freedom of conscience and the right to profess, practise, and propagate religion, subject to public order, morality, and health, among other constitutional limitations. Thus, religious freedom and the freedom to celebrate cannot be treated as an automatic licence to expose others to unreasonable risks to their health. The challenge is not to pit celebration and clean air in opposing camps, but to ensure that the enjoyment of one's freedom does not diminish another's ability to live in a healthy environment.

Environmental protection also demands collective action by governments, institutions, and individuals alike. This understanding of shared environmental responsibility extends beyond national constitutions and finds expression in international environmental principles. For instance, the Stockholm Declaration of 1972 recognised that human well-being is intertwined with environmental quality. The Rio Declaration of 1992 articulated two principles that remain pivotal to environmental policymaking: the precautionary principle, which calls for preventive action by the State against serious environmental risks even when scientific certainty is incomplete, and the polluter-pays principle that suggests that the polluter bears the cost of pollution. Applied to the firecracker debate, these principles bring two core concerns into focus: preventing environmental harm and ensuring that those responsible for pollution bear the cost.

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) and the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR) recognise religious freedom. Moreover, across the globe, countries adopt different approaches to firecracker regulation to protect public safety. For instance, Singapore has banned private firecracker use, permitting only licensed professional fireworks displays. Ireland and the United Kingdom prohibit the sale of traditional firecrackers to the general public. Sweden prohibits the use of firecrackers except by trained individuals holding special permits. Under Germany's explosives regulations, certain powerful firecrackers are restricted to authorised permit holders.

India need not choose between two extremes: a blanket ban and unrestricted use. Regulation can be designed to prevent harm while respecting lawful celebration. This requires scientifically assessing alternatives such as certified green crackers, enforcing emission and safety standards, and holding manufacturers and sellers accountable for violations. The State must ensure that restrictions are proportionate and effectively implemented, while citizens exercise their freedoms with due regard for public health.

After all, a celebration should leave behind memories of joy, not a legacy of polluted air.

Religious freedom and freedom to celebrate cannot be treated as an automatic licence to expose others to unreasonable risks to their health

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Indonesia's wildfires scorch 1.9 million hectares

El Niño has intensified dry conditions, worsening fires and toxic haze; CREA estimates 5,310 pollution deaths in Sept., with 58 mn exposed to unhealthy air

DATA POINT

Devyanshi Bihani

Wildfires scorching Indonesia's forests and peatlands have sent thick, toxic haze across parts of Southeast Asia, fuelling public anger over the government's response. On October 28, thousands of Indonesians took to the streets, with protesters linking the worsening fire crisis to broader grievances over President Prabowo Subianto's policies and handling of the country's problems. "No Clean Air Under Dirty Government," read one placard, while another warned: "If we burn, you burn with us."

More than 1.9 million hectares burned across Indonesia between January and September 2026, according to Nusantara Atlas FireWatch data. The annual hotspot count in 2026 has already surpassed the yearly totals recorded every year from 2019 to 2025, with two months of the year still remaining. **(Chart 1)**

The fires are a result of the land-clearing practices and unusually dry weather in the country. People set fire to vegetation to clear land for agriculture and plantations. The risk is particularly high in peatlands, wetlands which become highly inflammable when dried for any development.

El Niño has compounded the risk this year. Meteorology, Climatology, and Geophysical Agency (BMKG) of Indonesia, in a release in September, said, "The phenomenon of El Niño with very strong intensity and Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) in the ocean around Indonesia has an impact on reducing rainfall." It said 61.91% of the area of the Indonesian mainland was currently experiencing a dry season.

The scale of the fires is also striking when compared with previous El Niño years. By September 2026, the cumulative burned area had reached 38% higher than the 1.39 million hectares recorded by the same month in 2019 and more than double the 8,86,172 hectares recorded in 2023. **(Chart 2)**

The fires are spread across Indonesia's vast archipelago, extending beyond traditional hotspots in Sumatra and Kalimantan. Papua Selatan recorded the highest number of hotspots in the October 28-29 period, which coincided with nationwide protests **(Map 1)**. Burned-area figures also show a sharp escalation between July and September in several provinces, with Papua Selatan, Kalimantan Barat, and Nusa Tenggara Timur among the worst affected by September. **(Chart 3)**

The Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA) estimated that air pollution-related deaths rose 42%, from 3,740 in August to 5,310 in September, in Indonesia.

Of the September deaths, an estimated 3,560 were linked to smoke from forest and land fires, while 1,750 were attributed to non-fire sources, including urban and industrial pollution **(Chart 4)**. The number of people exposed to unhealthy or hazardous air reached a monthly record of 58 million, up 40% from August. CREA also estimated that high PM2.5 exposure triggered 3,33,470 acute respiratory infection cases across seven fire-affected provinces, with children under five accounting for nearly a quarter.

The effects of the fires extend beyond areas directly affected by the flames, worsening respiratory illnesses and air pollution in neighbouring Malaysia and Singapore. With private firms in Indonesia coming under heavy criticism for contributing to the fires with their 'slash and burn' activities to clear vast tracts of land, Singapore has initiated action under its Transboundary Haze Pollution Act. The foreign ministers of Indonesia and Singapore, after their meeting on October 27, said that the two countries will explore setting up a joint task force to deal with haze from Indonesia's forest fires.

Smoke and fury

Data for the charts were sourced from Nusantara Atlas FireWatch and Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), an independent research organisation that produces data and analysis on air pollution and its health impacts



Fighting flames: A man uses a tree branch to fight a peatland fire in Central Kalimantan, Indonesia, on October 22, 2026. AFP

MAP 1: The distribution of fire hotspots across **Indonesian provinces** on October 28-29, 2026, around the nationwide protests over the government's handling of the fires and resulting haze

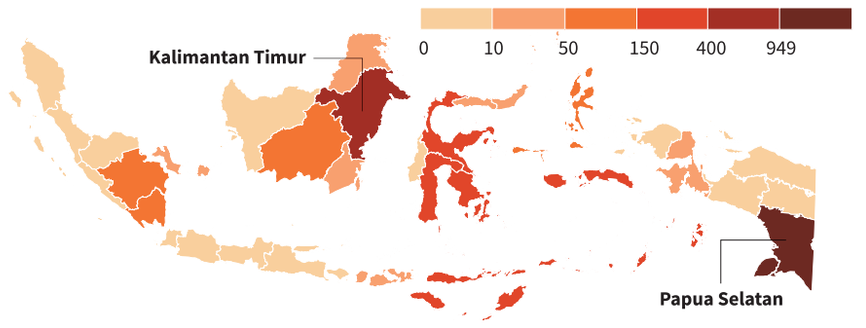


CHART 1: Hotspot counts in Indonesia from 2019 to 2026. Data for 2026 is as of October 31. Hotspots are satellite detected thermal anomalies that may indicate active fires They are indicators of fire activity, not direct counts of individual fires



CHART 2: Monthly progression of cumulative burned area in Indonesia every year since 2019 from January to December. 2026 data is till September. (in million hectares)

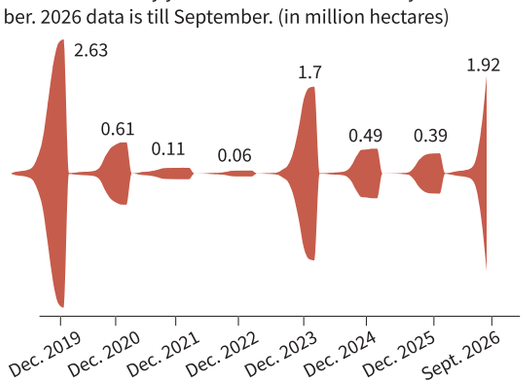


CHART 3: Month-wise cumulative burned area across the 10 Indonesian provinces with the highest record in 2026

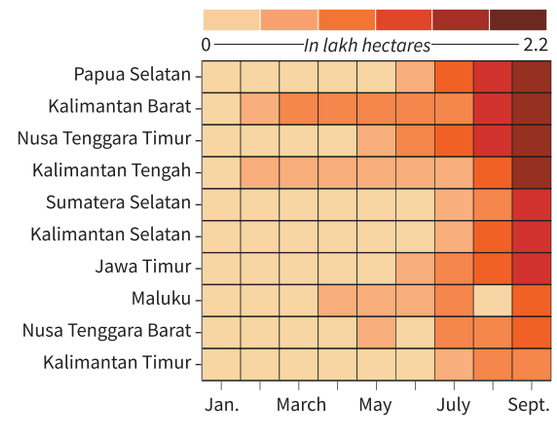
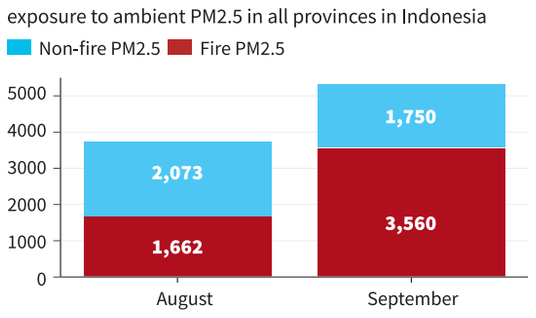


CHART 4: Non-accidental deaths attributable to short-term exposure to ambient PM2.5 in all provinces in Indonesia



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 3, 1976

Soviet Cars for Malaysia

SINGAPORE, Nov. 2.: The Soviet Union might assemble its cars in Malaysia and was now seeking to export Moskvich cars to the country, the Soviet Ambassador in Kuala Lumpur, Mr. Bendryshev, said last weekend. All plans for import of cars were ready and only the Government's license was required, he added. "We have got the technical equipment, diesel engines, aircraft and ships to name a few for export," he said.

The Soviet Union was keen on co-operating with Malaysia to help it to implement its Third Plan by supplying technical expertise and equipment. It was willing to help in energy producing projects, deepening fishing port construction and irrigation projects, he said. Trade expansion and economic co-operation with foreign countries were in line with Russia's latest five-year plan to produce more goods for export.

Eleven scholarships were awarded annually to Malaysian students by Russia, but many of these were not utilised though nearly 40,000 foreign students studied in Russia, he said. The Soviet Union buys large quantities of rubber.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO NOVEMBER 3, 1926

Tutankh-Amen's Tomb: Contents of the Second Chamber

CAIRO, Nov. 2.: The newspaper *Siasash* learns from a trustworthy source that the contents of the third chamber of Tutankh-Amen's tomb have recently been opened and while they are not so rich and fine as those of the other two chambers they are of great historical importance, because they represent everything used for the funeral ceremony. Thirty small boats of two kinds were found, one sort being that used for funerals for journeying from Luxor across the Nile to the tombs and the other sort intended to transport the body from the earth to heaven. A very interesting box of small statuettes has also been found having Tutankh-Amen's head but the body of a bird or animal, giving the Egyptian conception after life and two chariots have been found unornamented. They were supposed to have been used during hunting. These are the first of their kind ever discovered.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Case property items that went missing from Kochi court

124 As many as 124 case property items, including a Rado watch, have gone missing from the property room of a magistrate court, police said on Monday. The incident was reported from the Judicial First Class Magistrate Court-II on Park Avenue Road in Ernakulam. PTI

T.N. deploys electricity dept. personnel to restore power in A.P.

500 Tamil Nadu government has deployed 500 electricity department personnel in 25 teams to assist Andhra Pradesh in restoring power supply disrupted by Cyclone Murasu, following a request from Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu. PTI

Rainfall deficit recorded across Meghalaya in October

85 in per cent. Meghalaya received just 38.3 mm of rainfall in October, nearly 85% below the monthly normal of 255 mm, the India Meteorological Department said on Monday. The latest shortfall comes after a deficient southwest monsoon, during which the State recorded a 60% deficit. PTI

Worth of contracts sealed to procure 8 warships for Navy

53,866 in ₹ crore. The Defence Ministry on Monday said it has sealed contracts worth ₹53,866 crore with two State-run shipbuilders to procure eight next generation warships for the Indian Navy to bolster its combat prowess. PTI

Rise in Russia's LNG exports recorded for January-October

13.4 in per cent. Russia's liquefied natural gas exports rose to 28.0 million metric tonnes in the first 10 months of 2026, 13.4% higher than last year, due to supplies from the Arctic LNG 2 project, LSEG data showed. REUTERS

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What is the role of Legislative Councils?

What is the constitutional basis for Legislative Councils in the States? What were the arguments for and against? How are members elected and nominated? What powers do Legislative Councils have in relation to Legislative Assemblies? What reforms did the Second Administrative Reforms Commission propose?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:
Elections to 28 Legislative Council seats were held last week in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra and Karnataka. The exchanges among political parties and their leaders, including the Prime Minister, following the election results had piqued public curiosity about Legislative Councils.

Legislative Councils in British India
The Government of India Act, 1935 introduced bicameral legislatures in six large provinces of Madras, Bombay, Bengal, the United Provinces, Bihar and Assam. The electoral college for these councils was highly restricted and elitist, granting voting rights to only a very wealthy or educated minority.

They were to act as a revising chamber to review the work of Provincial Legislative Assemblies. These councils were not subject to dissolution, and the term of individual members was nine years, with one-third of members retiring every three years. Interestingly, these Legislative Councils had equal powers with the Legislative Assemblies with respect to passage of bills. If there was any disagreement, or if a bill was kept pending in the council for 12 months, the Governor may resolve such deadlock only by summoning a joint sitting of the provincial Assembly and Council.

Constituent Assembly debates
The debates around constituting Legislative Councils in States were highly contested in the Constituent Assembly. Some members favoured it on the ground that it would act as a check and balance against hasty legislation by popularly elected Legislative Assemblies. Others



BJP leaders celebrate after winning four seats in Karnataka Legislative Council polls, on October 28. PTI

viewed it as an unnecessary burden on the public exchequer. There were also objections to leaving out most important aspects of the constitution of Legislative Councils to ordinary legislation of Parliament without clearly specifying them in the Constitution itself. Finally, after considerable debate, the provisions with respect to Legislative Councils were adopted.

Structure of State councils
Article 168 of the Constitution provides that the State legislature of Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka shall have a Legislative Council.

Article 169 stipulates that Parliament may by ordinary law provide for the abolition or creation of a Legislative Council in a State. However, Parliament may pass such a law only if the Legislative Assembly of the State passes a resolution to that effect by a two-thirds majority.

Article 171 provides that the maximum number of members in a council shall not exceed one-third of the total membership of the Legislative Assembly, subject to a minimum of 40. The members of the council shall be elected as follows: one-third by municipality and local body members; one-twelfth by graduates for at least three years; one-twelfth by secondary school teachers for at least three years; one-third by MLAs of the State; and the remaining one-sixth to be nominated. Article 172 provides that the Legislative Council in a State is not subject to dissolution, and the term of individual members is six years, with one-third of members retiring every two years.

The ministers in a State, including the Chief Minister, can be from its Legislative Council, just like ministers in the Centre can be from the Rajya Sabha.

However, when it comes to legislative procedure, the council does not have significant powers. There is no requirement for a joint sitting to break any deadlock between the Assembly and Council with respect to bills. In case of disagreement, the bill as passed by the Assembly is considered final, with the Council only having the option to delay the passage of a bill for a maximum of four months.

Issues and way forward
The abolition or creation of Legislative Councils in the past has been primarily driven by political considerations. For instance, the Tamil Nadu Legislative Council was abolished in 1986 when M. G. Ramachandran was the Chief Minister. There was a resolution in the assembly to re-establish it in 2010 when M. Karunanidhi was the Chief Minister. However, before the Parliamentary law for creation could be notified, the Assembly in 2011 had passed a resolution against the revival of the council when J. Jayalalithaa became Chief Minister. Similarly, the Andhra Pradesh council was abolished in 1985 when N. T. Rama Rao became the Chief Minister, only to be later created again in 2007.

The second Administrative Reforms Commission (ARC) in its report on Local Governance (2007) had proposed that Parliament may, by law, create a Legislative Council in all States as 'Council of local governments'. It argued that, given the country's increased literacy rates, there was no longer a need for a separate electorate of graduates and teachers. Instead, all the members of the council can be elected solely by local body representatives.

The second ARC's recommendation may be deliberated and suitably implemented. Despite limited legislative powers of the council, this arrangement may enable it to function as an effective 'revising house', protecting and empowering the interests of local bodies. Otherwise, they may as well be abolished in the existing six States, rather than remaining as a mere ornament in those State legislatures.

(Rangarajan R is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified.' He currently trains at Officers IAS Academy. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

- Legislative Councils were envisaged as revising chambers to check hasty legislation by State Assemblies, but their creation and abolition have often been driven by political considerations
- Though the Constitution provides for their composition, tenure, and role, Legislative Councils have limited legislative powers and can only delay the passage of bills
- The Second Administrative Reforms Commission recommended transforming them into councils of local governments, with members elected solely by local body representatives, to strengthen local self-government

How are enumerators being trained for Census 2027?

What are the new questions? What are enumerators being told to ask about Aadhaar and caste?

Vijaita Singh

The story so far:
Before door-to-door enumeration for the second phase of the Census begins in Uttar Pradesh and three other poll-bound States of Uttarakhand, Goa, and Punjab on December 1, ahead of the rest of the country in January 2027, field trainers are preparing enumerators for the challenging task ahead. The second phase of the Census, the Population Enumeration, will ask 40 questions, and the enumerators need to spend at least 20-25 minutes with each respondent.

Why is training important?
Door-to-door enumeration for the Census will involve 34 lakh enumerators, mostly government school teachers. However, on October 16, the government expanded the definition of "any person" who could be appointed as Census enumerators, authorising the appointment of private school teachers and members of "institutions, societies and trusts."

On September 9, Mritunjay Kumar Narayan, Registrar General of India and Census Commissioner, wrote to all States and Directors of Census Operations that Census is not merely an administrative and statistical exercise but is one of the empirical foundations for building Viksit Bharat. "Training is therefore not just a preparatory step; it is in itself a contribution to the national vision in producing quality data," it said.

As this is the first digital census, enumerators will record the data through an app on their phones.

"To improve interactions with households, the government introduced a framework called PRAMAN, comprising Pehchaan (Identity), Rishta (Rapport), Anurodh (Request), Madad (Assistance), Aankada Shuddhata (Data Accuracy), and Nishtha (Commitment). The framework will be embedded across all levels of training and reinforced through a Seva Bhav pledge administered to enumerators and supervisors," the circular said.

What is the training pyramid's structure?
Subject matter experts are appointed as National Trainers, who in turn train Master Trainers. Master Trainers train Field Trainers, who then impart training to enumerators and supervisors, ideally in batches of 35-50. The September 9 letter stated that hands-on practice with the Population Enumeration mobile app is mandatory for all.

Why are enumerators being asked to be sensitive?
In the September 9 circular, Mr. Kumar said that while Phase I training had established a digitally proficient Census workforce, Population Enumeration would require officials to engage with respondents on a wider range of sensitive issues, including religion, language, caste, disability, migration, economic activity and fertility.

Training modules will cover caste, fertility and religion-related questions. According to the circular, the quality, completeness and integrity of Census data will depend directly on the effectiveness of training provided to Census personnel.

The circular said Population Enumeration will require enumerators to ask questions relating to religion, mother tongue, Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribe status, caste, disability, migration, fertility and economic activity, among other subjects. It instructed trainers to place special emphasis on these categories and on the correct application of coding and probing techniques.

What are the peculiar questions asked?
On August 14, the RG & CCI notified a set of 40 questions to be asked during the Population Enumeration phase, or the second phase of the Census, adding 13 new questions or data fields that were not part of the Census 2011 questionnaire. Some of the additional questions – such as particulars of mother and father, including their names, religion and place of birth; Aadhaar, mobile, voter ID and driving license details – mirror those asked in the rehearsal form of the National Population Register in 2019.

What are field trainers telling the enumerators?
At a training session in Uttar Pradesh, a field trainer explained the importance of Question number 37, which seeks the respondent's Aadhaar number, if available. The trainer told the enumerators that if a respondent is hesitant, they should nudge and convince them that Aadhaar cannot be used for any other purpose without biometric authentication of the user, and that the information provided during the Census is confidential.

"If any respondent raises an issue, they should be told that the question is intended only to determine how many people possess an Aadhaar card. If we get the accurate information during the Census, then in the future this document may act as proof of citizenship," the trainer said.

A senior Census official, however, told *The Hindu* that "no such instructions" have been passed to the trainers. "There is no instruction to link Aadhaar with the citizenship test. The question is optional; if a person says that he or she has or does not have Aadhaar, it will be recorded as such," the Census official said.

Another question where the enumerators were told to be cautious was question number 10C, which asks for the caste of the respondent. "You have to manually write the caste, as you are being told; there will be no drop-down box with options. It is a sensitive question, and your job is not to argue or provide any commentary on the issue," the field trainer told the enumerators. "There will be no separate column for OBCs (Other Backward Classes)," he added.

Other than Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribes, who can choose the names from a predetermined drop-down box, all others will have to type the caste name in an open column. This is Independent India's first caste enumeration. Question number 10 (C) says: "If not SC/ST in this State/U.T.,-Enter Caste name." There are two other options besides the Caste column – "Does not want to declare Caste" and "No Caste." The data fields are marked "mandatory".

ABSTRACT

How smoking sets the stage for lung cancer, glimpsed in new study

Chronic smoke exposure alters lung stem cells and weakens their safety mechanisms and local immune defences, creating a precancerous state; common KRAS and TP53 mutations triggered tumours only in smoke-conditioned tissue, showing how smoking primes cells for cancer

Anirban Mukhopadhyay

Na Wang, Raksha Padaki, Sara-Jayne Thursby and Michelle Vaz, 'Chronic Cigarette Smoke Exposure Induces Distinct Stem Cell States Driving Genetic Driver-specific Non-small Cell Lung Cancer Subtypes', Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, Vol. 123, Issue No. 42, October 5, 2026



GETTY IMAGES

Oncologists have long wrestled with a conundrum. Healthy human tissue often carries mutations that can drive cancer, but the tissue itself does not develop tumours. Clearly, a genetic spark alone is not enough. At the same time, chronic inflammation from smoking profoundly damages lung tissue long before any definitive cancer-causing mutations even take root.

How then does smoking increase the risk of lung cancer?

Results published in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* on October 5 have reported a crucial missing link.

'Change the soil'

Using lab-grown lung organoids, researchers showed that chronic exposure to cigarette smoke can prime certain lung stem cells into a 'precancerous' state by turning off their safety switches and dulling local immune defences.

This long-term inflammatory stress does not instantly form a tumour in the body. Instead, it prepares cells so that when common genetic mutations eventually occur, they can trigger the onset of a cancer.

If we think of normal lung cells as "healthy seeds", the research shows how long-term smoke exposure gradually changes the "soil around them", Sendurai Mani, a professor of translational oncology at Brown University and who was not involved in the study, said.

The findings have a significant implication for India. In a May 2020 analysis of 1,862 patients, a team at AIIMS New Delhi identified adenocarcinoma and squamous cell carcinoma as the country's most common lung cancers – the exact two subtypes formed by smoke-primed cells in the new study.

Understanding how persistent, low-grade inflammatory stress sets the stage for cancer is also critical because a substantial proportion of India's lung cancer cases occur among non-smokers exposed to severe air pollution and biomass smoke from traditional cooking stoves.

Tissue decline

To track how normal lung tissue deteriorates, the researchers, at the Johns Hopkins University School of Medicine and the Van Andel Research Institute in the U.S., turned to lung organoids – microscopic, three-dimensional 'mini-lungs' grown in the laboratory from mouse and human lung tissue.

The team treated these organoids with a liquid extract containing the chemical components and toxins of cigarette smoke for up to six months. Then they compared them to a group of unexposed organoids.

Within one to three months, certain cells in the smoke-exposed organoids grew significantly faster and formed denser, more crowded clusters than the controls. This growth came at a cost to normal cellular function. Stem cells destined to mature into either the airway lining or fragile alveolar air sacs expanded rapidly and adopted an altered, injury-like identity.

Simultaneously, the numbers of specialised cells that usually keep airways clean steadily declined. The lab-grown tissue became trapped in a disordered, unhealed state known as metaplasia, akin to how skin forms a thick callus in response to repeated friction.

Reprogramming cells

During the six months, the cells did not spontaneously acquire the traditional mutations that drive cancer. Instead, the smoke inflicted its damage through epigenetic changes – a bit like reprogramming a computer, explained Michelle Vaz, an oncologist at Johns Hopkins and a study co-author. The cell's underlying DNA hardware remains largely intact but the software instructions dictating how it should behave change.

By scanning how the cells packaged their DNA, the team discovered that chronic smoke caused the regulatory regions of genes crucial to a cell's survival to shut down. Chief among these silenced genes was *Zbp1*, a master sensor that detects cellular stress and initiates a process that forces damaged cells to self-destruct. As these instructions change, the cells "lose some of their normal controls," Dr. Vaz said.

The smoke-conditioned tissue also affected its environment. When grown alongside macrophages, the immune system's patrol cells, the altered lung cells coaxed them to switch sides, turning the cancer-fighters into accomplices that help abnormal cells hide.

Genetic spark

To test if these changes could really prepare the cells for malignancy, the researchers introduced two of the most common genetic alterations seen in human non-small cell lung cancer. They engineered different batches of the six-month organoids to carry either a cancer-driving mutation in the *Kras* gene or the loss of the *Tp53* tumour suppressor gene. Then they implanted these organoids into mice to see if they would grow into actual tumours.

Smoke exposure alone was not enough to trigger cancer in the animals. Introducing either mutation into healthy, unexposed organoids also failed to produce tumours. Instead, the tumours formed exclusively when the mutations were introduced to organoids that had already been conditioned to chronic smoke.

The two mutations also set off changes along different pathways: the *Kras* mutation acted on stem cells deeper in the lungs, giving rise to lung adenocarcinoma, while the loss of *Tp53* targeted stem cells in the airway lining and produced squamous cell carcinoma.

Biological memory

Instead of viewing cancer as an inevitable consequence of random DNA mutations, the findings suggest chronic smoke is essentially "preparing the ground for cancer", as Dr. Vaz noted, making distinct pools of stem cells uniquely vulnerable to certain genetic mutations.

Translating these lab-grown insights into actual human treatments or screening tools will not be easy. Human lung cancer is a very complex, decades-long process, Nithya Ramnath, professor of medicine at the University of Michigan, said. She pointed out that artificially engineering mutations in a lab dish bypasses the messy reality of how human bodies naturally acquire mutations, repair tissues, and conduct immune surveillance over a lifetime.

And while the study offers clues into one conundrum, Prof. Ramnath cautioned that a "critical unanswered question remains": why only a minority of individuals exposed to decades of heavy smoking ultimately develop lung cancer while some who have never smoked do.

Until researchers can unravel that mystery in real human populations, she said, the findings should be regarded as "hypothesis generating rather than actionable".

(Anirban Mukhopadhyay is a geneticist by training and science communicator from New Delhi)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

From the launch of Sputnik 2 to Laika's historic journey, test your knowledge of one of the most significant and poignant episodes of the early Space Race

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1
When was Sputnik 2 launched into space?

QUESTION 2
Which country launched Sputnik 2, and what was its significance in the history of space exploration?

QUESTION 3
Why was Sputnik 2 developed in such a short period after Sputnik 1?

QUESTION 4
Which rocket was used to launch Sputnik 2?

QUESTION 5
How were the dogs trained to adapt to the cramped conditions inside Sputnik 2?



Visual Question:
Laika, a stray mongrel selected for the mission, became the first animal to orbit Earth. How long after launch did telemetry from her vital-sign sensors cease, and what was eventually established as the cause of her death? MEMORIAL MUSEUM OF COSMONAUTICS

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. Why is National Unity Day celebrated every year in India? **Ans: Commemoration of the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel**
2. When was Rashtriya Ekta Diwas introduced by the government? **Ans: 2014**
3. What was the core objective of the day? **Ans: To reaffirm the nation's strength, resilience, and commitment to unity**
4. Name one of the key events conducted on National Unity Day? **Ans: Mass public runs organised by States and U.T.s**
5. When was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's 150th birth anniversary celebrated? **Ans: 2025**
6. How many years did Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel serve as the Home Minister? **Ans: 1947-50**
7. What is the height of the Statue of Unity (in metres), one of the world's tallest statues, overlooking Sardar Sarovar Dam in Gujarat? **Ans: 182 metres**
Visual: Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated this Statue of Unity in which year? **Ans: 2018**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Mohan Lal Patel | Piyali Tuli | Lalchand Bhutani | Sumana Dutta



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference between "friend" and "companion"? (S. Sateesh, Bangalore)
The meaning of the word "friend" has undergone several changes. I understand that during Shakespeare's time the word was used to refer to one's mistress! Nowadays, of course, the word "friend" is used to refer to someone whom you have known for some time and with whom you have a reasonably good relationship. The individual could be someone in whom you confide; a person to whom you tell your problems. In the case of a friend there is an emotional bonding, but there does not have to be physical proximity. You and your friend need not be together all the time.

A "companion", on the other hand, is an ambiguous term. This individual could be like a friend in that he/she may be very close to you. For example, Dr. Watson was Holmes' constant companion; he went wherever the great detective went. They got along famously and they were good friends. The word "companion" can also be used to refer to someone who accompanies you on a journey. You may talk to him, share food with him, but once you get off the train/bus, you may never see him again. While the word "friend" stresses the emotional bonding between individuals, "companion" stresses the physical presence of the individual being referred to.

How do you pronounce "rendezvous"? (D. Priyanka, Hyderabad)
The "e" in the first syllable is pronounced like the "o" in "pot", and "lot", while the "ez" in the second syllable is like the "i" in "sit", and "bit". The final "ous" is like the "oo" in "fool", and "pool". The main stress is on the first syllable. Any idea what the word means? When you "rendezvous" with someone, you agree to meet the individual at a specific time and place. For example,

The young couple will rendezvous at the park this afternoon at 5:00 o'clock.

The new coffee house has become a rendezvous for college students.

What is the meaning of the idiom "under a cloud"? (N. Balasubramanian, Sholinghur)
When you say that someone is under a cloud, what it implies is that people are suspicious or have a poor opinion of the individual because they think that he has done something bad. In our country, politicians are always under a cloud. Here is are a few examples.

Rohit left the firm under a cloud.

The firm's reputation is under a cloud at the moment.

Is it ok to say "My Mrs."? (Vasu, Kakinada)
In India it is fairly common for a man to refer to his wife as his "Mrs." "My Mrs. is not feeling well" is a sentence that one hears very often. Friends often ask, "How is your Mrs.?" or "How is your family?". The word "family" is often used to refer to the wife as well. Indians use these expressions in both formal and informal contexts. A native speaker of English does use the word "Mrs." to refer to his wife, but he does so usually in informal contexts. He uses the word jocularly; and never in formal contexts. When talking about his wife, a native speaker refers to her as "my wife" or calls her by her name.
Published in The Hindu on June 4, 2002

Word of the day

Modicum:
a small or moderate or token amount

Synonyms: iota, smidge, trace, pinch

Usage: *There was not even a modicum of doubt in her mind.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/modicum

International Phonetic Alphabet: /mɒdɪkəm/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Manufacturing PMI eases in Oct., export orders hit high

Activity in the manufacturing sector slowed in October 2026 compared with its level in September, according to a private sector survey. However, new orders rose strongly, driven by orders from abroad rising to their highest level in six months, it said. The private sector HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index fell to 54.7 in October 2026 as compared with 55.1 in September. The report said growth eased only marginally from September's seven-month high and remained strong by historical standards.

Petronet LNG's net profit jumps 53.2% to ₹1,235 crore

State-owned Petronet LNG reported 53.2% growth in net profit in the September-ended quarter, driven by improved operational efficiency although cargoes from its most prominent supplier, Qatar, continued to be affected because of the reignited conflict in West Asia. The company also declared a dividend of ₹7 per equity share. The country's largest LNG importer's net profit stood at ₹1,235 crore in the reported quarter against ₹806 crore in the same period last year.

Vultr unveils 20-MW AI supercluster in Chennai

U.S.-based cloud infrastructure provider Vultr on Monday announced the unveiling of a 20-MW AI supercluster in Chennai, powered by AMD Instinct MI355X GPUs, marking its largest such deployment in India. The facility, expected to house around 10,000 GPUs in its initial configuration, will be among Vultr's two largest AMD AI infra deployments globally, alongside its Springfield facility in Ohio. Vultr plans to expand capacity in 2027 with AMD's MI455X GPUs and Helios rack-scale AI architecture.

Capex push to sustain, but fiscal prudence is non-negotiable: FM

Ms. Sitharaman asks why experts who considered their own sectors healthy remained apprehensive about the broader economy

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI



Union Minister of Finance & Corporate Affairs Nirmala Sitharaman speaks during an HSBC event in Mumbai on Monday. ANI

Union Finance and Corporate Affairs Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday reaffirmed the government's commitment to sustaining capital expenditure (capex) to support economic growth, while stressing that fiscal prudence would remain non-negotiable.

"Capex is a very important component of our growth strategy. Because till such time the private sector will be able to expand capacity or make capital investment, it is important for the government to push through with capital investment," she said at an event organised by HSBC India in Mumbai.

Pointing to the returns from public investment over the past four to five years, the FM said the multiplier effects had strengthened the government's confidence in continuing the spending push.

"We find that in the last 4 to 5 years, we have got very good success. The multipliers actually work and it gives us confidence that the government is not going to sit back and watch whether growth is growing without doing much," Ms. Sitharaman said.

The government would be willing to extend capex support to ensure that the growth momentum was not disrupted.

"We will continue doing that because India's growth momentum should not be lost at all," she said.

However, she made it clear that higher public spending would have to be balanced against fiscal constraints. "We need to be fiscally prudent," she said, adding that while some advocated spending without worrying about sovereign credit ratings, responsible expenditure was essential.

"India must talk with optimism and there needs to be reduction in cynicism," she said, questioning why experts who considered their own sectors healthy remained apprehensive about the broader economy.

'Chandra's reappointment has sullied Tata Sons' image'

Aneesh Phadnis
MUMBAI

Tata Sons board's September 17 decision to grant N. Chandrasekaran a third term as chairman has sullied the company's reputation, outgoing Tata Trusts board member Darius Khambata has said.

Mr. Khambata expressed this view in a letter to Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata while declining another term in office.

"The sad events of September 17, 2026, a day that will live in infamy, have sullied Tata Sons' reputation and imperilled the image of corporate India. No amount of spin doctoring can mask what happened," Mr. Khambata wrote on Monday.

"Would the board of Tata Sons have acted as it did on September 17 had Ratan Tata still been alive? Of course not. But duties are owed to institutions, not individuals. And as Ratan Tata used to say, the institution is always bigger than the individual," he said.

Tata himself has opposed Mr. Chandrasekaran's reappointment and has termed the board's decision void. Mr. Khambata, a senior lawyer, has been a trustee of the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT), the two key shareholders of Tata Sons, since 2023. Within the organisation, Mr. Khambata has been an ally of Noel Tata on issues such as retaining Tata Sons' private status.



> Would the board of Tata Sons have acted as it did on September 17 had Ratan Tata still been alive? Of course not.
>
> **DARIUS KHAMBATA,** Outgoing Tata Trusts board member

The issue has divided the trusts, with fellow board members Vijay Singh and Venu Srinivasan supporting a share sale.

The SRTT continues to be under a regulatory ban. Mr. Khambata's term at SDTT was due to end in November, and he is believed to have opted against reappointment in anticipation of opposition from Srinivasan and Singh. An executive with the trusts said Tata continues to hold a majority within the trusts despite Mr. Khambata's exit.

Tata Sons declined to comment on Mr. Khambata's letter. In his letter, Mr. Khambata highlighted key resolutions, including those opposing the listing of Tata Sons shares.

"Since May 2025, I have consistently maintained that opposition to listing must go hand in hand with providing liquidity to the Shapoorji Pallonji group through the sale of some or all of their shares," he wrote. He also criticised Mr. Singh and Mr. Srinivasan for working against the trusts. "It is now untenable to argue that a nominee director of a public charitable trust, particularly a serving trustee, may act against the trust's interests merely because he owes a duty to the company. He sits on the board precisely to protect the trusts. There cannot be two classes of trustees, those who are nominee directors and those who are not. All trustees owe an equal fiduciary duty to the trust," he said.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Indices end 2% higher on Monday, RIL posts best gains since 2020

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Benchmark indices soared for the third consecutive trading day on Monday and settled higher despite paring some gains.

Sensex ended 1,233 points higher at 75,682.78, while the Nifty 50 closed 387.70 points higher at 23,440, both up 1.7%.

"Benchmark indices extended their winning streak to a third consecutive session. Reliance Industries led the rally following its Q2 results, while broad-based buying across sectors and sustained participation in large-cap stocks supported the positive momentum. The broader market also witnessed healthy buying interest," Pabitro Mukherjee, deputy VP - Research at Bajaj Broking said in a note.

Reliance Industries marked its highest level since over six years and jumped 11.6% following a higher-than-expected earnings for Q2 FY27.

The rally lifted major sectors including energy, metals, PSU banks and automakers while IT, Media and Pharmaceuticals remained laggards.

Strong corporate earnings for the quarter ended September has lifted investor sentiments despite uncertainty surrounding the West Asia conflict. According to estimates by Motilal Oswal Financial Services, as of October 31, earnings of 35 Nifty companies which have disclosed their financial results have grown 22% on year led by Reliance Industries, JSW Steel, ICICI Bank, Coal India and Axis bank. Crude prices too declined in early trade following progress in West Asia peace talks.

Centre stalling Vedanta arbitration awards enforcement, says SC

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI


In 2014, the Centre sought to recover $64 mn from Vedanta and $35 m from Ravva Oil.

The Supreme Court dismissed the Centre's challenge to a Delhi High Court order allowing mining major Vedanta Ltd. and Ravva Oil (Singapore) Pte. Ltd. to enforce foreign arbitration awards involving claims of almost $99 million. The SC questioned the Centre's resistance to the enforcement of the awards, warning such delays could undermine India's standing as an arbitration hub.

A Bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and Manmohan questioned why the government continued to oppose enforcement, particularly when India was seeking to position itself as a preferred venue for international arbitration.

"You are frustrating an arbitral award like this? At the stage of enforcement of it? And we talk about all of this arbitration and seat and this and that?... Nobody will trust you," the Bench remarked.

'Prolonged dispute'

The Bench also took note of the prolonged nature of the dispute, pointing out the first arbitral award was rendered in 2004 followed by the final award in 2016. It ultimately found no reason to interfere with the Delhi HC's July 1 judgment rejecting Centre's objections to the enforcement of the awards passed by an arbitral tribunal seated in Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia.

"We are of the view no error, not to speak of any error of law, could be said to have been committed by the High Court in passing the impugned judgment and order," the Bench said, dismissing the appeal.

The dispute dates back to a 1994 production-sharing contract for the development of Ravva oilfield in the Krishna-Godavari basin. The agreement was signed between the Centre and a consortium comprising ONGC, Videocon Petroleum, Ravva Oil and Cairn Energy. Cairn Energy's stake in the project later passed to Cairn India and later to Vedanta.

At the heart of the dispute was how payments towards costs previously incurred by the ONGC in developing the oilfield were to be accounted for while calculating the firms' share of revenue from oil output. The matter was referred to arbitration in Kuala Lumpur under Malaysian law and the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law (UNCITRAL) Arbitration Rules.

Partial award

In October 2004, the arbitral tribunal delivered a partial award, deciding two of the six questions in favour of the firms and four in favour of the government while leaving the amount payable towards the ONGC's earlier costs to be determined later. The Centre challenged the award in Malaysia. Though it was set aside by the Kuala Lumpur High Court in 2009, the decision was reversed on appeal and the award was ultimately upheld by the Malaysian Federal Court in 2011.

In 2014, the government sought to recover about $64 million from Vedanta and $35 million from Ravva Oil. The companies contested the demands and returned to arbitration with a reconstituted tribunal delivering final award in 2016. The Centre again challenged the award, but the Malaysian Federal Court upheld it in February 2019.

Vedanta and Ravva Oil then moved the Delhi HC to enforce the awards in India. The Centre opposed the plea on grounds including limitation, public policy and the tribunal becoming *functus officio* after passing the earlier award.

HC rejects objections

In July, the High Court rejected the objections, holding enforcement proceedings could not be used to reopen the underlying dispute or reconsider the tribunal's findings. It also held the proceedings were within the limitation period and directed the release of the companies' bank guarantees within eight weeks.



William Walsh

IndiGo sees flight capacity growth in Q3 despite higher jet fuel prices

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Despite elevated ATF prices, IndiGo expects capacity growth in Q3 following a quarter of cuts, said CEO William Walsh.

"We expect to grow," Mr. Walsh told the press responding to a query if more flight-capacity cuts were in the offing.

"We took a small capcity reduction in Q2, principally on international routes. Domestic capacity was flat. But, internationally, there was a 2.9% cut. But our plan for Q3 is for growth in capacity," though "jet fuel is expected to stay at very elevated levels."

On operational impact from the regional war, IndiGo cut 30 daily flights to Saudi Arabia while for the rest of the region, it is back to normal schedules.

Last week, IndiGo posted a net loss of 1,879.1 crore for Q2 of FY27.

Though higher airfares partly cushioned the impact of surging fuel costs amid geopolitical tensions in the Gulf, Mr. Walsh had said in an analyst's call that fares were only able to offset 60% of the fuel cost hike while the rest was being absorbed by the airline.

Bot battle


Engineered to win: A robot navigates a set of steps while competing in a qualifying round of the CMG World Robot Mount Tai Competition in Tai'an, in China's eastern Shandong province. AFP

Granules India net profit rises 39% to ₹182 crore

N. Ravi Kumar
HYDERABAD

Drugmaker Granules India reported 39% year-on-year (YoY) jump in consolidated net profit to ₹181.8 crore in September quarter.

The profit came on a 20% YoY increase in revenue from operations to ₹1,559.9 crore. Sequentially, however, the growth was subdued. Granules had posted ₹179.9 crore net profit and ₹1,476.7 crore revenue from operations in the June quarter.

"Our quarterly revenue has crossed ₹1,500 crore in Q2 FY27 with EBITDA of ₹338 crore despite higher input and logistics costs from tensions in West Asia," said CMD Krishna Prasad Chigurupati.

The cost pressures are expected to persist and the company will work with customers to manage them with a lag, he said.

Mr. Chigurupati sought to highlight Granules is well positioned in its transition towards complex generics and peptide CDMO. The company backed by ₹828 crore net cash plans to invest in research and development, manufacturing and quality.

On Monday, Granules shares closed 2.38% at ₹819.55 apiece on the BSE.

Dr. Reddy's gets nod for HIV drug lenacapavir

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Dr. Reddy's Laboratories has received U.S. Food and Drug Administration (U.S. FDA) tentative approval for twice-yearly injectable HIV prevention drug lenacapavir.

The approval was granted under the U.S. FDA's President's Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief (PEPFAR) programme. It is an important milestone and reflects the company's capabilities in developing and manufacturing complex medicines, Dr. Reddy's said on Monday.

First supplies are expected to reach people by December with broader rollout across eligible countries expected in 2027, it said, announcing the tentative approval for its long-acting injectable lenacapavir for pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) to reduce the risk of sexually acquired HIV-1 in adults and adolescents weighing at least 77 pounds (35 kg).

The approval builds on the voluntary licence granted by Gilead Sciences to Dr. Reddy's in October 2024, followed by an agreement with Unitaid, (Wits RHI) and the Clinton Health Access Initiative in September 2025.

BOJ locks in December hike but neutral rate open to debate



Tough time: People walk past the Bank of Japan (BoJ) headquarters in Tokyo. AFP

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
TOKYO

Bank of Japan (BOJ) Governor Kazuo Ueda has all but locked in a December rate hike, but left investors guessing how much further it could go once rates approach neutral territory, a largely unfamiliar setting after decades of ultra-loose policy.

Beneath the BOJ's hawkish message lies the challenge ahead. As inflationary pressures become more entrenched, policymakers must judge how quickly households and businesses, long conditioned to near-zero borrowing costs, can absorb higher rates without derailing a fragile economic recovery. The BOJ last week declared victory in its 14-year battle to hit its price target and stressed its policy has entered a new phase focused on avoiding an inflation overshoot, reinforcing its hawkish bias.

Upside price risks

Mr. Ueda said the BOJ decided to forgo a rate hike to scrutinise economic and price developments "a bit more" - language that echoed remarks made in July before the bank raised rates in September. He also said the board will debate policy focusing on upside price risks, including at the next meeting, signalling a high probability of a hike in its policy rate to 1.5% in December.

Japan's economy expanded an annualised 1.4% in the second quarter, as firms continued to boost spending despite headwinds from the Middle East conflict. Annual core inflation hit 2.1% in September, exceeding the BOJ's 2% target as mounting price pressures outweighed the dampening effect of fuel subsidies.

"Judging from the latest BOJ communication, a rate hike in December is pretty much a done deal," said former BOJ official Nobuyasu Atago, who is currently chief economist at Rakuten Securities Economic Research Institute.

"What's less clear is what happens next year because a subsequent hike would bring the BOJ's policy rate to 1.75%, which could be around levels deemed neutral to the economy."

Case for ambiguity

The source of the BOJ's ambiguity is its limited confidence over where Japan's neutral rate actually lies. BOJ staff calculations place Japan's nominal neutral rate, which neither heats up nor slows the economy, at between 1.1% and 2.5%, offering a rough guide to how far policymakers could lift borrowing costs. But like many central banks, the BOJ has been deliberately vague about where that rate sits in practice as it cannot be observed and estimates can vary depending on models used. That uncertainty explains why the BOJ is warning about inflation risks without committing to a steady march higher in rates. While warning of price pressures, Mr. Ueda has also stressed the need to watch how higher borrowing costs affect corporate and household lending.

"We're hearing that smaller firms' lending conditions are tightening, so we'll keep a close watch on whether such calls will spread," he said, while maintaining that overall financial conditions remain accommodative.

The challenge posed by uncertainty over neutral rates is more pressing for the BOJ than for its overseas counterparts. With its policy rate still at just 1.25%, officials face pressure to push borrowing costs toward neutral relatively quickly to avoid fuelling excess inflation.

Yet Japan's three-decade-long experience with deflation may also have left households and businesses unusually sensitive to higher rates, a risk the BOJ says warrants caution.

Compounding the challenge, the BOJ is navigating unfamiliar terrain. Since gaining independence in 1998, it has spent most of its existence battling disinflation and deflation, leaving it with limited experience of how an economy accustomed to ultra-low rates responds to sustained monetary tightening.

There is no consensus within the board on how far the BOJ should push up rates. Hawks like Naoki Tamura argue the neutral rate is likely near 2% and have called for steady rate increases. Another hawk, Hajime Takata, also favours faster hikes and proposed unsuccessfully on Friday a hike to 1.5%. Former academic Junko Koeda appeared more cautious, saying only the neutral rate was "likely significantly above 1%."

China's robot producers mastered the moves; now comes the race for brains

Chinese robot makers shift focus from hardware to AI brains; firms race to train robots using real-world data and simulations; China's embodied-AI sector raised $13 billion in first half of 2026; China's manufacturing and data edge could help challenge U.S. developers; the field remains crowded

FOCUS

REUTERS
BEIJING

After years of building humanoid robots capable of running, dancing and performing backflips, Chinese companies are pouring resources into a different challenge: developing the AI that could make those machines useful across a wider range of jobs.

The shift is fuelling an investment boom in embodied AI, a field focused on software that allows robots to understand their surroundings, learn unfamiliar tasks and adapt without having to be programmed for every job.

Chinese embodied AI companies raised 93.5 billion yuan ($13 billion) across 322 deals in the first half of 2026, five times the amount a year earlier, according to data research firm ITjuzi.

Funding is increasingly reaching specialist developers of robot intelligence alongside manufacturers.

As competition drives down hardware prices, robot makers have "concluded that the margin won't come from the hardware but from the brain," said Dermot McGrath, founder of Shanghai-based technology consultancy ZenGen Labs.



Outpacing humans: X Square humanoid robots at World Robot Conference, in Beijing, China. REUTERS

The emerging sector is opening a new front in U.S.-China tech rivalry. American companies lead in some advanced robot AI systems, while Chinese developers hope their manufacturing strength and access to real-world training data will help them challenge their U.S. competitors, according to *Reuters* interviews with founders and top executives at five Chinese robotics firms, as well as industry analysts.

The country that best combines AI with machines could gain an advantage in automating factories and logistics, potentially reshaping industrial productivity and the global market for robotics technology.

"The brain is indeed the weakest link in the complete robotics stack," said Spirit AI co-founder Gao Yang.

> Chinese companies can work closely with robot manufacturers and industrial customers to test and improve their systems

Race for intelligence

American startups, including Physical Intelligence, Skild AI and Generalist, are developing software intended to teach robots different skills without extensive retraining.

Generalist says its GEN-1.5 model completed around 60% of simple tasks after viewing a demonstration lasting between 3 and 12 seconds. China's X Square has published research showing robots acquiring handling skills from a single human video without retraining the model for each task.

"The leading American labs are setting a demanding benchmark, particularly in how quickly robots can acquire and reuse skills," said robotics consultant Georg Stieler, who considers China's strongest startups credible competitors.

While U.S. developers benefit from advanced AI research and greater access to powerful computing chips, Chinese companies can work closely with robot manufacturers and industrial customers to test and improve their systems.

Specialist Chinese startups, including X Square, Galaxea and Spirit AI, have each reached valuations of roughly $3 billion, according to company disclosures.

"We want robots to shift from being driven by code to being driven by common sense," said X Square co-founder and COO YangQian.

Huge pay packets

Established manufacturers are investing too. Hong-Kong-listed UBTech advertised a chief scientist position overseeing AI model development with compensation of up to 124 million yuan ($18 million), including equity and benefits. Hangzhou-based Unitree, one of the world's largest humanoid robot makers by shipments, has about 30 researchers developing AI that predicts how objects behave, according to a person briefed by the company. Unitree did not respond to a request for comment.

Unlike chatbots, which learn from vast quantities of internet text, robots need examples of physical interactions, from gripping objects to handling flexible wires. Chinese companies are pursuing different approaches to collecting that information, with some employing people to demonstrate tasks, others using computer simulations, and some combining both.

The field remains crowded, with no company establishing itself as the clear leader.

Spirit AI has hired around 1,000 people to record everyday and industrial activities, Gao said. ACE Robotics uses wearable sensors to capture workers' movements and grip forces in stores and hotels.

Ant Group's robotics unit Robbyant said it trained a model using 1,60,000 hours of material, including 50,000 hours of human-guided robot movements. It also trained software on 20robot configurations from 17 brands, aiming to use the same AI across different machines.

DexForce is taking another approach, using computer-generated environments to teach robots. Chief operating officer Nicole Yang said the company can prepare some industrial tasks for deployment within 6 to 8 hours and reported success rates above 99.9% in specified precision operations. But simulations cannot perfectly reproduce physical interactions, said Jerry Wang of spatial intelligence company Manycore Tech, which designs simulated environments for AI training. "Data quality is more important than data diversity, and more important than simply collecting data at massive scale," XSquare's Yang said.

Cloud boom, revenue increase, investor gloom: What is really worrying Alphabet shareholders?

EXPLAINER

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

Alphabet reported strong growth in the September quarter but the results also highlighted the cost of keeping pace with the artificial intelligence (AI) race.

The company is investing heavily in computing infrastructure to develop and run AI models and services. At the same time, AI is changing how people use Google Search, raising questions about how the company will continue to earn money from its biggest advertising business.

The concerns are not about whether Alphabet is growing. They are about how much it will have to spend to sustain that growth, and if its AI investments will generate enough returns.

Why net fell

Alphabet's revenue grew 25% year-on-year (YoY) to $127.6 billion in the quarter ended September 30. Operating income rose 30% to $40.6 billion. Google Cloud was a major contributor to the growth, with revenue more than doubling to $30.7 billion. It increased from $15.2 billion in the September 2025 quarter to $30.7 billion, a YoY increase of 103%.

Net profit, however, fell to $26.5 billion from $35 billion a year earlier. Alphabet's quarterly filing with the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission attributed a substantial impact on net income to losses on equity securities. The company reported a net loss of $8.7 billion on these securities, which reduced net income by $6.7 billion after tax. Its operating income, meanwhile, rose 30% to $40.6 billion.



Huge spend: Infrastructure investments, TPUs would pressure cash flows. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Why huge spend

The AI boom needs enormous computing capacity. Firms developing and deploying AI models need data centres filled with powerful servers, specialised chips and networking equipment. The facilities also need substantial power and supporting infrastructure. Alphabet is building this capacity to serve own products, including Gemini and AI-powered Search, as well as customers using Google Cloud.

The scale of its investment is reflected in its capital expenditure. Alphabet spent $51.4 billion in the September quarter, with the vast majority going towards technical infrastructure to support its AI investments.

Alphabet CFO Anat Ashkenazi said about 65% of the company's technical infrastructure investments in the September quarter went towards servers and networking equipment, while the remaining 35% was spent on data centres.

Alphabet retained its capital expenditure guidance of $195 billion to $205 billion for 2026. Ms. Ashkenazi said during the Q3 earnings call that the company's capital expenditure would increase significantly in 2027.

Why negative cash flow

The scale of this spending has begun to affect the cash Alphabet retains after investing in business.

In the September quarter, Alphabet generated $42.3 billion in cash from its operations but spent $51.4 billion on capital expenditure. This resulted in negative free cash flow of $9.1 billion.

Free cash flow is the cash left after a company deducts capital expenditure from the cash generated by its operations. It is an important measure because it indicates how much cash a company hais available with the company for other purposes, including acquisitions, debt repayment and returning money to shareholders.

Negative free cash flow does not mean Alphabet is making an operating loss. The company remained profitable, with operating income of $40.6 billion.

Ms. Ashkenazi said the company's operating cash flow was affected by inventory being built up ahead of sales of Google's Tensor Processing Unit (TPU) systems, as well as a $5.2-billion cash payment towards a fine imposed by the European Commission in 2018, following the conclusion of the appeal process.

She said the firm's investments in infrastructure and the inventory being built for TPU sales would continue to put pressure on free cash flow. Alphabet ended the quarter with $265.1 billion in cash and marketable securities.

AI changing search?

Another concern is how AI could change the way Google earns money from Search. Google's traditional Search business is built around advertising. When users search for information, Google displays advertisements alongside search results, generating revenue from advertisers.

AI-powered features are changing this experience. Google's AI Overviews provide AI-generated summaries within Search, while AI Mode allows users to ask questions in a more conversational format and pursue follow-up queries.

The challenge is whether these experiences will generate as much advertising revenue as traditional search results.

Google Search and other advertising revenue grew 12% to $63.35 billion in the September quarter. This was slower than the 17% growth reported in the previous quarter.

During the earnings call, Philipp Schindler, Google's senior vice-president and chief business officer, said the strong growth in AI Mode queries had affected advertising monetisation because the company was earning less from these queries than from traditional Search.

However, he also said foreign exchange movements were the biggest factor behind the slowdown in Search revenue growth compared with the previous quarter.

Changes in advertising spending in the retail and media and entertainment sectors also contributed.

Google is expanding advertisements in AI Overviews and AI Mode to more users and queries.

Mr. Schindler said the company's advertising experiments had shown promising results.

There is also evidence that AI is bringing more users to Search. Alphabet chief executive Sundar Pichai said the year-on-year growth in Search queries was the highest in five years. He attributed the increase partly to the company's AI investments.

This presents Google with a difficult balancing act. It wants to make Search more useful through AI while ensuring that the new experience continues to generate advertising revenue.

Cloud's AI's potential

Google Cloud is one area where Alphabet is already seeing substantial returns from demand for AI.

Its revenue grew 103% to $30.7 billion in the September quarter. Operating income increased to $11.1 billion from $3.6 billion a year earlier.

Alphabet attributed the growth to demand for AI infrastructure and enterprise AI solutions, alongside its core cloud services.

The company also said sales of its TPU systems contributed meaningfully to revenue growth.

CFO Ashkenazi said the strong demand for Google Cloud's AI infrastructure and services showed that businesses were willing to pay for such capabilities. However, expanding this capacity requires further investment.

She said the increase in technical infrastructure spending would weigh on the company's financial results through higher depreciation expenses and data centre operating costs, including energy.

She said the company expects to generate returns from its AI investments across Search, Google Cloud and subscription services such as Google One, adding that Alphabet expects its return on invested capital (ROIC) to remain meaningfully above its cost of capital throughout the investment cycle.

CAIRO

Israeli air strikes kill at least three people in Gaza Strip, medics say



AP

Israeli strikes killed at least three Palestinians in the Gaza Strip on Monday, the territory's health officials said. Two people were killed and six wounded in two separate air strikes in Khan Younis, while a third person was killed in an Israeli air strike in Al-Mussadar. Israel's military said it carried out the strikes targeting militants. REUTERS

CARACAS

19 dead in Venezuelan Army attack on camp of Colombian rebel group



AFP

At least 19 people were killed in the Venezuelan Army's recent attack on a camp of the National Liberation Army, a Colombian guerrilla group, in Venezuela's Apure, the FundaRedes NGO which tracks rights violations said. A Venezuelan military source said the attack on Friday was supported by U.S. intelligence. AFP

SANAA

Yemen's Houthis say they targeted Saudi Arabia's Dammam airport



AFP

Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis on Monday said they targeted Dammam airport in Saudi Arabia with two drones, following weeks of attacks against the oil-rich kingdom. Military spokesman Yahya Saree also claimed strikes on an early-warning radar and a military transport plane in the kingdom's southwest. AFP

TOKYO

Japan urges U.S. to discipline its troops after second Marine arrest



AFP

Japan urged the U.S. to enforce discipline among its troops after a Marine was arrested on suspicion of drink driving during a curfew in the wake of another serviceman's arrest on a murder charge, the Defence Minister said on Monday. The case has reignited debate over the heavy U.S. military presence on the island of Okinawa. AFP

Foreign policy is a local issue in midterm campaigns

Republicans argue the price rises are temporary and worth the war with Iran; tariffs, they say, are bringing manufacturing and jobs to America and opening up markets abroad; but some candidates have distanced themselves from Donald Trump, while not overtly attacking him; the number of Republicans who say Trump's policies have made the economy worse has almost doubled this year

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sriram Lakshman

As Americans vote to elect new lawmakers on Capitol Hill and at State and local levels on November 3, foreign policy issues have become enmeshed in domestic policy issues. Specifically, these issues are U.S. President Donald Trump's tariffs on trading partners, the war on Iran and, to a lower extent, U.S. support for Israel. The Iran war caused gas and diesel prices to shoot up. This, along with tariffs, has created problems for Republicans in their strongholds and challenges for Mr. Trump with his own base of manufacturing workers, business owners and farmers.

Between September 1 and October 14, campaign ads for at least half of 50 competitive Senate and House races featured Iran, according to a study by the Associated Press. The total spend on these ads was $42 million. Almost all the 65 unique ads, according to the AP study, linked the Iran war to the cost of living.

The Iran factor

In the 'battleground State' of Iowa, a group called the Vote Vets Action Fund ran an ad saying the Republican Senate candidate Ashley Hinson voted five times for the Iran war, giving Americans "record prices for gas and fertilizer".

Some Republicans are distancing themselves from the war.

"I hate war," Senator Roger Marshall of Kansas said at a debate in September. Mr. Marshall, who is defending his seat against Democratic challenger Adam Hamilton, nevertheless sought a workaround to his position on war in the Iran case, saying that if Democrats controlled the Senate, Tehran would get a nuclear weapon and the price of gas (petrol) would increase significantly.

"We should not be in the war. This man (Mr. Marshall) supported the war. I want to get us out of the war," Mr. Hamilton said to loud cheers from the crowd, as he linked the war to higher prices.

Mr. Marshall on the other hand was booed when he tried to bring up the issue of Iran's nuclear capabilities and claimed that gas prices were higher in the Presidency of Joe Biden than under Mr. Trump. The Republican was heckled again, when he tried to argue that the impact of tariffs was minimal and claimed that they were helping exports.

These exchanges happened in Kansas, a State that has not elected a Democrat to the Senate since 1932: a case in point of how foreign policy issues are challenging Republicans' grip of their strongholds. Kansas has now transformed into a battleground state for the Senate. It is not surprising then that Mr. Trump made an 11th hour visit to Kansas, campaigning there over the weekend, on the eve of the elections.



Hitting the circuits: U.S. President Donald Trump and his Republican Party are making last-gasp pitches to voters ahead of the crucial election. REUTERS

U.S. support for Israel has also featured on the campaign. In Michigan, where Democrats are defending their Senate seat, a group supporting progressive Democratic candidate Abdul El-Sayed ran an ad showing a couple discussing what they could buy at a grocery store.

"We have to set that $7 aside for killing Palestinians," the woman says, as she tells the man to put back a carton of eggs. (Some have called the ad antisemitic).

The issue of U.S. support for Israel continues to divide within the Democratic party as well. This past weekend, former Democratic primary candidate Haley Stevens endorsed Mr. Rogers rather than her colleague, Mr. El-Sayed. At the heart of their differences is the U.S. relationship with Israel.

The 'necessary' war

Republican candidates and Mr. Trump have argued that the price rises are temporary and worth the war with Iran, which they have said was necessary. On tariffs, they have argued that it is bringing manufacturing and jobs to America, while opening up markets abroad. Nevertheless, some candidates have distanced themselves from Mr. Trump, while not overtly attacking the President.

In Mississippi last week, Mr. Trump defended tariffs, arguing they were bringing manufacturing back to the U.S. "They [tariffs] don't cause inflation. You know what they cause?" he asked, rhetorically. "Success. They cause growth. They cause jobs," he added.

On Iran, almost three quarters of Americans are "very worried" or "extremely worried" about the war's consequences for gas and fuel prices, according to a survey from Gallup published in early October. Eighty-five percent of Democrats and 61% of Republicans share this concern. More generally, the number of Republicans who say that Mr. Trump's policies have made the economy worse has almost doubled (18% to 35%) since the start of the year.

While foreign policy issues may not directly be driving voting decisions, their second-order impacts via the economy and cost of living are certainly at the top of voters' minds.

Iran ready to reopen Hormuz if U.S. agrees to demands: Baqaei

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Iran on Monday said it was ready to reopen the Strait of Hormuz within two days if Washington agrees to conditions, as U.S. President Donald Trump issued his latest war threat at a rally for midterm elections.

Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmaeil Baqaei said the offer to open the vital energy corridor showed "good faith".

Tehran has blockaded Hormuz since the war started in February, sending energy prices soaring and posing an electoral challenge for Mr. Trump.

"The possibility of implementing this plan in two days is another indication of Iran's good-faith approach," Mr. Baqaei said.

"We have stated that, if Iran's demands are met, it would be possible to restore security to the Strait of Hormuz and resume the negotiating process within a short period."

Mr. Baqaei said messages were being exchanged with the U.S. through mediators, adding that "everything depends" on the U.S. side accepting the Iranian demands. "Only then can we discuss the subsequent stages."

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi also said indirect talks were taking place via mediators.

"Given the sensitivity and gravity of the current situation, consultations and deliberations are very intensive," Mr. Araghchi told the official IRNA news agency.

But Mr. Trump has kept up his threats against Iran, telling a campaign rally in Iowa that at "some point we're going to have to give them [Iran] the hammer".

Thermal attack



Frozen goods are loaded into shopping carts to be thrown away at a supermarket in Sjobo, Sweden, on Monday, after a hacker attack raised the temperature in the freezers to 50 degrees Celsius. Stores in Belgium, Estonia, Finland, Ireland, Luxembourg, the Netherlands and Sweden were affected. REUTERS

Many U.K. social care migrant workers to get PR in five years

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

Foreign social and home care workers, who arrived in the U.K. before May 2025, will be able to settle (become permanent residents) in five years, rather than in 15 years, as was first proposed in the British government's 'earned settlement' scheme announced in November that year.

Those earning more than £50,271 per annum, doctors, nurses and teachers will be able to settle in five years, while those earning more than £1,25,140 per annum could settle in three years, as was proposed in the November 2025 draft rules.

The news of softer final rules for care workers is likely to impact thousands of Indians who came in on the Health and Care Worker visa scheme, which began in October 2020 and ran until July 2025. The scheme is associated with reports of Indian care workers – including many from Kerala – being subject to abuse, including unpaid wages, illegal recruitment fees, threats and other forms of exploitation at the hands of employers.

Under the scheme, finalised on Monday, social care workers earning at least £25,000 per year, who arrived in the U.K. before May 2025, would be eligible for 'indefinite leave to remain' (ILR) after five years. Those who have fallen afoul of the initial visa conditions would be given "a second chance", U.K. Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood said, with a fresh five-year qualifying period.

"The government has already stripped around 1,800 exploitative employers of their licenses," Ms. Mahmood said.

Softening stance

The softening of the conditions for residency in the final version of the earned settlement rules, announced by Ms. Mahmood, was a response to pressure from the left flank of the Labour Party and health unions, as well as a response to a public consultation on the draft policy, conducted earlier this year. The U.K. government said that over 2,02,000 responses were received, most (73%) of whom were visa holders.

Net migration hit a record of 9,44,000 in the year ending March 2023. However, following a tightening in policy started by the Rishi Sunak government and continued by Keir Starmer's Labour government, the net figure as of December 2025 dropped to 1,71,000.

"10 billion pounds. That is the cost of today's U-turn," shadow Home Secretary Chris Philp said in the House of Commons on Monday, using Ms. Mahmood's own cost estimate against her.

Other low-income workers could now obtain ILR in 10 years rather than the 15 years. Those with ILR have the right to live and work in the U.K. permanently and to potentially apply for benefits.

Russian bombing kills 24 in village in southeastern Ukraine, authorities say

Reuters
KYIV

Russian forces bombed a school in a village in Ukraine's southeastern Zaporizhzhia region on Monday, killing 24 people, Ukraine's emergency services said.

The emergency services said two members of a rescue crew were among the dead in the village of Komyshuvakha.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, writing on Telegram, said Russian forces initially dropped aerial bombs on a school in the village, used for distributing humanitarian assistance.

"After the first air strike, there was a repeat strike with nine more bombs, directly on the shelter where people were gathered," Mr. Zelenskyy wrote.



Human cost: Rescue personnel carry the body of a person killed by a Russian air strike in Ukraine's Zaporizhzhia. REUTERS

"The Russians could not have been unaware that every week residents who have remained in Komyshuvakha were receiving assistance right there. This is yet further proof that Russia does not want any kind of de-escalation."

Local truce ends

The attack occurred a day after the expiry of a six-day local ceasefire brokered by U.S. first lady Melania Trump to bring aid into the embattled city of Oleshky to the southwest in Kherson region and evacuate residents wishing to leave.

Earlier in the day, The head of Kherson city administration said a Russian-launched drone hit a "medical facility" in the centre of the city.

Kyiv's military also alleged that Moscow had used the pause in fighting to "fortify its positions".

The Kremlin did not deny the accusations, with its spokesman Dmitry Peskov saying: "This is a completely normal practice in such situations."

He alleged the Ukrainian Army had also used pauses in fighting in the past to regroup.

(With inputs from AFP)

Myanmar military strikes leave at least 15 dead in Rakhine

Reuters
BANGKOK

A newborn was among at least 15 people killed in Myanmar military strikes at multiple locations over the weekend, including a maternity clinic and a school, an ethnic armed group, an aid worker and rights monitors said on Monday.

The bombings come as the military-backed government, attempting to rebuild diplomatic ties after years of isolation, escalates its campaign to retake territory lost to resistance groups that now control large areas of the country.

On Sunday, airstrikes hit four townships in western Rakhine State, where fighting has been fierce in recent weeks as the Arakan Army, which controls most of the State, has neared the capital, Sittwe.

The strikes hit a bridge in Kyauktaw, locations in Kyaukpyu and Pauktaw, and a makeshift clinic and maternity ward in Arakan army-held Mrauk-U, killing a week-old baby and 11 people, an Arakan Army spokesperson and an aid worker said. Four other people, including healthcare workers, also died, the aid worker said.

Myanmar has been in turmoil since the military ousted Aung San Suu Kyi's elected government in a 2021 coup.

‘Israel seeks to minimise the Palestinian population’

Justice Srinivasan Muralidhar, chair of the UN-appointed Independent International Commission of Inquiry on Occupied Palestine, says Israel is seeking to expand the occupation while reducing the Palestinian population by systematically targeting children and women; he says the Commission’s report has demonstrated Israel’s intent to prevent Palestinians from continuing to exist as a group

INTERVIEW

Srinivasan Muralidhar

Stanly Johny

Israel’s policy is to maximise the occupation of Palestinian territories and minimise the Palestinian population, says Justice Srinivasan Muralidhar, the chair of the UN-appointed Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory. Speaking on The View from India podcast of *The Hindu*, Justice Muralidhar said the commission, in its recent report, has demonstrated Israel’s intent to prevent Palestinians from existing as a group. He also said the commission is gathering and preserving evidence of war crimes and crimes against humanity in the occupied Palestinian territories.

Read the excerpts from the interview below:

Can you tell us about the evidence the commission gathered about war crimes in Gaza and the West Bank?

As far as Gaza is concerned, we have found a systematic pattern of deliberate, targeted killings. And this has been happening over a period of time, not just after October 7, 2023. In Gaza, we found the elements that constitute genocide: targeted, deliberate killings; making life impossible for Gazans; targeting children; the forcible displacement of children; and preventing childbirth. We have found these elements established.

Our most recent report before the present one was on children. We submitted a nearly 100-page report on children in which, apart from discussing the prevention of childbirth and the forcible transfer of children, we also demonstrated the intent, the mental element, the *mens rea* – the intent to ensure that Palestinians do not continue as a group.

Your report also says that the West Bank is witnessing the largest displacement since 1967. Is this displacement happening because of violence by settlers or the state?

It is the violence by the state that is causing Palestinians in the West Bank to suffer. But settlers are also instigated, encouraged and completely supported by the Israeli security forces to attack Palestinians in the West Bank.

The Palestinian Authority is actually helpless. They cannot proceed against an Israeli national who attacks a Palestinian in the West Bank. They have to rely on the Israeli authorities to investigate such persons, which rarely happens.

Do you see any historical parallels?

The Commission is expected to look into the geographical territories of not only the Occupied Palestinian Territory but also Israel. The Commission also has to look into the root causes of the conflict, which date back to 1947-48 and perhaps even earlier, to the days of the Balfour Declaration. We find that, from 1947 to 1949, and there is one section devoted to this in the report, there has been a policy of maximising the occupation of land and minimising the Palestinian population. Under the two-state solution proposed at the time, the Arabs were to get 53% of the land and the Israelis 47%. This has been completely reversed.

Israel [today] controls nearly 70% of Gaza’s land. So, while a map might suggest that the Gaza Strip and the West Bank are what legitimately belong to the Palestinians, in fact, they are not in control of that much land at all. This has a historical past, as I said, going back to 1947-49. But even since then, it has been a very systematic and coordinated strategy.

If Israeli troops are controlling 70% of Gaza, and Gaza’s population, roughly 2.3 million, are now living in the remaining 30%?

They are completely in displacement camps. All those buildings have been demolished. Even in Rafah, there are only displacement camps. People are forced to move into displacement camps where the conditions are completely abominable. All the basic conditions for decent living are completely absent. Healthcare facilities have also been destroyed. The Gazans are not allowed to cross at the Rafah crossing. They cannot even travel from Gaza to the other part of the Occupied Palestinian Territory, that is, the West Bank.

R.V. MOORTHY



You have referred to people approaching the Yellow Line being shot...

Absolutely. Cars carrying defenseless Palestinians, including families of seven or eight, are bombed, and none of them survives. We have referred to several such incidents. There was a woman, eight months pregnant, near the Yellow Line. They said that she was looking suspiciously at the ground, as if she were trying to plant something, a landmine or a bomb. This is a completely false accusation if you look at the video. This is the kind of evidence we have been able to gather as a Commission of Inquiry.

How do you establish intent?

It is because of the pattern. In the report on children, when we spoke of intent, we spoke of aiming at the neck and head, ensuring that a person does not survive. Look at the pattern of attacks on others.

Look at the disproportionate nature of the attack. Then there is the denial of ambulance facilities. We have set out these kinds of instances because these are some of the cases that the Commission has investigated in depth. We establish intent through these patterns, where the attacks are very deliberate and targeted, and are intended to kill Palestinians, not merely attack or injure them.

At the UN, the Israeli Permanent Representative called the Commission’s report historical fiction. Your response...

One issue is factual inaccuracies. First, Israel’s pattern has been to attack the messenger and leave out the substance of what is being said. So it attacks individuals. The ambassador focused his attack on Mr. [Chris] Sidoti, who is my co-commissioner. He also discredited Ms. Navi Pillay in the most unfortunate manner. Israel has devoted a lot of funds to this. I am told that an entire budget of almost $700 million is devoted to propaganda work and discrediting the UN’s work.

But the claim is also factually incorrect because we are actually short of funds. The UN is unable to give us enough funds to do our work. The third point I must make is that Israel always accuses us of not discussing what Hamas has done. We have done a report on the events of October 7, 2023, in which we discussed what happened. When it comes to Gaza, Hamas and Hamas-supported groups are causing great misery to Palestinians. We have discussed that. Israel chooses to ignore these things.

In your response, you also said that Israel refused to cooperate with the Commission. Can you give more details?

Before we launch an exercise, we send what are called note verbales, in which we request specific information. Israel never responds. This is even before we launch the exercise of gathering evidence. At that stage, we also write to the Palestinians and the Palestinian Authority. They invariably respond. Before we finalise the report, we send them a draft. This is like giving them an opportunity to comment on our findings. All this happens before we finalise the report. Israel pointedly refuses to engage with the Commission.

The Commission has also called for accountability. What steps would you recommend to the international community to ensure accountability in this case?

Small steps are already being taken. In the last year or so since I took over, I can myself see a change. The government of the Netherlands has taken a positive decision to boycott goods coming from settler colonies in the Occupied Palestinian Territory. [U.K. Foreign Secretary] Ed Miliband also made a statement that they would not deal with goods coming from the Occupied Palestinian Territory. On the legal front... Let us say an Israeli soldier is found holidaying in New Zealand. New Zealand is a party to the Geneva Conventions and perhaps the ICCPR and the Rome Statute. It has an obligation to prosecute such a person, or at least investigate someone found in its territory who may be responsible for genocide or war crimes in the Occupied Palestinian Territory.

Do you still think a political settlement to the Palestine question is possible?

Certainly, nobody will give it up. That is the very basis of the dialogue that started way back in 1947-48 and also the basis of the hostilities that we are not seeing an end to. In the international community, a majority of countries are still rooting for the two-state solution. It is not off the charts. It is very much on the charts.

And what response has the Commission received from India for its work?

We are not aware of any official response, either to the report on children or to this report. So we are still waiting for that response, and the world community is waiting for it as well.

Greenland opens new international airport, eyes path to independence

Associated Press
ILULISSAT

Greenland has opened a new international airport, seeking to lure visitors from around the world as the Arctic island looks toward eventual independence from Denmark.

Thursday’s inaugural international flight between Copenhagen, Denmark, and Ilulissat, Greenland, was part of the island government’s efforts to grow its tourism industry to boost and diversify an economy still reliant on fishing.

Greenlandic Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen described the new airport as “one of the biggest investments” in the island’s history. Mr. Nielsen was one of 169 passengers on Thursday’s 4.5-hour flight on an Airbus A330neo. “If Greenland wants to be independent, we need to have a strong foundation, both economically and in terms of industry and business,” Mr. Nielsen said before the plane departed.



Passengers disembark an Air Greenland A330neo, after completing the first-ever direct flight from Copenhagen to Ilulissat. AP

The strategic island, home to roughly 56,000 people, has been a focus of U.S. President Donald Trump since his first term. His repeated threats to seize the territory from Denmark, a NATO ally, during his second term prompted months of tensions with other NATO allies. In September, Trump signed an agreement with the leaders of Denmark and Greenland to strengthen security in the Arctic and North Atlantic.

Ilulissat, known as the “City of Icebergs,” sits along the island’s western coast and is home to some 5,000 people. Greenland’s third-largest city is also one of the island’s most-visited destinations. More than 550 kilometres north of the capital, Nuuk, its tourism offerings range from sled dog tours to icefjord cruises in picturesque Disko Bay, known for its towering icebergs.

Previously, travelers reaching Ilulissat had to arrive by cruise ship, take a small plane from Iceland or fly to one of Greenland’s international hubs and connect to smaller aircraft. There are no road connections from other big towns.

The Ilulissat airport, meanwhile, has a 5,000-square-meter (53,820 square feet) terminal and a new 2,200-meter runway, long enough to accommodate larger passenger aircraft.

Vintage voyage



A 1901 Albion leads classic vintage cars making their way across the Westminster Bridge past the Houses of Parliament shortly after beginning the annual ‘Veteran Car Run’ from Hyde Park in London to Brighton, southern England. AFP

Western Sahara refugees still yearn for home as UN peacekeepers leave

Reuters
TINDOUF

At 51, Binina Mohamed is as old as the conflict that drove her from the Western Sahara region into a refugee camp in southern Algeria, where she has spent her life among tens of thousands of others facing a similar fate.

The confrontation over her native land, often described as Africa’s longest-running territorial dispute, was brought back into focus this weekend by a UN Security Council spat that led to the end of a decades-old peacekeeping mission there.

The Western Sahara conflict pits Morocco, which considers the territory its own, against the Algeria-backed Polisario Front, a political and military organisation that has been seeking a separate state there since the departure of former colonial power Spain in 1976.

Peacekeepers have watched over the territory since 1991, when the UN brokered a ceasefire ending years of guerrilla warfare between the two sides.

Thousands of Sahrawis fled hostilities to the Tindouf area in southwestern Algeria, where the Polisario administers five refugee camps.

During a rare visit to the region for foreign media outlets, organised by the Polisario, Mohamed described how her daughters, now in their twenties and thirties, had never visited the region where she was from.

“I do not want them to reach the age of 50 without seeing their homeland,” she told *Reuters*.

One of her daughters, Safia Al-Saleh, 33, said she hoped her own two children would have a different future.

“I want my children and my grandchildren to study and growup in their own country, not to grow up like us here, as refugees, with nothing,” she said.

Camps at the centre

The uncertainty facing refugees such as Mohamed has become a central point of contention in the latest diplomatic battle over Western Sahara.

The dispute heated up last year when the UN Security Council backed Rabat’s plan to give the region autonomy under Moroccan sovereignty as the “most feasible” way to resolve the conflict.



A view of a part of the refugee camp of Boudjdour in Tindouf, southern Algeria. REUTERS

After abstaining last year, Russia this year vetoed a US-drafted resolution that would have reaffirmed that position. When a competing Russian resolution was defeated, it left the UN mission without a renewal of its mandate.

In a speech at the council, Algeria’s UN envoy defended the Polisario’s stance and highlighted a decline in aid and the suffering of refugees in the camps.

Morocco’s envoy in turn said the harsh conditions in the camps were the responsibility of Algeria, a longtime Russian ally, which he accused of denying the refugees their right toreturn home.

He urged Algiers to allow the UN to register the refugees, saying other nationalities were present there.

Algeria and the Polisario say over 160,000 live in the Tindouf refugee camps. UNHCR says it provides assistance to anestimated 90,000 of the “most vulnerable” refugees there.

Refugees’ long wait

Morocco disputes both numbers, citing a lack of a UN census, and accuses the Polisario and Algeria of using Sahrawis aspolitical pawns, which Algiers denies.

As the dispute grinds on, Mohamed’s family described daily problems in the camp, including access to water and the harsh climate. More than 80% of the camps’ residents rely on humanitarian assistance to meet basic food needs, the World Food Programme said in a statement earlier this year.

Another of Mohamed’s daughters, Aisha Salem, a 24- year-old fighter with the Polisario Front, said she wanted a different future for the next generation: “We don’t want to live the wayour grandparents did, through displacement and deprivation,” shesaid.

Mohamed echoed the sentiment.

“We want stability. We aretired of being refugees,” she said. “The one who has no land hasno life,” she added.

STAYING HUMBLE

Superstitious Antonelli to shun F1 champion's No. 1 next year



AP

Kimi Antonelli will not have the No. 1 on his car next year and will keep the No. 12 for the 2027 season. "It's a very special number for me, but also it's a way for me to stay grounded, to stay humble. And to be honest, I'm very superstitious, and number one has never been a good number for me. I will stick with 12".

CALLING IT A DAY

Maxwell announces retirement from international cricket



FILE PHOTO

Australia all-rounder Glenn Maxwell has announced his retirement from international cricket. The 38-year-old had quit ODIs last year. Maxwell featured in seven Tests, 149 ODIs and 130 T20Is in an international career spanning 14 years. His last appearance for Australia was against Oman in the T20 World Cup earlier this year.

ANOTHER ASSIGNMENT

Tilak named India-A skipper for Rising Stars Asia Cup

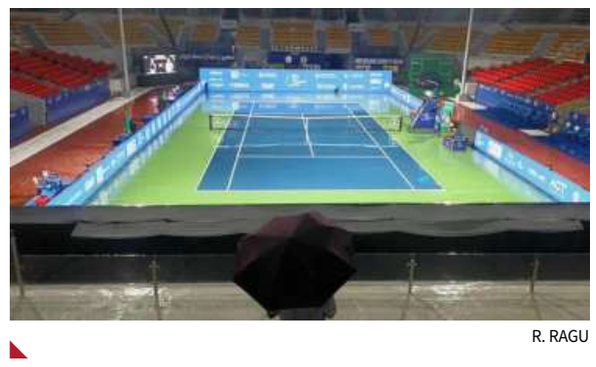


FILE PHOTO: NAGARA GOPAL

India squad for the ACC Men's Rising Stars Asia Cup: Tilak Varma (Capt.), Rajat Patidar, Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Prabhsimran Singh, Rinku Singh, Kumar Kushagra, Suryansh Shedge, Shahbaz Ahmed, Vipraj Nigam, Harsh Dubey, Tanush Kotian, Harshit Rana, Prince Yadav, and Arshad Khan.

DAMPENER

Opening day's play at WTA 250 Chennai Open washed out



R. RAGU

Rains brought in by cyclone Murasu led to a complete washout on the opening day of the WTA 250 Chennai Open on Monday. Therefore, the action on Tuesday, featuring all 16 first-round matches, will begin at 11 a.m. to get the tournament back on schedule. However, inclement weather is expected on day two.

Kimi Antonelli crowned youngest-ever champion

The Mercedes driver, aged 20 years and 68 days, finishes third at the Mexico City GP to become the first Italian champion since Ascari 73 years ago; Verstappen takes the chequered flag

FORMULA ONE

Reuters
MEXICO CITY

A tearful Kimi Antonelli became Formula One's youngest World champion at 20 years and 68 days old on Sunday when he finished third for Mercedes in a red-flagged and restarted Mexico City Grand Prix won by Red Bull's Max Verstappen.

The first Italian champion since Alberto Ascari in 1953 sobbed with joy over the team radio as he took the chequered flag at the high-altitude Autodromo Hermanos Rodriguez, with his overall lead now an unassailable 119 points.

Ferrari's Lewis Hamilton started from pole position and took a close second place – after clashing with teammate Charles Leclerc – on an afternoon of drama with two safety cars, multiple crashes and an agonising 33-minute halt with 25 of the 71 laps remaining. The previous youngest champion was Germany's Sebastian Vettel, who took the first of his four with Red Bull at 23 years and 134 days in 2010.

Verstappen went second in the overall standings, with Hamilton third and pre-season favourite George Russell plummeting to fourth and 130 points behind Antonelli.

The results: 1. Max Verstappen (Red Bull) 2h: 20m: 28.772s; 2. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) + 0.799, 3. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) 4.006; 4. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) 10.707; 5. Lando Norris (McLaren) 11.778; 6. George Russell (Mercedes) 12.263; 7. Oscar Piastri (McLaren) 19.475; 8. Franco Colapinto (Alpine) 20.204; 9. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls) 20.899; 10. Pierre Gasly (Alpine) 21.483; 11. Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi) 22.041; 12. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull) 22.503; 13. Ryo Hirakawa (Haas) 25.373; 14. Alexander Albon (Williams) 27.562; 15. Carlos Sainz (Williams) 28.638; 16. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi) 29.977; 17. Sergio Perez (Cadillac) 30.695. **DNF:** Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls); Oliver Bearman (Haas); Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac); Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin). **Standings: Drivers:** 1. Antonelli 380 pts.; 2. Verstappen 261; 3. Hamilton 259; 4. Russell 250; 5. Leclerc 245. **Constructors:** 1. Mercedes 630; 2. Ferrari 504; 3. Red Bull 380; 4. McLaren 371; 5. Racing Bulls 104.



NZ-A's gritty lower-order puts the team in front

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Pacer Mohammed Siraj warmed up for the upcoming two-Test series with four wickets in 35 overs for India-A but New Zealand-A's lower-order showed a lot of grit to earn a 78-run first innings lead on the penultimate day of the second 'Test' here.

Replying to India-A's first innings score of 346, New Zealand-A, which was reduced to 338 for eight, finished its first innings at 424. The last two wickets added 86 runs to provide the hosts a handy lead.

Siraj and Mukesh star

Speedster Siraj took four for 118 while seamer Mukesh Kumar grabbed five for 87 in 29 overs to share the spoils.

Kristian Clarke (41), Fraser Sheat (40), Jayden Lennox (32) and Jarrod McKay (33) played their part as New Zealand-A got the lead after being 291 for seven.

The scores: India-A 346 & 32/0 vs New Zealand-A 424 (Boyle 110, Foxcroft 93, Siraj 4/118, Mukesh 5/87).

IPL retention deadline extended to November 17

Amol Karhadkar
MUMBAI

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has extended the deadline for the Indian Premier League (IPL) franchises to submit the player retention list by two days, giving them until November 17 to finalise their squads ahead of the mini auction in Goa on December 16.

In a communication shared with the franchises on Monday, the BCCI informed them of the revised deadline, replacing the original November 15 cut-off.

The extension is understood to have been prompted by the India-New Zealand ODI series, with the fifth and final match scheduled to be played at the Bay Oval in Mount Maunganui on November 15. Interestingly, the auction itself will coincide with India's second ODI against Sri Lanka at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium in Bengaluru.

The BCCI has also outlined the timeline leading up to the auction. Player registration opened on Monday and will close on November 23. Franchises will have until December 1 to submit the list of players they wish to bid for, before the final auction register, including the order of player sets, will be released on December 3.

Siraj excited to operate in helpful conditions

INDIA IN NZ

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Every fast bowler has a run-up that begins long before the first stride. Mohammed Siraj's began in Hyderabad, took him to his India debut against New Zealand in November 2017, and has now carried him, nine years later, to that country again.

Siraj is now a senior statesman. As if to remind himself of the road travelled, he stopped at the start of it: two Ranji Trophy matches as Hyderabad captain, two emphatic wins over Tripura and Andhra, and a final tune-up at the Gymkhana under the watchful eyes of T. Dilip, the former India fielding coach.

"I am very excited to play in New Zealand because a fast bowler needs grass and bounce. It will be very challenging because there will be a lot of swing. My plan will be simple: enjoy the experience," Siraj told *The Hindu*.

If there is one thing he is wary of before a big assignment, it is idleness. His body, he has made it clear, does not take kindly to rest. The two back-to-back games for Hyderabad, tiring as they were, felt more like a gift than a burden.

"The first few sessions were about making him realise that he doesn't need to do anything different as he has been successful at the international level. But when you have a long graph, there will be ups and downs. How you pick yourself up mentally is the most important," Dilip told *The Hindu*.

When Siraj was asked about personal goals, he said: "I'm not a believer in milestones. It's all about collecting wins and memories as a team.

"I had nothing at the beginning and I have everything now. I have a fan following. I thank the almighty who has brought me here. My only thought is to keep myself grounded, keep working hard and keep winning matches for my country," said the 32-year-old.

In the Shaky Isles, Siraj has wasted no time in making his presence felt by scalping four wickets for India-A in the second 'Test' against New Zealand-A. It augurs well for the pacer as well as India.



Gameplan: Siraj hopes to keep it simple and enjoy the experience. FILE PHOTO: K.V.S. GIRI

Record-breaker Antonelli's coronation could well be the change of guard

S. Dipak Ragav

One of the charms of watching elite sport is to marvel at the human endeavour to constantly push the envelope, for records and history are meant to be shattered and rewritten. Whenever there's a strong belief that a feat can't be matched, someone springs up to prove it wrong.

Mexico City was witness to one such occasion on Sunday when a young Italian barely out of his teens did just that. Kimi Antonelli clinched his maiden Formula One driver's championship after finishing third in the Mexico GP. The 20-year-old became the sport's youngest champion, surpassing Sebastian Vettel who won his first title at 23. Incidentally, Antonelli was born on the day (August 25, 2006) Vettel made his F1 debut during a practice session in Istanbul (Turkish GP).

The Mercedes driver burst onto the scene after just one season in F2 and was thrown into the deep end last year when he replaced seven-time champion Lewis Hamilton.

It was a huge gamble by team boss Toto Wolff to offer one of the most coveted seats in F1 to an 18-year-old. Wolff's decision was partly driven by the fact that he lost Max Verstappen when he had the opportunity to sign him in 2015 and didn't want to repeat the mistake with someone whom he considered a generational talent. However, Antonelli's rookie season was far from impressive and far off the pace from Russell.

This year, the sport introduced drastic changes, including a new power unit and aerodynamic regulations, challenging drivers used to a certain style. This is where Antonelli showed he could quickly adapt to the new demands.

From pre-season testing, it was clear that Mercedes had the best package and, understandably, Russell was the overwhelming favourite. This was further emphasised when the British driver comfortably won the opener in Australia. However, Antonelli took the bull by the horns and strung together a five-race winning streak that changed the complexion of the season.

Sunday was the official coronation and it was fitting that he was joined on the rostrum by Max Verstappen (winner) and Hamilton (second), the two drivers who have been the icons of Formula One for the last 15 years. This could well be the change of guard, a point driven home by Antonelli's race engineer who remarked "it's just the first chapter".



All hail the new king! Antonelli is carried by Verstappen, left, and Hamilton who have been the icons of F1 for the last 15 years. AP

India ends league phase with a thumping win over Korea

ACT

Uthra Ganesan
JALANDHAR

Eight goals, seven different scorers, eight penalty corners, 60% possession and complete domination. The Indian men's hockey team finished the league stage of the Asian Champions Trophy the way it began, thrashing Korea 8-0 on Monday to maintain its winning run.

Despite the absence of two key players – Hardik Singh rested ahead of the knockout games as the campaign now moves to Mohali and Abhishek's status still uncertain after twisting his ankle during warm-up ahead of Sunday's match – there was little to bother the host. India began aggressively, kept the pace up and, barring the occasional push back from Korea in the first half, did not allow the opposition any space.

Dilpreet Singh began the goal-fest with a reverse hit into the net in the eighth minute and Angad Bir Singh rounded it off seconds from full time. In between, India not only gave a masterclass in game control but also answered questions on dropping intensity, specially when playing back-to-back matches.

The forwards had a field day, running past the Korean defence for fun even as the Indian defence stood strong.

There wasn't much for it to do except for a series of four penalty corners for Korea in the second quarter when it showed glimpses of a fightback. Those were the rival's only four shots at goal to India's 19 attempts.

The two teams will now face-off in a day's time in the semifinal. Japan stunned Malaysia 2-1 and will play each other again in the other last-four clash.

Japan overcame a missed penalty stroke and the form book to upset the Asian Games runner-up and climb to second on the table.

Jun Watanabe squandered a penalty stroke in the seventh minute and Malaysia, quick on the counter, got the lead through Abu Kamal Azrai.

But Japan kept coming hard and Kentaro Fukuda struck twice.

The results: China 1 (Chen Benhai 2-pc) drew with Bangladesh 1 (Ashraful Islam 38-ps); Japan 2 (Kentaro Fukuda 24, 54) bt Malaysia 1 (Abu Kamal Azrai 10); India 8 (Dilpreet Singh 8, 40, Jugraj Singh 11-pc, Harmanpreet Singh 15-pc, Shilanand Lakra 33-pc, Sukhjeet Singh 34, Sanjay 36, Angad Bir Singh 60) bt Korea 0.



Total domination: India put eight past Korea with seven players finding the target. HOCKEY INDIA

Urvil, Vishal boost Gujarat on day one

The two carry the host to 300 for five as Kerala squanders advantage

RANJI TROPHY

M.R. Praveen Chandran
AHMEDABAD

A frustratingly familiar script unfolded again for Kerala at the Narendra Modi stadium here on Monday. For the third time this season, Kerala allowed the opposition's lower-order to fight back and wrest away the hard-earned advantage.

An unbroken, counter-attacking 111-run partnership for the sixth wicket between Urvil Patel (63 batting, 67b, 7x4, 1x6) and Vishal Jayswal (50 batting, 83b, 3x4, 2x6) was the latest to hurt Kerala as Gujarat ended the opening day of the Ranji Trophy Elite Group C match at 300 for five.



Solid knock: Opener Aarya hit six fours and three maximums in his 95. VIJAY SONEJI

Soon after tea, Kerala had Gujarat in a spot of bother at 189 for five when Jaymeet Patel (one) was stumped by Mohammed Azharuddeen off Aditya Sarvate. But the visiting side let Gujarat off the hook when it failed to grab the chances and wilted under the calculated assault by Urvil and Vishal.

Rohan Kunnummal showed poor judgement while running back and failed to reach a skier from Vishal off Vaisakh Chandran when the batter was on 33. Azharuddeen fumbled when Urvil, on 32, stepped out to attack Sarvate. Urvil and Vishal capitalised on these errors to take their side to a position of strength in the final session.

Earlier, Kerala had crawled back into the contest in the post-lunch session, picking up four wickets to reduce the host to 182 for four. The strikes included that of top-scorer Aarya Desai (95, 132b, 6x4, 3x6), who in a hurry to reach his hundred top-edged a wild slog and was caught by Vishnu Vinod off Vaisakh.

In the morning, openers Aarya and Abhishek Desai played fluently against the Kerala bowlers who found little help from the track. However, a better disciplined show with the ball in the second session choked the flow of runs which forced the Gujarat batters to take the risks, which ultimately led to their downfall.

The scores: Gujarat — 1st innings: Abhishek Desai c Rohan b Nidheesh 42, Aarya Desai c Vishnu b Vaisakh 95, Vedant Trivedi c Rohan b Basil 9, Manan Hingrajia c Azharuddeen b Jalaj 33, Jaymeet Patel st. Azharuddeen b Sarvate 1, Urvil Patel (batting) 63, Vishal Jayswal (batting) 50; Extras (b-4, lb-2, wd-1): 7; Total (for five wkts. in 83 overs): 300.

Fall of wickets: 1-116, 2-138, 3-180, 4-182, 5-189.

Kerala bowling: Nidheesh 20-3-59-1, Basil 13-3-50-1, Jalaj 24-1-60-1, Sarvate 11-0-68-1, Vaisakh 15-2-57-1.

RANJI SCORES - ROUND 4, DAY 1

Elite:

Group A: At Kanpur: Baroda 269/6 in 87 overs (Dhruv Patel 124, Shashwat Rawat 47, Mitesh Patel 49) vs. Uttar Pradesh; **Toss:** Baroda.

At Panaji: Goa 288/6 in 87 overs (Abhinav Tejrana 73, Snehal Kauthankar 116 batting) vs. Bihar; **Toss:** Goa.

At Nagpur: Madhya Pradesh 209 in 66.1 overs (Atharva Mahajan 85, Harsh Dubey 9/53) vs. Vidarbha 56/4 in 23 overs; **Toss:** MP.

At Srinagar: Pondicherry 261/6 in 77 overs (Neyan Shyam Kangayan 70, Mohit Kale 73, Ankit Sharma 45) vs. Jammu & Kashmir; **Toss:** J&K.

Group B: At Guwahati: Assam in 48.1 overs (Rithesh Bhatkal 5/35, Shikhar Shetty 5/53) vs. Karnataka 180/2 in 36 overs (Rohan Patil 89, Mayank Agarwal 57 batting); **Toss:** Assam.

At Agartala: Tripura 219/7 in 74.3 overs (Sridam Paul 86, Sentu Sarkar 46) vs. Saurashtra; **Toss:** Saurashtra.

At Hyderabad: Chhattisgarh 279/7 in 87 overs (Anuj Tiwary 72, Vikalp Tiwari 69) vs. Hyderabad; **Toss:** Chhattisgarh.

At New Chandigarh: Punjab 276/5 in 80 overs (Salil Arora 111 batting, Sanvir Singh 100 batting) vs. Andhra; **Toss:** Andhra.

Group C: At Bhubaneswar: Jharkhand 37/3 in 25 overs vs. Odisha; **Toss:** Odisha.

At Kolkata: Bengal 143 in 36.5 overs (Abishek Porel 54) vs. Maharashtra 21/2 in eight overs; **Toss:** Maharashtra.

At Ahmedabad: Gujarat 300/5 in 83 overs (Abhishek Desai 42, Aarya Desai 95, Urvil Patel 63 batting, Vishal Jayswal 50 batting) vs. Kerala; **Toss:** Gujarat.

At New Delhi: Services 266 in 88 overs (Rajat Paliwal 111 n.o., Aman Chaudhary 4/79) vs. Delhi; **Toss:** Services.

Group D: At Dehradun: Haryana 153 in 59.5 overs (Mayank Mishra 6/57) vs. Uttarakhand 59/0 in 32 overs; **Toss:** Haryana.

At Mumbai: Mumbai 247/6 in 83 overs (Angkrish Raghuvanshi 78, Siddhesh Lad 47, Sarfaraz Khan 55) vs. Railways; **Toss:** Railways.

At Chandigarh: Tamil Nadu 320/4 in 86 overs (N. Jagadeesan 52, Pradosh Ranjan Paul 138 batting, B. Indrajith 51) vs. Chandigarh; **Toss:** TN.

At Dharamshala: Rajasthan 78 in 30.3 overs (Abhishek Kumar 5/14) & 8/0 in one over vs. Himachal Pradesh 153 in 40 overs (Ankush Bains 56, Pukhraj Mann 42, Sahil Dhiwan 5/50); **Toss:** Rajasthan.

Plate: At Anand: Arunachal Pradesh 285 in 77.5 overs (Salil Malhotra 146, Likha Sonia 40, Kuldip Yadav 4/44) vs. Mizoram 35/0 in 10 overs; **Toss:** Arunachal.

At Ahmedabad: Sikkim 301/5 in 90 overs (Nilesh Lamichaney 40, Ashish Thapa 107, Parth Palawat 86) vs. Manipur; **Toss:** Sikkim.

At Shillong: Nagaland 244/8 in 67 overs (Rongsen Jonathan 69, Nagaho Chishi 68, Manish Sharma 4/64) vs. Meghalaya; **Toss:** Meghalaya.

Top golfers in the fray for IGPL Visakhapatnam leg

K. Keerthivasan
VISAKHAPATNAM

One of India's most accomplished golfers, Gaganjeet Bhullar, emerging talent Pukhraj Singh Gill and young golfer Aryan Roopa Anand will be the star attractions when the 10th leg of Season-2 of the Indian Golf Premier League (IGPL) gets underway here on Tuesday.

The tournament called the Green Fuels Maritime Invitational, presented by Vizag Dolphins Golf Club, will see Bhullar face a serious challenge from the likes of in-form Pukhraj, who recently sealed his Asian Tour card and a host of IGPL winners such as Aryan, Sachin Baisoya, Udayan Mane, Aman Raj and Arjun Prasad.

Needless to say, with rains adding another dimension, weather will also play an important role.

Uttam Singh Mundy, CEO of IGPL, said, "We are hopeful of play beginning tomorrow (on Tuesday), but the final call will be taken in the morning depending on whether it rains overnight. However, we are confident of having 54 holes as weather later in the week is expected to be better."

Adding further interest is the contingent of 10 women professionals besides six amateurs. The event will bring together 60 professionals.

The participation of women professionals and amateurs will showcase IGPL's stated goal of giving all golfers a chance to test themselves in a competitive atmosphere. Sneha Singh, Vidhatri Urs and Jasmine Shekar will be among the recognised women players in the group.

(The writer is in Visakhapatnam at the invitation of the Indian Golf Premier League.)

Isak's honesty punished: Iraola on Liverpool's denied penalty

EURO LEAGUES

Agencies
LIVERPOOL

Liverpool boss Andoni Iraola said it was a "shame" there was no reward for honesty after his side was controversially denied a penalty in a 0-1 loss to Arsenal on Sunday.

The defending Premier League champion moved to the top of the table after its first win at Anfield in 14 years. But Liverpool was left aggrieved after Alexander Isak was pulled back by Jurrien Timber as he attempted to meet Bradley Barcola's cross midway through the first half.

The Swedish striker did not go to ground and neither the referee nor VAR intervened to award a spot-kick.

"We have to tell them to go down because they are not going to call it otherwise," said Iraola after only his second defeat since taking charge of the Reds.



Putting pressure: Iraola said he would ask his players to go down when fouled inside the box. AFP

"I don't see the reason why. Only because he hasn't dived or he hasn't gone to the floor. It shouldn't be a reason, but of course it's a penalty."

In LaLiga, Real Madrid coach Jose Mourinho said "we are improving" after his side's dominant 3-0 win over Racing Santander.

The results: LaLiga: Athletic Bilbao 2 (Inaki Williams 14, Berenguer 45+2-pen) bt Real Sociedad 1 (Sucic 30).
Serie A: Juventus 2 (Alajbegovic 70, Boga 87) bt Napoli 0; Lecce 1 (Maleh 40) lost to Genoa 2 (Osmajic 11, Messelas 28).

LIVE TELECAST

Ranji Trophy: Day 2, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.

Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 11.15 p.m. & 1.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE SCHEDULE

Galatasaray vs. VfB Stuttgart; Shakhtar Donetsk vs. Sporting CP *(both at 11.15 p.m. on Tuesday).* Atletico Madrid vs. Bayern Munich; Barcelona vs. Aston Villa; Bodo/Glimt vs. Lille; Feyenoord Rotterdam vs. Inter Milan; LASK Linz vs. Slovan Bratislava; Manchester United vs. AS Roma; Villarreal vs. Paris Saint-Germain *(all at 1.30 a.m. on Wednesday).*



Productive shot: Pradosh used the sweep to great effect. R.V. MOORTHY

Pradosh's unbeaten century powers TN

S. Shrivathsan
CHANDIGARH

Yo Mahesh prayed and Pradosh Ranjan Paul answered.

Some 30 minutes into the second session of the Ranji Trophy Elite Group D contest between Chandigarh and Tamil Nadu, the visiting team's head coach pleaded to Pradosh and B. Indrajith: "*Neenga kadasi varikum aadamum* (you must stay there till the end of the day's play)."

While the right-hander could not fulfil Yo Mahesh's wish, the southpaw did not disappoint his boss at the Sector-16 Stadium here on Monday.

His well-constructed unbeaten century (138 batting, 215b, 12x4) on a greenish surface was the headline act as Tamil Nadu, having opted to bat, stood at 320 for four at the end of a day it dominated. Pradosh, walking out at No. 3 after the fall of Vimal Khumar, was solid in defence, played the ball close to his body and employed the sweep repeatedly against the left-arm spinners. The 10th First Class ton, which he completed with a crunching cover-drive for four off Rohit Dhanda, was a tangible reward for his grind.

> When I got to my fifty, I felt that I could have batted better.
> I was not connecting the ball well in the initial part.
> I celebrate only when I have the perfect feeling that I batted well

> The job is not done. Until I am in the middle, my role is to take my team to a commanding position.
> I will be satisfied if this knock results in a win. My job is to win games for Tamil Nadu

Another feature of his knock was the excellent running between the wickets. After keeping the fielders on their toes during the 139-run third-wicket stand with Indrajith (51, 112b, 3x4), the 25-year-old did not pass up any opportunity in his unbroken 66-run fifth-wicket association with G. Ajitesh (34 batting).

Indrajith, the topper

Unlike Pradosh, senior pros Indrajith and N. Jagadeesan (52, 88b, 8x4) could not carry on after crossing the first milestone.

Jagadeesan saw his stumps rearranged in left-arm tweaker Bhagmender Lather's first over, with Indrajith walking back to the hut following a sharp return catch from Nishunk Birla. Indrajith, however, achieved a feat before being dismissed: he became the Tamil Nadu batter with most half-centuries (30) in the Ranji Trophy, surpassing S. Sharath and Hemang Badani (29). Pradosh, though, has his feet on the ground determined for more.

The scores:
Tamil Nadu – 1st innings: Vimal Khumar c Arjit b Nikhil 11, N. Jagadeesan b Bhagmender 52, Pradosh Ranjan Paul (batting) 138, B. Indrajith c & b Nishunk 51, Andre Siddarth c & b Bhagmender 13, G. Ajitesh (batting) 34; Extras (b-8, lb-7, nb-3, w-3): 21; Total (for four wkts. in 86 overs): 320.
Fall of wickets: 1-38, 2-92, 3-231, 4-254.
Chandigarh bowling: Jagjit 12-3-38-0, Nikhil 10-0-34-1, Rohit 19-2-81-0, Nishunk 18-0-63-1, Bhagmender 16-2-47-2, Chiragvir 10-0-41-0, Arjun 1-0-1-0.

Anuj and Vikalp to Chhattisgarh's rescue

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Hyderabad had the contest by the collar until the wind rose and loosened its grip. Unhurried half-centuries by Anuj Tiwary, twice forgiven by the fielders, and Vikalp Tiwari sailed Chhattisgarh to 279 for seven on a tide that refused to go out.

Rakshann Readdi struck early, with wicketkeeper Pragnay Reddy pouching a sharp catch to send Ayush Pandey back. At the other end, Anuj survived twice: Aniketh Reddy and Pragnay the culprits.

Mayank Verma kept the scoreboard moving with a boundary every other over, until Aniketh struck twice in the 26th over. An edge ended Mayank's stay, and Sanjeet Desai followed for a duck, snaffled by Tanmay Agarwal at first slip. Anuj hit the day's first six over midwicket, and four overs later Vikalp smashed Tanay Thyagarajann over long-on. Tanay hit back just before lunch, removing Amandeep to give Hyderabad the upper hand.

A cool wind descended thereafter and generously swung momentum in favour of the visitors. Anuj swept to the backward square-leg boundary to bring up his fifty, and ring in a half-century stand with Vikalp. The latter was the more urgent of the two, keeping his strike-rate in triple figures. Three fours in the second over after lunch signalled his intent, and he reached his own fifty in 48 balls.

Anuj's luck finally ran out when he was trapped leg before by C.V. Milind, ending a 132-ball, 93-run partnership that put the visitors in control of the proceedings. For all the early bravado, Vikalp managed only 19 runs in his next 48 balls before Ruthik Yadav breached his defence on the fourth ball after tea.



Rising to the occasion: Anuj played a captain's innings. NAGARA GOPAL

In the closing overs of the day, Hyderabad's short ball ploy against Prateek Yadav bore fruit when the southpaw's pull landed safely into Abhirath's hands at backward square-leg, before bad light brought stumps early.

The scores: Chhattisgarh — 1st innings: Ayush Pandey c Pragnay b Rakshann 17, Anuj Tiwary lbw b Milind 72, Mayank Verma c Pragnay b Aniketh 36, Sanjeet Desai c Tanmay b Aniketh 0, Amandeep Khare c Himateja b Tanay 0, Vikalp Tiwari b Ruthik 69, Jayant Yadav (batting) 36, Prateek Yadav c Abhirath b Rakshann 27, Ayan Mandal (batting) 9; Extras (b-4, lb-7, w-2): 13; Total (for seven wkts. in 87 overs) 279.

Fall of wickets: 1-22, 2-87, 3-87, 4-94, 5-187, 6-216, 7-264.

Hyderabad bowling: Milind 10-3-17-1, Tanay 26-4-89-1, Rakshann 12-1-34-2, Ruthik 18-1-69-1, Aniketh 21-4-59-2.



Dazzling duo: Spinners Ritesh and Shikhar combined for all 10 wickets. SIDDANTH NAIR

Ritesh and Shikhar do it for Karnataka

Siddanth Nair
GUWAHATI

The green grass was a disguise. What lay beneath, however, was a surface that Karnataka's spinners exploited ruthlessly, bowling Assam out for 135 before the visitors raced to 180 for two on the opening day of their Ranji Trophy Elite Group B encounter at the ACA Stadium on Monday.

Spinners Ritesh Bhatkal (five for 35) and Shikhar Shetty (five for 53) combined for all 10 wickets.

Captain Shreyas Gopal's decision to introduce spin early paid dividends after Assam won the toss and elected to bat. Karnataka, noticing the green tinge on the surface, started with pace and an aggressive field set-up, positioning fielders at short-leg and deep-fine. That strategy did not go according to plan, but the green layer's bluff was exposed soon after.

Underneath it lay a dry, grippy surface that Ritesh and Shikhar made full use of once they were introduced into the attack from the seventh over.

Captain Denish Das (26, 72b) and Sibsankar Roy (37, 66b), Assam's best batters this season, were the only ones to put up a fight.

Denish and Sibsankar stitched together a 63-run partnership for the fourth wicket, with the latter being the aggressor. Just when the association began to flourish, Sibsankar fell to Ritesh.

Ritesh completed his five-for in the first over of the second session by sending back Denish before Shikhar also reached the landmark – his third five-wicket haul this season – by wiping out Assam's tail in no time.

In reply, Karnataka openers Rohan Patil (89, 87b, 13x4, 1x6) and Mayank (57 batting, 95b, 7x4) got off the blocks strongly with a 129-run partnership.

The scores: Assam — 1st innings: Nibir Deka c Karun b Ritesh 12, Pradyun Saikia b Ritesh 13, Sumit Ghadigaonkar lbw b Shikhar 1, Denish Das b Ritesh 26, Sibsankar Roy b Ritesh 37, Sarupam Purkayastha c Manvanth b Shikhar 13, Amlanjyoti Das c Karun b Shikhar 12, Roshan Alam lbw b Ritesh 7, Mukhtar Hussain c & b Shikhar 0, Mohit Thakur (not out) 0, Hridip Deka b Shikhar 0; Extras (b-12, lb-1): 13; Total (in 48.1 overs): 135.
Fall of wickets: 1-19, 2-20, 3-30, 4-93, 5-98, 6-121, 7-130, 8-130, 9-130.
Karnataka bowling: Kaverappa 3-1-9-0, Manvanth 6-3-15-0, Ritesh 18-4-35-5, Shikhar 17.1-4-53-5, Shreyas 4-0-10-0.
Karnataka — 1st innings: Rohan Patil c Sibsankar b Amlanjyoti 89, Mayank Agarwal (batting) 57, K.L. Shrijith lbw b Amlanjyoti 19, K.V. Aneesh (batting) 7; Extras (lb-5, nb-3): 8; Total (for two wkts. in 36 overs): 180.
Fall of wickets: 1-129, 2-157.
Assam bowling: Mukhtar 3-0-20-0, Mohit 8-0-39-0, Amlanjyoti 13-1-51-2, Hridip 3-0-14-0, Sarupam 3-0-19-0, Roshan 6-0-32-0.

Gymnast, seamstress, Olympian... the many lives of Casey Kaufhold

I am naturally competitive, but the enjoyment aspect has always stayed with me. I think that has led me to a lot of success



SIDDHANT THAKUR

INTERVIEW

Casey Kaufhold

Anirudh Velamuri

Before big competitions, Casey Kaufhold plays a song. Her go-to is "Don't stop me now" by Queen, a three-minute declaration of unstoppable joy. It might be the most honest summary of her career ever recorded. Casey has run at the sport's speed since she was a teenager, shooting quickly and shooting without fear. So when the Archery Premier League (APL) came calling with a 15-second shot clock and teams filled with recurve and compound archers cheering for one another, the American did what she has always done. She turned the volume up.

In a conversation with *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the recently concluded APL, the 22-year-old spoke about warming up to the league, the advice she has for budding archers like her Chero Archers teammate Kumkum Mohod, evolving with archery since the age of three, and more. Excerpts:

You said that this is a format that forces you to trust every shot that you shoot. How has that been compared to the regular shot clock?

When you're at a World Cup event, it's a lot easier to get in a rhythm. You have 20 seconds to shoot, then your opponent shoots, and then you shoot, and so on. In the APL, it's a lot faster, so it's harder to get in a rhythm. But you also have more time between your first arrow and the next. It's a lot longer. So you really just have to commit to that one shot at a time and make it your best.

Do you think you shoot better when the clock is faster?

Oh, for sure. The first day that I shot at APL, I shot second to last; Atanu (Das) shot last. I went last in the next round of shots where I had only 11-12 seconds. I was still able to step up and shoot an X or a 10 when the team needed it. The confidence that gave me was huge. If I can shoot an X in 12 seconds, I can easily shoot one in 20 seconds, right?

With just 15 seconds, you can't think too hard. You have to just let yourself shoot without thought. That's something I want to apply when I go back to international archery, and it's 20 seconds: work with the thought that I have only 15.

What stays the same in your process in the regular sport and the APL, and what are you doing differently?

As far as the physical shot, my execution is the same. Coming to the line, loading the arrow, even drawing is a little bit faster. But once I get to anchor, the whole process is the same. What I'm saying to myself in my head is a lot faster though. I have some words that I say while I'm approaching the line and also during my shot, and normally it's a bit slower-paced, whereas here I'm having to definitely speed that up to match the timing of the shot.

It's just a lot of positive self-encouragement. And then as I'm going through my expansion, I say go. But I say go till the clicker clicks, and then I see the arrow hit the target. So those words just align with my shot and help me.

Do you have a favourite venue?

Paris has always been special to me. Even before I won my first Olympic medal there. I got to shoot the test event the year before the Games, and I won that World Cup. I use a lot of that experience in all the finals I shoot.

You broke onto the world stage very early. In India, we have 17-year-old Kumkum Mohod, your Chero Archers teammate, who took the nation by storm at the Asian Games. Did you give her any words of advice?

What really helped me was staying hungry. Of course, she is the Asian Games champion, which is awesome. I went to the Olympics first at 17 and won a World championship silver medal at that age too. But it was just the start. I hope it's the same for Kumkum. Yes, you have this great accomplishment, but you stay hungry for the future, and you think, "Okay, I've done this first thing. But what's next?"

Your parents ran an archery shop. What was the sport like for you as a kid growing up in that environment?

The first time I ever shot, I was three years old and shooting with my brother, who's older than me. But we would just shoot arrows into the grass, just to shoot an arrow. It wasn't even to try to hit a target or be good at it, it was just pure fun. That environment built a love for archery before it got competitive.

I am naturally competitive, but that enjoyment aspect has always stayed with me, and I think that's led me to a lot of success.

What other sports did you play?

I also did gymnastics competitively for a long time, with some state and regional tournaments and loved it. For a long time, it was more prevalent in my life than archery. But I got a career-ending injury around the age of 11 and stepped away a year later. Everything happens for a reason. Leaving gymnastics gave me a lot more time to put into archery, and that's when I really started to excel.

What elements of gymnastics and archery are transferable?

If a parent asks me what sport my child should do besides archery to become a good archer, I tell them gymnastics or strength training.

When I was young, if you didn't give your best effort, my gymnastics coaches would make us run three laps around the building. If you didn't finish your drills optimally, you had to do 10 more pull-ups than everybody else. That mindset really helped me in archery. My parents disciplined me a lot, sure, but to have a coach figure at a young age who was also firm on discipline helped me hard on myself but in a good way for archery.

Secondly, in gymnastics, you're flipping through the air and have to twist and know how to land, and the biggest thing in doing that is to not get injured, right? The body awareness and balance that I needed helped me eventually understand how expansion works, how string alignment works, and things like that that a kid at maybe eight or nine might not understand in archery.

You won your first international event at the age of 14. How do you look back on that eight years later?

Never did 14-year-old Casey expect to win her first international tournament! That said, going into something with no expectation like you do at a young age is very powerful. It was a whole new world and I was looking to learn. To step away with a win was great. I remember being almost impressed with myself and thinking, if I could do that on the first try, I could do so much more with some experience behind me.

How did 14-year-old Casey celebrate that win and how differently did you ring in the Olympic medal?

Well, 14-year-old Casey was actually given a bottle of champagne at the time for winning the tournament - an indoor World Series - which I saved until I was 21. When 20-year-old Casey won her first Olympic medal, I remember just feeling massive relief. You train so hard and you have this opportunity that only comes every four years, and you have to make the most of it.

Being in competitive sports at a young age often means sacrificing a lot of one's childhood. What was that like for you?

I don't know if I would use the word sacrifice as much as I just made choices. Achieving your dreams comes with sacrifices no matter what, and you commit to that when you commit to the dream.

I had a World Cup that was over my high school prom, and I chose the World Cup. There were definitely some things that normal high school kids would do that I chose archery over and quite happily too. It might sound selfish, but every decision has been for the betterment of my dream and my career. Sometimes friends might be upset but, at the end of the day, I need to do what's best for me and for my goals and aspirations. Not everyone may understand and I am okay with that.

You went to the Tokyo Olympics as a 17-year-old and didn't win. What did that opportunity teach you?

I understood that it was the first of many Olympics so I wanted to go, remember as much as I could and write notes. I hadn't done anything until then to the calibre of an Olympic medal, so a part of me knew I needed to fail to learn how to win. That really helped me prepare for Paris. They also weren't too far apart.

In an interview before heading to the Paris Games, you said your impact on the sport matters more than the medals you win. That's quite profound for a 21-year-old...

Starting as young as I did at the pro level, my brain is far beyond its years. A lot of times I don't think of myself as being in my early 20s.

On the one hand, I do say the choices I make are selfish because it's what's best for me and my career. But in doing those things, I also want to give back and inspire people. It's why I make a lot of social media videos too. If those can pop up on someone's page who hasn't seen archery before, it might inspire them to pick up a bow or take a lesson for the first time. Archery is too great not to know.

Being this competitive can also be quite intense. How do you switch off from the sport?

I love to sew. I love fashion, and I have made dresses. I made my prom dress that I never got to wear to prom, but I love anything creative. I also love hiking, fishing, kayaking, tennis and anything outdoors.
I haven't had time in the last season. I've moved a few times,
so I haven't been sewing as much, but last July I had a friend that got married and she approached me after she got engaged to make her a dress. That's such an honour. She said it exceeded the expectations of what she pictured.

How does completing such a sentimental project for a friend compare to winning an Olympic medal?

Quite similar, emotionally. It took me over a year to make the dress. She's my friend and watching her walk down the aisle made me cry. The time and effort it took is a lot like training for a big competition. Both things make my heart full!

